A TEXTBOOK OF HISTORIOGRAPHY

500 BC to AD 2000

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I. INDOLOGY AND THE RECOVERY OF INDIAN HISTORY

1. Paucity of Historical Literature on Ancient India

The earliest and one of the positive results of the British conquest and unification of India – one which kept pace with that process itself – was the recovery of ancient Indian history on modern lines of historiography. Thanks to the medieval Indo-Muslim historians, the history of the seven or eight hundred years prior to the British advent had been duly written and preserved. For this reason the English came to have a fair knowledge of medieval India. But the typical Hindu view of life had kept history encompassing the mundane experience of human beings outside the pale of useful knowledge, and there were no genuine historical records on ancient India that the men of the East India Company could rely upon. The Hindu, as the British found him, had a vague consciousness of the antiquity of his country s culture which, indeed, he was prone to exaggerate, but it was far from a genuine historical consciousness as we understand the term. An Indian of Warren Hastings time receiving a traditional education, whether Hindu or Muslim, could not have had any idea of the two thousand years of his country's history before the Turkish conquest (AD 1200). How ridiculous an idea of their ancient history that even educated Hindus entertained would be evident from the following example cited by R.C. Majumdar. When the Fort William College was founded in 1800 for giving instruction on India to the officers of the East India Company, a teacher of the college and chief pundit of the Supreme Court named Mrtyunjay Sharma, prepared a historical text in Bengali which was published in 1808. Leaving aside the legendary kings who lived in the *Satya*, *Treta* and *Dvapara yugas* for more than eight lakh years, it referred to the royal dynasties during the four thousand nine hundred and five years which had elapsed since the beginning of the *Kali* age. One hundred and nineteen kings sat on the throne of Delhi during the first four thousand two hundred and sixty-seven years. Except for Yudhishtira and Mahanandi referred to in the *puranas,* the numerous kings that are mentioned in the above text are unknown, with no references to them found in any other work.[1]

It is with Robert Orme's two works that British historiography on India begins. The two works are *A History of the Military Transactions of the British Nation in Indostan from the year 1745* published in 1764, and *Historical Fragments of the Mughal Empire, of the Marathas and of the English Concerns in Indostan from M.Dc. LIX*. Orme was historiographer to the Company from 1769 till his death in 1801. From his study of the Indo-Muslim chronicles of the medieval age, Orme also wrote a fair, though brief outline of the Muslim ruling dynasties in India from the invasion of Muhammad ibn Kasim in AD 712. Francis Gladwin's *History of Hindustan* (1783) covered the reigns of Jahangir, Shah Jahan and Aurangazeb. The second of Orme's works named above contained a brief account of ancient India prefaced with the remark: "The Indians have lost all memory of the ages in which they began to believe in Vishnu, Isvara, Brahma and a thousand deities subordinate to these....The history of these gods is a heap of the greatest absurdities."[2] William Robertson's *Historical Disquisition Concerning the Knowledge which the Ancients had of India* (1792), was an attempt to gather such information on ancient India as preserved in the works of Greek and Roman classical authors from Herodotus and Megasthenes to Pliny and Arrian. Except for such information and merchants' greedy references to 'the wealth of the Indies', as Well as Marco Polo's picture of her western fringe, ancient India remained *terra incognita* to the West, a land of marvel and mystery. Here a major thrust of recovery had to be made.

2. The Orientalist or Indological Recovery of Ancient Indian History

It was to this task of reconstructing the lost history of India that the Orientalists or the Indologists addressed themselves. In the absence of genuine historical texts, the work of reconstruction had to rely almost entirely on information obtainable from literature and different kinds of archeological finds like inscriptions, coins, monuments and sculpture.

Influences behind the Indological Quest

Modern Indian historiography began with the writings of the scholar-administrators of the English East India Company. What were the influences behind these men? David Kopf has shown with deep insight that the Company's servants, the more elite among them, came from the intellectual-cultural milieu of the eighteenth century European Enlightenment, a fact which goes far to explain 'the phenomenal Orientalist rediscovery of the Hindu classical age'. Men like William Jones and Henry Colebrooke were as much products of the eighteenth century world of ideas as Voltaire and Gibbon. The Orientalists fully subscribed to the Enlightenment view that differences among large aggregates of human beings as, for example, between Europeans and Asians, are not to be explained by their nature which is constant and universal, but by their custom and culture which bear diverse fruits. Such a

position tended toward unity of all human history. This historical and cultural relativism bore fruit not only in a sweet tolerance and a high intellectual regard for non-European peoples, but in a positive appreciation of their histories and cultures. Indeed, Volatire believed that there must have been a widespread civilization in Mesopotamia in times of old, and he had written that India and China had invented nearly all the arts before Europe possessed them.

The impact of the eighteenth century European Enlightenment was combined with the fertilizing influence of European Romanticism which invested non-European civilizations like the Egyptian, Chinese, Indian, Persian and Arabic with an aura of sanctity and positive value. The Romantic love of the mysterious and the unknown had contributed to a new interest not only in distant races, societies and civilizations, but in distant historical epochs. The Orientalist interest in ancient India needs no further explanation.

Moreover, the establishment of British rule in India was roughly coincidental with the development in Europe of a strictly scientific spirit in historical reconstruction. A highly critical attitude in the treatment of the sources had come in the wake of the Scientific Revolution of the seventeenth century, a revolution which had brought about the Enlightenment attitude itself.

Early Indological Efforts

Indology may be defined as the scientific study of data relating to Indian history and culture, a study in which little emphasis is laid on the political aspect. The missionaries - particularly the Jesuits - had begun the Indological quest long before the British efforts in that direction. But the missionary scholars, for all their studies, made no real attempt to know the historical background of the culture of the people among whom they worked, for in them, the religious motive had a preponderance over the historical.

There was already in Bengal, even before William Jones's arrival there, a group of young officers who had been charmed into Indological studies. These early British Orientalists produced works of great interest. One of them, Francis Gladwin, had published the *Institutes of the Emperor Akbar*, an abridged form of Abul Fazal's famous *Ain-i-Akbari.* In 1776, Nathaniel Halhead, at the age of twenty-three, produced the famed *Gentoo Laws* which, two years later, was followed by *A Grammar of the Bengal Languages.* Charles Wilkins who came to India in 1770 had been fascinated by Sanskrit which he mastered, and for that reason, had commended himself to the special favor of Warren Hastings. Jonathan Duncan who served in India from 1772 to 1811, was as avid a scholar as he was an able administrator. True to the Hastings tradition, Duncan consistently encouraged the revitalization of Hindu learning and philosophy.

Apart from personal love and devotion there were two circumstances to which the recovery of India's forgotten past owed its impulse. The first was that the Company officials needed to know the language and culture of the people committed to their charge. Linguistic proficiency was the key to advancement in the Company's service. Second, the young Indologists got a patron in the governor-general himself. Warren Hastings mastered the Persian language, collected Indian paintings and manuscripts, drew inspiration from the *Bhagavad Gita*, and quoted it in his letters to his wife. He encouraged the Indologists, fought for them in the Supreme Council, and held long discussions with them on their subjects.

William Jones (1746—1794)

Yet the greatest figure in the Orientalist movement was Sir William Jones. Jones's widowed mother, Mary Nix, brought up her son in an intellectual atmosphere and the child Jones grew into a prodigy. In his seventeenth year, Jones went to Oxford. Already he had learnt Hebrew, Greek and Latin, and now at Oxford he learnt Arabic from a Syrian by name Mirza whom he maintained from his own stipend. Arabic drew him to Persian. By 1768, Jones had become well known as an Orientalist. Meanwhile he studied law and, in 1783, was appointed a judge of the Supreme Court at Calcutta.

Asiatic Society of Bengal

In January 1784, supported by Warren Hastings, Jones founded the Asiatic society of Bengal. The birth of the Asiatic Society was an event of momentous importance. Jones extended to Indology the methods of organized scientific research then spreading in Europe. The Society's unremitting labor bore its first fruits in important translations from Sanskrit literature. In 1784, Wilkins's *Bhagavad Gita*, the first direct translation of a Sanskrit work into English, was completed. In 1787 Wilkins presented his translation of the *Hitopadesa.* Jones himself was studying Sanskrit under Pundit Ramlochan with a devotion which has few parallels. His very first performance in the art of translation, that of *Shakuntala* (1789), was of epochal importance. It immediately caught the imagination of literate Europe and five editions followed in twenty years to cater to the new appetite. The avid scholar quickly followed it up by the translation of the *Gita Govinda.* Jones's translation of *Manusmrti* was published posthumously

under the title *The Institutes of Hindu Law*.

Great Discoveries

Indo-European Languages

It was not, however, his translations, but the way he drew the attention of the world in the direction of India's ancient history that made Sir William Jones a seminal figure in the Orientalist movement. Of the eleven annual discourses that Jones delivered before the Asiatic Society, eight were on history and one on science. In the discourse for 1786, Jones announced the first of his outstanding achievements in Indian history, namely, the discovery of the common origin of what came to be known as the Indo-European family of languages. In the discourse, Jones first propounded a theory that India's golden period as a culture lay in a remote, uncharted period of world history, and then he startled the world of scholarship by announcing that Sanskrit was cousin to Old Persian, Greek, Latin and the modern languages of Europe. The theory depended for its validity on the striking affinity that existed between the words of, say, Old Persian, Sanskrit, Greek, Latin, German and English. Some examples:

Old Persian	Sanskrit	Greek	Latin	German	English
pitar	*pitar*	*pater*	*pater*	*vater*	father
matar	*matar*	*meter*	*mater*	*mutter*	mother
bratar	*bhratar*	*phrater*	*frater*	*bruder*	brother
nama	*nama*	*onoma*	*nomen*	*nahme*	name
cta	*stha*	*istemi*	*sto*	*stehen*	stand

[*] The examples given are not necessarily those cited by William Jones.

D.D. Kosambi shows how the English word *daughter*, German *tochter*, Greek *thygater*, Irish *dear*, Lithuanian *dukte* and Russian *doch* are of common derivation with the Sanskrit *duhitr*.[3] Such correlations are numerous and could not have been accidental. They indicated a common origin. Jones postulated that Sanskrit, Old Persian and most of the European languages must have originated from one mother language which does not exist now.

Aryan Race

From the theory of a common linguistic origin for what came to be called the 'Indo-European family' of languages, Jones made an audacious advance to the theory of a common race. The speakers of the ancient common mother language from which Old Persian, Sanskrit, Greek, Latin and the modern languages of Europe evolved must have belonged to a common nucleus race known to us as Aryan (Wiros, Indo-Europeans). Jones's discovery made the people of northern India kinsmen to the Persians and the Europeans, and Central Asia the cradle of the Indo-European Aryans.

Chandragupta

Equally momentous was the breakthrough in ancient Indian history which Jones effected through a process of synchronism and identification. In the history of Alexander's invasion of India, the classical sources mention an Indian prince called Sandrocottas who ruled the land of Prasii, and whose capital was Palibothra. In his tenth annual address on 28 February 1793, Jones referred to the importance of mythology, tales and even dramas as containing facts of history such as the murder of Nanda and the usurpation by Chandragupta. He then provided a third fact of pivotal importance to the recovery of ancient Indian history. This was the accession of Chandragupta Maurya to the throne of Pataliputra. The identification of the Greek Palibothra with the Indian Pataliputra led to the concomitant discovery of greater moment: Chandragupta Maurya who had the seat of his empire at Pataliputra was none other than the Greek Sandrocottas who ruled from Palibothra and conducted a treaty with Seleukos Nikator. No synchronism and identification has added more chapters to the history of an ancient people. Besides bringing to light the first great empire in Indian history, it supplied for the first time a firm historical date, 325 BC, from which reckoning backward and forward, other dates and periods could be fixed. Simple though it may seem, the synchronism of Chandragupta Maurya with Seleukos Nikator has truly been called 'the sheet anchor of Indian

history'.

3. The Development of Indological Studies

After William Jones, Indological studies developed mainly along two lines. The first was the critical study of ancient Indian texts and documents, and the second, archeological discovery and study of old inscriptions, coins and monuments.

Study of Ancient Texts and Documents: Colebrooke and Max Muller

The Asiatic Society became a centre for organized research and hundreds of articles on Indian antiquities were published in its journal. Systematic attempts were made to search for old manuscripts, and translations and critical editions of important texts on Indian history and culture were published in the *Bibliotheca Indica* series.

The Indologist who in importance was second only to William Jones was one who had spoken disparagingly of the Sanskrit-mad Orientalists and their early publications as 'a repository of nonsense'. Henry T. Colebrooke, a mathematician, came to India at the age of eighteen, became himself Sanskrit-mad, and studied the language at Benares. By 1794, Colebrooke s work became so widely recognized that he was chosen as logical successor to Jones.

Colebrooke tackled the grammatical treatises, commentaries, philosophic systems, and above all, the immense literature of the Vedic period. Fascinated with the rediscovery of a Hindu age of splendor, he concentrated his research upon Vedic India. In 1800 Governor-General Wellesley appointed him professor of Sanskrit at the Fort William College. It was then that Colebrooke wrote the famous *Essay on the Vedas or the Sacred Writings of the Hindus* (1803). By the end of his career, Colebrooke had devised a new composite image of the whole Indo-Aryan period as a golden age, an age in which there was no *sati*, no caste, no idolatry, and no polytheism. Instead of being introspective and otherworldly, Colebrooke pictured the early Indians as an outgoing, non- mystical, robust, beef-eating, life-loving, socially egalitarian society. Instead of Oriental despotism, one saw tribal republics. Yet, Colebrooke seems to have failed to realize the importance of the *vedas* for he thought that their study "would hardly reward the labour of the reader much less that of the translator."[4]

About the same time when Colebrooke revealed the oldest product of Indian literature, the *Rig Veda*, to the world, Anquetil Duperron, a French scholar travelling in India, translated (1801–02) Dara Shukoh's Persian translation of the *Upanishads* which acquainted Schelling and Schopenhauer with that product of Hindu philosophy. Eugene Burnouf, the French Orientalist, traced the connection between the languages of the *Rig Veda* and the *Zend Avesta* (the Zoroastrian sacred scripture written in Old Persian). The three German scholars Bopp, Grimm and Humboldt established the intimate relationship among all Aryan languages, the most primitive form of which was shown to be preserved in the language of the *Rig Veda.*

Max Muller (1823-1900), a German Orientalist and language scholar settled at Oxford, acquired a mastery over Sanskrit without the help of a teacher. He then turned to comparative language studies which involved him in the study of the *Zend Avesta.* The *Zend Avesta* led him to the study of comparative religion and to the editing of the whole text of the *Rig Veda* (1845-79) with the commentary of Sayana. His *History of Sanskrit Literature* (1859) mapped out in chronological order all the Sanskrit texts known till then. His interest in mythology on which he wrote appealing essays led him further into the study of comparative religion and to the publication of *The Sacred Books of the* (1879-1904). A monumental achievement, this collaborative enterprise made available in English, translations of 50 major Oriental non-Christian scriptures.

Eugene Burnoufs *Essaisur le Pali* (1826), i.e., the language of the Buddhist documents, made Buddhism known to the West for the first time as a system of thought. Buddhist and Jain texts came to be treated by Fausbol and Jacobi in the same manner as the Brahmanical texts. Oldenburg's treatise on Buddhism held the field for many years. Rhys Davids was to devote an entire life to the exposition of the literature of Buddhism, and the Pali Text Society was to learn from the examples of the *Sacred Books of the East.*

Discovery and Study of Old Inscriptions, Monuments and Coins: Prinsep and Cunningham

The rediscovery of India's forgotten past could not safely rely on literature alone, for much of that past, as in the case of Egypt, Crete or Troy, lay in epigraphic, archeological or numismatic materials. The Orientalists came from a Europe that had started digging up history or reading it on stones and tablets. With each digging, each reading, the frontiers of man's knowledge of his own development was being pushed further and further. There cannot be anydiing finer in civilization than this noble curiosity, this restless passion, to discover the development of human life from rude stone-age flints to whole civilizations. The French Champollion, in 1822, had deciphered the Hieroglyphics, read the Rosetta Stone, and begun Egyptology; the English Rawlinson would decipher the Cuneiform in 1851; the German Schlieman and the English Arthur Evans would eventually dig up Troy and Minoa

respectively. And typical
of the scientific and historical temperament of the nineteenth century was the devotion with which James Prinsep applied himself to the decipherment of Brahmi and Alexander Cunningham to the excavation of Indian archeological sites.

James Prinsep (1799–1840)

The most basic requirement in epigraphic studies, in the decipherment of alphabets, is linguistic proficiency, which fortunately was a particular hallmark of the Orientalists. In 1781, Charles Wilkins had made a beginning in the use of inscriptions to reconstruct the history of the Palas of Bengal. In 1785, he deciphered the Gupta Brahmi characters of some Gaya inscriptions thereby revealing the history of the Maukharis who ruled Gaya in the first half of the sixth century AD. But what puzzled the scholars most were the Asokan inscriptions written in Old Brahmi. Speculations on these inscriptions had continued for nearly fifty years until the Asokan Brahmi found its Champollion in James Prinsep. Prinsep's short life was a saga of devoted scholarship. He was assay-master at the Calcutta Mint, but became the presiding genius of the early period of Indian archaeology. His wide scientific curiosity was driven forward by a burning, irrepressible enthusiasm. Prinsep collected a large number of facsimiles of Old Brahmi characters, yet unread, from inscriptions on rocks, pillars and railings of *stupas*. For seven years, it was his habit, every morning after breakfast, to spread these fascimiles on a table and to gaze at them with undivided attention and undying curiosity—always haunted by the fear that some German scholars would forestall him in deciphering them.[5] Prinsep's labors bore fruit in 1834 when the Old Brahmi alphabet of the Asokan inscriptions yielded its mystery to the key that had suddenly dawned upon him. The achievement parallels in importance to Champollion's reading of the Hieroglyphics and Rawlinson's deciphering of the Cuneiform. A vast, hitherto uncharted realm was added to Indian history. Not only did the legendary forgotten Buddhist emperor become the historical Asoka, but the history of Buddhism in India, lying untapped in the Pali literature, was thrown open to historical investigation. The pattern of research which Prinsep created by his example may be seen in his *Indian Antiquities* (1858), a posthumous edition of his historical, paleographic and numismatic essays.

Alexander Cunningham (1814-1893)

The great pioneer's mantle fell upon the shoulders of Alexander Cunningham, rightly remembered as the creator of the Indian Archaeological Survey. Cunningham had joined the engineering wing of the Bengal Army (1833). A meeting with Prinsep was enough for this young Englishman of nineteen years to be charmed into Indology. In 1837, Cunningham began excavations at Saranath where the Buddha had delivered his first sermon, and where Buddhism as a world historical force had begun to take form. The young archeologist carefully prepared the drawings of the sculptures found in Saranath. In 1850, he excavated Sanchi, site of some of the oldest surviving buildings of ancient India. From 1870 to 1885 Cunningham carried out archeological excavations among many ruins including those at Taxila. Over the years Cunningham had made a large collection of Indian coins, the choicest of which were purchased by the British Museum. In 1870 he was made the director of the Archaeological Department. In 1901, the department received a real boost owing to the interest taken by Lord Curzon.

F.R. Allchin writes that it is not so much the department which deserves notice as Cunningham's own ideas on the scope of Indian archeology. Cunningham contrasts the "closet or scholastic archaeologists" of the old days with what Prinsep called the "field archaeologists or travelling antiquarians" who had appeared.[6] His instructions to his assistants written in 1873 give us a comprehensive account of the scope of archeology.

> Archaeology is not limited to broken sculptures, old buildings and mounds, but includes everything that belonged to the world's history....Architectural remains naturally form the most prominent branch of archaeology.. ..But our researches should be extended to all ancient remains whatever that will help to illustrate the manners and customs of former times.[7]

Cunningham goes on to say that his workers should record evidence not only of sites and ruins, and gather together coins, sculptures or inscriptions, but they should also record finds of stone implements and of dolmens, cromlechs or barrows. They should study the many ancient forms of objects which are still in use today, and they should not be above observing the sort of plough in use, the other implements of agriculture, the types of houses and systems of irrigation, etc. To Cunningham, each such new fact was one of the "fossil fragments of the great skeleton of lost Indian history."[8] Yet, he was not interested in settlement sites.

The founder of Indian archeology also wrote several works on the subject. They include the first volume of the *Corpus Inscriptionum Indicarum*, *Inscriptions of Asoka*, *Coins of India*, *Book of Indian Eras*, *Ancient Geography of India*, *Bhilsa Topes*, *Stupa of Barhut*, and a work on Ladakh. Cunningham's extensive tours also produced the valuable Archaeological Survey Reports in one of which a typical seal from Harappa was published for the first time. Such was the spirit that had been breathed into archeological work that Mackenzie, an avid collector, collected more than 8000 inscriptions from southern India alone. Indian archeology would eventually stride towards its

greatest triumph at Mohenjodaro and Harappa where the remains of a highly developed urban life, five thousand years old, would rudely upset the belief that civilization in India began with the Vedic Aryans migrating from the region around the Caspian.

4. The Significance of Orientalist Recovery of Ancient Indian History

Impact on Indian Historiography

It was with the Indological quest that modern methods of historical research and reconstruction – then spreading in Europe – were introduced into India. The Asiatic Society of Bengal which William Jones had consciously modeled on the Royal Society in London ushered in the age of scientific and specialized study in Indian history and culture. More particularly, Jones's revelation of the kinship between the Indo-European languages and peoples almost created the modern sciences of comparative philology, comparative mythology and ethnology; he had demonstrated the importance of linquistic studies in historical inquiry; his identification of 'Sandrocottas' with Chandragupta Maurya and of 'Palibothra' with Pataliputra opened the field for the scientific study of ancient Indian history; and synchronizing the first Mauryan king with Seleukos Nikator he provided the key to resolve many a chronological puzzle that history presented. Prinsep's seminal success with the riddle of Old Brahmi not only solved the problem of the Asokan edicts but set the grand example of epigraphic revelations of Indian history; in the course of the nineteenth century three-fourths of ancient and medieval Indian history would be read from inscriptions. Indian archeology and numismatics, taking shape with the indefatigable Cunningham, were to make history in the years to come. Burnouf's *Essai sur le Pali* opened up another untapped fount of Indian religion and thought – the Buddhist – and roused his great pupil Max Muller to make possible the translation of all the sacred books of the East into English; and Rhys Davids to devote his whole life to the exposition of Buddhist literature. By the end of the nineteenth century, ancient India – that *terra incognita* to the academic world – had been historically charted and mapped.

Revelation of India to the World

The Indologist findings should be reckoned as one of the major breakthroughs effected in the history of knowledge. A.A. MacDonnell writes: "Since the Renaissance there has been no event of such worldwide significance in the history of culture as the discovery of Sanskrit literature in the latter part of the eighteenth century."[9] By a supreme irony of history, even as India was helplessly passing under British rule, the British Orientalists were holding up before the world an image of the Indians as one of the creative peoples of the world with an impressive continuity of development and civilization for more than three thousand years. The literate West often compared the Orientalists with the Italian humanists and praised them in the press for their gift of a new Renaissance in the East. William Jones was accorded the greatest honor of all, as the one who had restored India to its rightful place among the civilizations of the world. His English translation of Kalidasa's *Shakuntala* rendered into German in 1791, profoundly affected Herder and Goethe, and through the Schlegels, the entire Romantic movement. Colebrooke's *Essay on the Vedas* revealed to Europe the oldest known literary product of the 'Aryan' mind; and Anquetil Duperron's translation of a Persian translation of the *Upanishads* acquainted Schelling and Schopenhauer with what the latter called the profoundest philosophy he had ever read. In fact, the *Upanishads* sent Schopenhauer into a philosophic ecstasy as the *Shakuntala* sent Goethe into a poetic one. It was no mean spiritual triumph for a people so physically crushed, and the Orientalists had made it possible.

Seamy Side of Orientalism

The work of the Orientalists had its seamy side which should not be ignored. A cloud of doubt came to be cast on William Jones's notion of the language-race nexus and the theory of the Aryan race has now been generally discarded. The theory however, came to have a somewhat harmful influence on future thought. The belief in the superiority of the White Aryan race became a basic assumption of European imperialism everywhere, and the British imperialist historians of India would duly employ it as the *raison d' etre* of British rule in India.

But the Aryan race theory had a more insidious influence on the writing of Indian history. It came to mean that a superior conquering race of Aryans speaking an Indo-European tongue came invading India through the northwestern passes in the second millennium BC, conquered the indigenous population of mostly Dravidian and Austric origin, inferior in race and culture. The Aryan invasion supposedly effected a racial segregation of the groups through the mechanism of caste and established the superior Vedic Aryan culture which became the foundation of Indian civilization. The interpretation not only contained an explanation of 'upper'-caste superiority,[10] but also the suggestion of an Aryan-Dravidian racial divide. Future revelations and research would cast many of these assertions into the realm of motivated fancy. Again, the race theory in the hands of the European scholar, particularly of the British imperialist historian, also came to mean that everything of value in Indian life and culture,

at least above reproach in European eyes, was of European origin. The habit of looking for foreign origins for things of value in a people's life is unhistorical.

Great as were the Orientalist revelations, much of it was fanciful too; and this latter aspect misled some modern Indian historians. The Orientalists, particularly William Jones, had, in the enthusiasm of discovery, romanticized and exaggerated the value of the new revelations, not always warranted by the sources. Jones had found the Sanskrit language "more perfect than the Greek, more copious than the Latin, and more exquisitely refined than either...."[11] He labored to show that the Indian division of the Zodiac was not borrowed from the Greeks or Arabs; he supported the story that Plato and Pythagoras borrowed their philosophical ideas from India and concluded that the six Hindu philosophical schools comprised all the metaphysics of the old Platonic Academy; he endeavored to prove that India had excelled in arithmetic, geometry and logic; he thought that it is possible that Aristotle based his system of logic on Brahmanic syllogisms; and took pains to show that the fertile genius of the Hindus invented the decimal scale, the science of grammar and the game of chess. The rhapsody ended in what was to be his last discourse to the Asiatic Society, which claimed that the whole of the Newtonian theory and part of the Newtonian philosophy may be found in the *Vedas* and even in the works of the Sufis.[12] Such claims were a soothing balm to a wounded, decaying civilization, and nothing could have been more flattering to a conquered, subject people. But the claims bred chauvinism. When, at the turn of the nineteenth century and beginning of the twentieth, nationalist historiography grew , in reaction to British imperialist historiography on India, some of the nationalist historians – in their enthusiasm to whip up national feeling by extolling national achievements and virtues – found a ready quiver in Orientalist assertions, and read into the sources things that were not there.

II. BRITISH IMPERIALIST (COLONIAL) HISTORIOGRAPHY ON INDIA

l. James Mill: The History of British India

Ideological Basis

The first important history of India came not from the Orientalists but from their great opponent James Mill, an official of the East India Company in London. To understand the nature and characier of British imperialist historical writing on India, it is necess ary Eo acquaint ourselves with the major assumpdons, attirudes and purposes of the writers, and the dominant schools of thought to which they belonged. After the batde of Plassey the major question confronting the merchant-conquerors was the method of
governance of the newly won empire. During the first phase of . empire – in the pre-Mutiny period – three schools of thought competed to control British attitude and policy towards India.

The first of these schools was that of men like Governor-General Warren Hastings and the Orientalists like Wilkins, Jones and Colebrooke who formed a high opinion of early Hindu civilization. They thought that changes in Indian life should be brought about slowly and only with deference to the old institutions of the natives. This view came to be maintained later by Elphinstone, Munroe, Malcolm and H.H. Wilson.

But sympathy for the Indians and their ancient institutions came to be challenged by new ideas and new schools of thought. The eighteenth century was the age of reason, of Enlightenment. Late in that century, the belief that the West had discovered the secret of progress through the employment of reason put India in the category of static or semi-barbaric cultures. Based on this conviction two views were formed as to how Indian society was to be redeemed and reclaimed for civilization. John Shore, who was governor- general after Lord Cornwallis, and Charles Grant, his friend, represented that evangelical viewpoint expressed in the latter's *Observations on the State of Society among the Asiatic Subjects of Great Britain.* Grant urged in the *Observations*, the application of Christianity and Western education to change what he thought was a "hideous state of Indian society."[13] Shore and Grant were actively backed by the missionaries who similarly castigated Indian society and suggested similar remedies. To the much advertized Indian depravity and vice, the evangelical and the missionary found ready remedy in scheme of English education preceded or followed by a general conversion to Christianity. Ironically, they found a ready ally in the rationalist-utilitarian who arrived at the same conclusion by a different route. Benthamite utilitarian philosophy held that the test of anything – any institution whether political, religious or social – is its utility. A thing is valuable if it is useful, if it can perform a useful function. Things that are not useful or institutions that are not conducive to general human welfare are to be reformed or discarded. Reform could be effected through universal education and governmental legislation. The utilitarians believed with evangelical zeal in the efficacy of laws, and of reform on utilitarian lines to remake whole societies and civilizations. To James Mill, Bentham's disciple and the leading utilitarian, Indian culture was static and degraded and the only hope of transforming it lay in an infusion of Western ideas and knowledge to be achieved by proper laws administered by a despotic government. This was the ideological basis of Mill's *History.*

Mill's History

Mill's predominant motive in writing the *History* was his desire to apply the utilitarian doctrine to the governance of India. He saw in the new Indian Empire a fertile field for utilitarian reform toward which arguments were to be supplied by the decadent state of life and culture in India. For this purpose he deliberately attempted an evaluation of the Hindu and Muslim government and civilization in India (the second and the third of the six books of the *History*), and the evaluation was a sweeping condemnation of both. Begun in 1806 when the author was thirty-three, the *History* was published in 1818. It made a great impression. The Court of Directors of the East India Company appointed Mill to a senior post on their London staff. Ricardo praised Mill's work to the skies; Macaulay spoke of it in the House of Commons as "the greatest historical work which has appeared in our language since that of Gibbon."[14] His *Minute on Indian Education* bore its mark. Mill's son, John Stuart Mill, described it as one of the most instructive histories ever written. H.H. Wilson, the leading Orientalist and the severest critic of the *History*, nevertheless judged it as still "the most valuable work upon the subject which had yet been published."[15] The encomiums of Mill's work showed, more than its quality, the British attitude towards the Indians. The radical alteration of Indian society on utilitarian lines recommended by Mill seemed to suit the aims and needs of British imperialism.

Sources and Method

Since Mill had reached his conclusions even before he started work on his *History*, all that he needed was some kind of evidence. Employed in the offices of the East India Company in Leaden Hall Street, London, he had access to every bit of paper from India. Unfortunately he felt no need to benefit by the advances made by the Orientalists in ancient Indian histoiy. He had only contempt for William Jones and the other Orientalists who had learnt the Indian languages and drawn up their accounts from primary sources. Dismissing the Orientalists and their testimony, Mill depended on travelers' reports to point out the vast difference between the professions and practice of the Hindus.

> In the same breath that they extol the wonderful strength of filial piety they speak of the common practice of exposing the infants; a strict morality and ceremonious conduct are followed by a list of the most gross debaucheries.[16]

In his indictment of the Hindus, Mill contravened all rules of historical methodology. Ignorance, prejudice, the quality of the sources and the manner of their treatment combined to give to his *History* its peculiar tone and color. If he felt that the Orientalist account of the Hindus was exaggerated, he should have applied to it a process of criticism to reveal the concealed truth instead of completely dismissing it. For evidence in his indictment Mill relied on Robert Orme's account which was partial; on Buchanan who had tried and failed to learn Sanskrit and was prejudiced against the Indians; on Tennant, a most superficial observer; and on Tytler who had known Indian society only through the criminal law courts. Committed to the view that Hindu society was barbarous, Mill was highly selective in the use of evidence. He cited testimony when it was hostile to the Hindus, such as that of Abbe Dubois, the missionary, of Tytler and other men, but ignored favorable testimony. The massive evidence on the character of the Indians, collected in the parliamentary investigation of 1813, on the whole favorable to the Hindus, went unnoticed. C.H. Philips writes:

> ...he commonly attached the greatest weight to the writers who are least entitled to confidence. In this manner he constructed a damning indictment of Indian society and then went on to prescribe a revolutionary cure to be achieved through the application of government and law on utilitarian principles.[17]

Condemnation of the Hindus

Mill sought "to ascertain the true state of the Hindus in the scale of civilization...."[18] by applying to their life and culture the test of utility. The test turned Book Two of the *History* – filling five hundred pages – into a series of moral judgements. The judgements deal with the ancient history and chronology, classification of society, form of government, laws, revenue system, religion, manners, arts and literature of the Hindus. The worth of the book may be assessed from some samples of the conclusions reached by the author. Mill asserts that the laws and institutions of the Hindus could not have begun or existed "under any other than one of the rudest and weakest states of the human mind."[19] The author speciously argued that if the Hindus had ever been in a high state of civilization, "we know of no such period of calamity, as was sufficient to reduce them to a state of ignorance and barbarity."[20] He declares that "the people of Europe, even during the feudal ages, were greatly superior to the Hindus."[21] "In truth, writes Mill, the Hindu, like the Eunuch, excels in the qualities of a slave."[22] The condemnation of the Hindu is concluded with a sweeping statement that "human nature in India gained, and gained considerably, by passing from a Hindu to a Muhammadan government."[23] Muslim rule was better than the Hindu, and British rule, though not to be praised in unqualified terms, was better than either.

Influence of Mill's History

The tremendous influence Mill s *History* had on British policy towards India could be seen in the number of times it went to press—1818, 1820, 1826, 1840. In 1848, H.H. Wilson, the leading Orientalist of the day, produced an edition of Mill with elaborate footnotes, and an extension of the story from 1805 to 1834. The persisting influence of the book can be easily explained. It provided, as C.H. Philips observes, the main basis for British thought on the character of Indian civilization and on the way to govern India. Mill's *History* was established as a textbook at Haileybury College from 1805 to 1855, where the Company's civil service recruits were trained, and where a succession of eminent utilitarians or close sympathizers held senior teaching posts. Here, at Haileybury, Mill's catechism worked. His *History* had provided the *raison d'etre* of British rule in India and, trained along lines suggested by the book, the British administrators who came out to India began to entertain illusions of the permanence of that rule. British Indian administration moved into a phase of imperial dogmatism, and complacency of its achievements in India.

Criticism

Mills' *History* had its greatest critic in H.H. Wilson. Referring to the superiority of the Muslims in comparison to the Hindus, so confidently asserted by Mill as a fact, Wilson contended that it was no fact at all. The comparison involved a total disregard of *time and circumstance.* Because, asks Wilson, the British have left the Hindus behind in the march of progress, would one assert that the Britons in the days of Caesar were more civilized than the Hindus of that period?[24]

Wilson then pointed his finger to the evil influence Mill's *History* had on Englishmen. It was destroying all sympathy between the ruler and the ruled, monopolizing all posts of honor and power in India, and producing an unfounded aversion for the Indians. The harsh, illiberal spirit and heavy-handedness of the British Indian administrators originated from the impressions imbibed in early life from the history of Mill. The Mutiny could not have been far in the way. R.C. Majumdar observes: "It would be difficult to name another book, written by one possessing eminent qualifications as a historian, in which so much prodigious labour has been misdirected to produce a historical work which by any canon of criticism does not deserve the name."[25]

2. Mountstuart Elphinstone (1779–1859)

History of Hindu and Muhammadan India

When Mill's *History* was reigning supreme, another history of India was written by a critic of Mill. Mountstuart Elphinstone had come to India as a wild lad of sixteen, but had disciplined himself into a scholar-administrator. In 1827, Elphinstone voluntarily retired from the governorship of Bombay and nothing could induce him to take up another post however high.

Criticism of Mill's History

Deeply in love with India and deeply in love with history, Elphinstone had all along been uneasy about Mill's *History.* In his retirement period he became increasingly critical of Mill and the latter's offensively cynical and sarcastic tone. Mill's work, he felt, though ingenious, original and elaborate, was not candid in its Hindu and Muhammadan parts. Feeling it his duty to combat it, in 1834 Elphinstone began work on the *History of Hindu and Muhammadan India.* In the very year of its publication, 1841, Elphinstone's *History* came into use at Haileybury for the benefit of the Indian Civil Service cadets and the author was hailed as the Tacitus of India.

Mill had written his *History of British India* on the Enlightenment-utilitarian assumption that human nature was the same everywhere, irrespective of climate and age, and that differences should be accounted for by the custom of the people. This custom, if found useless or harmful, could be changed only by law and government, and the historian's job is to demonstrate it. But cast in the Romanticist mould, Elphinstone held that human nature differed from region to region, period to period, and from people to people. In the true Romantic spirit, he would rather comprehend human nature and recognize its difference from another when cast in different settings or environment than enter into value judgements. Yet, too diffident and cautious, Elphinstone's criticism of his formidable adversary was implied and not open. In answering Mill's sweeping condemnation of the Indians, Elphinstone even allowed a marginal concession:

> Those who have known the Indians longest have always the best opinion of them...all persons who have retired from India think better of the people they have left after comparing them with others even of the most justly advanced of the nations [though] the Hindus have in reality some great defects of character.[26]

Sources, Method and Chronology

Mill's *History* was based solely on European evidence, much of which was casual. Elphinstone rightly felt that a work written using native sources might come to different conclusions. Intending to write a history more full of facts and. free from disputes and dissertations, he wrote his account from personal observation and chronicles provided by

his friend, William Erskine, the translator of Babur's *Memoirs.* He had intimately known the Hindus for many years, and he made a diligent and careful study of the available literature on Indian history. Guided by the works of William Jones and H.H. Wilson, he dismissed the traditional Hindu conception of the four *yugas* and started the history of the Hindus from the oldest fixed point known till then—the composition of the *Rig Veda*, which he assigned to the fourteenth century BC. Elphinstone tried to fix the later chronology with the help of the dynastic lists given in the *Puranas.* He was also acquainted with Prinsep's decipherment of the Asokan inscriptions. And now, without any difficulty he fixed Chandragupta Maurya's accession towards the end of fourth century BC. Then counting backwards and forwards from this one fixed point, he fixed the approximate dates of the royal dynasties mentioned in the *Puranas* from the Mahabharata war to the Guptas in the fourth century AD. The chronological framework Elphinstone gave to ancient Indian history is much the same as is generally accepted, though occassional modifications have been rendered necessary by archeological discoveries of coins and inscriptions.

Cultural History

But Elphinstone's treatment of the political history of ancient India is meagre and inadequate. There is only a bare enumeration of the succession list of the royal dynasties based on the *Puranas.* Detailed accounts of the invasion of Alexander, and the achievements of Chandragupta Maurya and of Asoka are absent. The absence cannot be blamed on the dearth of sources, as general accounts of them could be found in Graeco-Roman classical writers, ancient Indian literature, and the newly deciphered inscriptions of Asoka. Yet a brief outline of the political history of India south of the Narmada is given. By the side of this meagre treatment of political history is the stress Elphinstone laid on the cultural achievements of the Hindus. Long accounts are given of the administrative system, society, religion, literature, philosophy, arts and sciences, manners and customs, and the trade and commerce of the Hindus. The gradual changes in these are traced with a true historical instinct. Elphinstone also noted the distinction between north and south India in these respects, as Aryan culture penetrated into the south at a considerable later date to merge with the Dravidian, which was already highly developed. It is surprising that he should have given at such an early date, a description of the overseas trade and maritime activities of the Hindus, and their colonization of Java, Bali and other islands. Elphinstone truly laid the foundations of the cultural history of India.

Duff, Erskine and Tod

Elphinstone who loved the Indians and had drawn up an objectively favorable account of their life and culture inspired others to write on Indian history. He had handed over to James Grant Duff the entire corpus of the Peshwa's state papers and correspondence. In 1825 Duff's two-volume *A History of the Marathas* appeared. Straightforward and sympathetic, Duff's work, says C.H. Philips, is a classic though not much read, and invaluable in that it is based on material that has long since disappeared. A publisher shied away from printing it for fear of not finding enough readers for it and Duff had to print the work at his own expense. William Erskine, another of Elphinstone's followers, completed a translation of the *Babur-namah*, besides providing Elphinstone chronicles for the latter's *History of Hindu and Muhammodan India.* But the most famous of Elphinstone's disciples was James Tod who, between 1812 and 1823, lovingly gathered in three volumes, the *Annals and Antiquities of Rajasthan.* Not even Walter Scott would have stumbled upon material so romantically rich and bearing so much of the pollen and fragrance of the past. Legend and romance have given to the *Annals and Antiquities* such an enduring character that the work would never suffer from want of readers.

3. Persistence of the Mill Tradition

Elliot and Dowson

The British – both the government and the people – were more inclined to take Mill's, and not Elphinstone's view of the Indians. The great Revolt of 1857, they thought, was a further proof of the validity of Mill's argument. It was Henry Elliot who did more than anyone else to perpetuate the tradition of Mill. A product of the Haileybury College, Elliot rose to be Chief Secretary in the Government of India's Foreign Department. Learning Persian, he devoted all his spare time to collecting the chronicles of the Indo-Muslim annalists of the Sultanate and the Mughal periods. Selections from these were translated and published between 1867 and 1877 in eight large volumes as *The History of India as Told by its own Historians.* It was a project in which he received the help of John Dowson, Professor of Hindustani at the University College, London.

Elliot did not write any formal history, but in his preface to the above volumes, he "...poured as great scorn on Muhammadan government in India as Mill had done on the Hindu; in the process pushing into the background the more sober, more sympathetic interpretation of Elphinstone."[27]

Elliot wrote in his preface that the material he had collected on medieval Indian history would "make our native subjects more sensible of the immense advantage accruing to them under the mildness and equity of our rule."[28] The Elliot and Dowson series had great influence on Indian historiography since all the subsequent histories of Muslim

rule in India were based on them. Equally important, perhaps more, was the effect that Elliot's preface had on the British Indian officials from the Viceroy down. Writes C.H. Philips: "They were all agreed that the happiness of the governed which might be ensured by strong executive government and the rule of law was more important than self-government."[29] The Mill tradition bred a sense of imperial dogmatism and self-assuredness which crept into the British Indian administration. The British failure to conciliate India must be blamed chiefly on the rigor of the Mill tradition which Elphinstone's more sympathetic interpretation of the country's history could not soften.

Ideas behind Late Nineteenth Century Imperialism

Imperial dogmatism and self-assuredness were only strengthened by certain ideas and pseudo-scientific theories in late nineteenth century Europe. The first of these was the idea of race superiority. The belief, writes James Joll, that the White races are superior to the Black or Yellow was a basic assumption of the confident imperialism of the late nineteenth century.[30] "What is empire but the predominance of race," said Lord Rosebury, a former Prime Minister of England. The belief in race superiority and its relation to imperial domination was nourished by pseudo-scientific evolutionary theories such as the 'survival of the fittest', the Aryan master-race, and Social Darwinism. The very fact that Europeans were able to beat non-Europeans in war showed that in terms of evolution and progress they were more fit to survive than were the non-Europeans. White men are simply better specimens of the human species than are colored men, and this racial superiority carried with it a mandate to rule over those thought to be racially inferior.

The imperialist argument based on the White man's special right to rule was given a moral and humanitarian cover. The Christian missionary was altruistically eager to save heathen souls from the certainty of hell. Ethical imperialism emphasized the humanitarian task of bringing about good government, education, material improvement and moral elevation of the colonial peoples under the White man's care. Rudyard Kipling, in his famous poem, *The White Mans Burden* (1899) put the case comfortably for the Europeans:

> Take up the White Man's Burden
> Send forth the best ye breed
> …
> To serve your captive's need;
> …
> Your new-caught sullen peoples,
> Half-devil and half-child.

Some imperialists thought that this benevolent rule of the White men, particularly in the tropics, would last indefinitely, since in their opinion non-Whites were totally incapable of undertaking tasks of leadership and ruling themselves. Tutelage of the civilized over the uncivilized was thought to be a necessity. Lord Curzon, a typical imperialist, expressed the conviction that the world had never seen a greater instrument for accomplishing good than the British empire. In the late nineteenth century, a psychology of imperialism developed which found utterance in such prominent men as Thomas Carlyle, Charles Kingsley, Benjamin Disreali and John Ruskin. John Seely's *Expansion of England* (1883) was so enormously popular as to get into the reading of most middle and upper class school boys.[31] Intellectuals began to speak and write of their country's 'civilizing mission', 'advance of the flag', and 'manifest destiny'—only slight semantic variants of Kipling's 'White man's burden'. Such was the language, such the words and phrases, used to cover up Europe's power impulse—the mad race for empire and spheres of influence dictated by the capitalist search for raw materials and markets and fields of investment.

Holden Furber attests that there was an increasing number of writers who were frankly imperialist as regards India, and antiimperialist as regards Canada, Australia and New Zealand. They believed in the wisdom of a firm, paternalistic rule in India, and the continuance of the civilizing mission. John Stuart Mill, the apostle of liberty, comforted them by resolving to their satisfaction the paradox of a democratic England despotically ruling India by pointing out that a despot responsible to a fiee people twelve thousand miles away was better than a despot responsible to none but himself.[32] It was believed too complacently that Indians were unfit for self-government, that British rule was the best for them, and that they were happy under that rule. This was the general attitude of the writers we will consider in the next section. The arrogant tone of British imperialist historiography on India after Elphinstone, and the British treatment of the Indian national movement were conditioned by the tendencies outlined above.

4. The British Imperialist Administrator-historians (c. 1870–1940)

Much of the historical writing on India during the period of British rule came from British Indian administrators. One may form an idea of the main assumptions of such writers by a selective treatment of a few important figures. E.T. Stokes broadly divides them into the two categories of 'popular' and 'philosophic' historians.

Popular Historians

Macaulay returning from India had caught the popular attention by explaining British ascendancy in India in terms of the British national character in its highest examples. He endeavored to demonstrate how individual character moulded history. The fact of a few Englishmen gaining an empire in India was for him a theme which could easily be written in biographical form. Macaulay's *Essay on Clive* drew the picture of the founder of the British Indian empire in heroic proportions. He wrote of "the valour and genius of an obscure English youth" turning the tide of fortune,[33] and the disciplined valor of handfuls of Englishmen led by a genius overcoming and putting to flight vastly superior numbers of Indians. The moral stressed was always the superiority of character. Macaulay's essays on Clive and Warren Hastings were examples to other writers who treated British Indian history largely in biographical terms. Thus the *Rulers of India* series, twenty-eight short studies, edited by William Wilson Hunter, offers a good example of history written as a string of biographical studies. They deal mostly with military campaigns and the careers of successful British officials, a mere half dozen devoted to Indian rulers. The writers invariably extolled virtues of the British national character. G.B. Malleson who wrote the *History of the Indian Mutiny*, *History of the French in India*, and the *Decisive Battles of India* as well as three volumes in the *Rulers of India* series, explained the British conquest of India in terms of the difference between English and Indian character. The Indian had intelligence, fidelity and individual courage, but was incapable of combination and unity necessaiy for successful military resistance. Once this defect was compensated by British leadership, Indians became a formidable military force, cooperating willingly and faithfully in the work of conquering their fellow countrymen.

Philosophic Historians

There is another class of British Indian administrators writing on Indian history whom E.T. Stokes calls 'philosophic' historians. Using the new knowledge derived from Sanskrit studies they arrived at conclusions diametrically opposite to that of the Orientalists. Against the traditional view that the British Indian dominion came as a result of a sudden, miraculous accident, this class in general held that it was the result of long working forces and was an inseparable part of the history of Europe and Britain. If the popular historians had tried to interpret British Indian history largely .in terms of individual character, the philosophic historians seemed to reduce that history to the interplay of impersonal forces. But whether 'popular' or 'philosophic', they arrived at more or less the same conclusions.

James Fitzjames Stephens

A Haileybury product, James Fitzjames Stephens was a utilitarian trained in the authoritarian tradition and was also Social Darwinist. He was Law Member in India from 1869 to 1872. The above influences issued in a theory which asserted that the strongest always ruled. Stephens was incensed at the old Whig interpretation of British Indian history now voiced by sentimental liberals like John Bright who held that British Indian rule was founded in violence and crime and maintained by an intolerable conception of power. Sharing Mill's dislike of the Indians and their culture, he believed in the forthright imposition of British rule. His book *Liberty*, *Equality*, *Fraternity* (1873) sought to give a firm moral basis to the British rule in India. Stephen's moral argument was that the essential function of Britain in India is similar to that of ancient Rome's in the Mediterranean world. Britain had not only developed the highest ideal of social happiness, but in Bentham's legislative science had devised a scientific instrument of enforcing it. Since only Britain could perform the task of civilizing India within a framework of law, the British Indian government, though only a minority resting on force, had to remain for all the foreseeable future. None could have written a better apology for imperialism.

Henry Maine

Henry Maine, author of the famed *Ancient Law* (1861) and Law Member in India from 1861 to 1869, was not strictly a historian, but his influence in forming an important view of Indian history was great. Maine fully accepted the Aryan theory and believed that even the Indian village community was an Aryan institution surviving in full vigor. But he employed the theory not in India's favor but only as a justification of Britain's dominion. The notion of the common racial stock served only to lessen racial prejudices and render the government of India by the English easier. Maine shared with the other British administrators the contemptuous attitude towards Indian culture. He argued that instead of being in an advanced state of civilization India remained in the "infancy of the human mind prolonged...."[34] In the Cambridge Rede lectures (1875) he said that "the primitive Aryan groups, the primitive Aryan institutions, the primitive Aryan ideas have been arrested in India at an early stage of development."[35] The principle of progress is the continual production of new ideas. Spreading from the Greeks to the Romans, the Germans, the French and the English, this principle was now being communicated to India by the English. Maine's liberalism stopped at India's door. His conclusion did not differ essentially from that of Stephens or the popular

writers. E.T. Stokes observes:

> The result of the new intellectual influences was in this way rather to emphasize than diminish the gap between India and Europe, and this historical view provided for Maine, as well as Lyall and Hunter, a rational and dispassionate justification for the continued maintenance of British rule.[36]

J. Tallboys Wheeler

J. Tallboys Wheeler, another administrator-historian, further demonstrated that the attempt to write philosophic history on the basis of the new knowledge derived from Sanskrit studies could reach conclusions as prejudiced as those of James Mill. Wheeler was Assistant Secretary to the Government of India's Foreign Department, and later Secretary to the Chief Commissioner, British Burma. His five-volume *History of India from the Earliest Times* blamed India's failure to develop nationalities on the tyranny of the Brahman priesthood. Devotion to the common weal found amongst all Aryan nations and which certainly belonged to the Vedic Aryans, passed away beneath the blighting influence of Brahmanical oppression. The public spirit which animated the body politic in the Vedic age, and which is essential to the permanence of states and empires came to be narrowed down to the caste, the village, and the family. Political tie, nationality and patriotism—all came to be squeezed into the religious spirit.[37] Wheeler was no kinder to Muslim rule. The Mughal administration "was a monstrous system of oppression and extortion which none but Asiatics could have practised or endured."[38] India, Wheeler concluded, like Charles Grant or James Mill, had been saved from the most hopeless of anarchies only by the introduction of European rule. The Mutiny was a revelation of Asiatic nature and India was utterly unready for any type of representative government. "The would be philosophic historian," comments E.T. Strokes, "ends in this way in the ranks of the most narrow and prejudiced Anglo-Indians."[39]

Alfred Lyall

Alfred Lyall is known through his two series of collected articles *Asiatic Studies* (1882, 1889) and an expanded set of lectures, *The Rise and Expansion of British Dominion in India* (1894). Liberal in outlook and interested in India's religion and culture, Lyall's aim was to correct certain misconceptions about India in England. Burke's oratory had denounced "the oppressors of Indian nationalities, the degraders of ancient nobility, and the dethroners of sovereign princes."[40] Lyall's interpretation endeavored to prove that it was precisely the absence of any permanent organization such as nationalities, aristocracies and long-seated dynasties – in fact, any permanent organization – that ensured the rapid conquest of the country by the British. Like Maine, Lyall maintained that Indian society was "in an arrested state of development, a mere loose conglomeration of tribes, races and castes."[41] Explaining this phenomenon, Lyall advanced the theory that the primeval tribal-units based on kinship and religion into which mankind is distributed everywhere in the world did not, in India, coalesce into larger units based on broader loyalities. Advanced religious and moral conceptions were not unknown in India, but they lacked the persistent backing of a stable political power to extirpate the lower polytheism and establish themselves with a formal ecclesiastical organization and defined theology as the Rotnan empire and the later monarchies had done in Europe in the interests of Christianity. The one principle of government known in Asia was personal ascendancy. And popular Hindu religious practice assisted not fusion but dispersion; occupational groups came to be organized into the religious institution of caste. Hinduism, unlike Christianity and Islam, was simply a name for the perplexity of diverse practices and beliefs without any organized church and theology to reduce them to order.

Again, John Seely in his *Expansion of England* (1883) had stated that the British conquest of India was unintentional and accidental.[42] Lyall refuted Seely in his *The Rise and Expansion of the British Dominion in India*, and stated that there was nothing miraculous in that conquest. He saw it as part of the powerful wave of European expansion which from the sixteenth century had been steadily overwhelming Asia.

The British rule in India, like its predecessors, was an overcentralized despotism, though far more efficient. Lyall saw decentralization as a necessity and accepted Ripon's local selfgovernment measures and the establishment of provincial assemblies as steps in the right direction. But he could never imagine for a moment that the British should impair their ultimate controlling power over India. Like Mill or Stephens he thought it absolutely necessary to maintain British rule intact for a great transformation of the Indian society.

William Wilson Hunter

Intelligent, perceptive and able, William Wilson Hunter was the leading British historian of India in the last twenty years of the nineteenth century. Hunter's earliest work on India, *Annals of Rural Bengal* (1868), makes him a pioneer in economic studies. His *Indian Mussalman* (1876) is proof of his unusual insight into the mind of the Muslim community in India. He edited the *Rulers of India* series and the *Imperial Gazetteer* took shape under him. But Hunter's most important historical work was his *History of British India.* He died on the eve of completing the second volume of this work.

Hunter's *Annals of Rural Bengal* was an attempt to give a fresh interpretation to Indian history. Hitherto the history of the British period had been presented in the form of the "biographies of the English governors of India, not histories of the Indian people. The silent millions who bear our yoke have found no annalist."[43] He aimed at depicting the historical growth of the peoples of Bengal, and then tracing the early effect of British rule on the state of society. Accepting the notion of a common Aryan stock, Hunter sought to explain why India had not developed strong nationalities like the Aryan races of Europe, a defect which had rendered the foreign conquest by Muslims and Europeans inevitable. Hunter found the answer in the institution of caste, which had its origin in the racial distinction between the conquering Aryans and the aborigines of India. Tracing the successive Aryan migrations into Bengal, he showed how cohabitation between the Aryans and the aborigines had resulted in mixed castes. The refusal of the pure Aryan tribes to mix socially with the latter, and their treatment of them as a helot class had prevented the growth of an homogenous society with a common nationality. Shifting all manual labor on to the mixed castes, the Brahman caste had become slothful and effeminate and had been unable to resist conquest by successive waves of more vigorous peoples. In the *Annals of Rural Bengal* Hunter envisaged the role of the British as one of breaking down all physical, racial and social barriers in preparation for creating a united Indian nation. Previous efforts at uniting India had failed because the material means were inadequate to overcome the physical obstacles.

The *History of British India* purported to show that Britain's Indian connection was not a strange and fortuitous accident, but the outcome of a long process beginning with Britain's own rise to greatness in Elizabethan times. The British achievement "was no sudden triumph but an indomitable endurance during a century and a half (1600–1750) of frustration and defeat."[44] It is national character which Hunter stresses as the dominant factor in the English fortunes in the East. Size had little to do with a European nation's success. "The prize fell successively to states small in area, but of great heart."[45] The history of British rule in India, wrote Hunter, "Stands out as the epic of the British nation.... It will make the world understand the British race—adventurous, masterful, patient in defeat and persistent in executing its designs."[46]

Hunter held that each stage in the history of British rule in India was one of constant readjustment to historical forces Britain had itself set in motion. For this reason alone he believed that a place had to be found for the Western educated classes in India, and that it was impossible to rule modern India through a foreign bureaucracy alone. By the planned introduction of modern life, Britain was to lead India into the modern world with a paternal authoritarian hand.

Vincent Smith (1848—1920)

Vincent Arthur Smith does not belong to the group of what E.T. Strokes calls 'philosophic' historians. Smith was born in 1848 in Dublin, the son of a prominent doctor who was also a well known amateur numismatist and archeologist. Smith joined the Indian Civil Service in 1869, and served in what is now Uttar Pradesh. After retirement in 1900 he taught Indian history at Dublin.

By the time Smith wrote, a vast corpus of new source materials had been brought to light, and the chronology of ancient Indian history had been placed on a firmer footing. In 1904 he produced his famous *Early History of India* incorporating the advances made in the knowledge of India's past. In 1919 appeared the *Oxford History of India.* In the interval between the two books Smith also wrote *The History of Fine Art in India and Ceylon*, and several lesser works. Both the *Early History* and the *Oxford History* were great successes as standard textbooks in Indian colleges and universities.

Pragmatic View and the Subjective Element

Smith shared with the other administrator-historians of India, the pragmatic view that those desirous of knowing modern India and solving its numerous problems must know its ancient history. In the *Early History* he aimed to present the story of ancient India in an impartial and judicial spirit. But he knew fully well that even the most direct evidence is liable to unconscious distortion, as some degree of subjectivity is inevitable for it is impossible for the historian to altogether eliminate his own personality however great may be his respect for the objective fact.[47]

Sympathetic Treatment of Ancient Indian Civilization

Smith, like Elphinstone, is sympathetic in his treatment of ancient Indian civilization. In his *Early India* he rejects a view quite common in his day that all that was good in early India owed to the influence of Hellenistic ideas. Western influence on India was very small.[48] He admires the art of India, though not her literature. Failing to realize, as A.L. Basham observes, that canons of taste differ from culture to culture, Smith writes that the Rajput epics are rude, and Bana's *Harshacharita*, though containing passages of admirable and vivid description, is an "irritating performance, executed in the worst possible taste."[49] For Smith, the Gupta period was "a time not unworthy of

comparison with the Elizabethan and Stuart period in England."[50]

Imperialist Strain

But the *Early History* and the *Oxford History* are primarily political histories, and in this aspect Smith becomes an imperialist historian. Here the impartial and the judicial spirit leaves him. The political moral that he draws from ancient Indian history is starkly imperialist. Out of the 478 pages of the *Early History of India* covering the period from 600 BC to AD 1200, sixty-six are devoted to the Indian campaigns of Alexander. Smith writes: "The triumphant progress of Alexander from the Himalayas to the sea demonstrated the inherent weakness of the greatest Asiatic armies when confronted with European skill and discipline."[51] In point of fact, however, King Purushothama or the tribes of northwestern India whom Alexander confronted did not possess the greatest Asiatic armies. The classical writers themselves allude to the war-weary soldiers of Alexander and the military might of the Nandas. Smith concedes that Seleukos's treaty with Chandragupta as "humiliating" to the Greek king. The historian especially admires the India of the Guptas. India had probably never been governed better "after the Oriental manner" than under Chandragupta II. The *Arthasastra* is criticized for its autocratic and Machiavellian character, and its penal code is stigmatized as "ferociously severe".[52] 'Autocracy' and 'despotism' – the only political forms known to ancient India – are for Smith, forms which do not admit of development, and for this reason, presumably, India has not developed. But the despotic sway of the British over India is benevolent and necessary. The paramount lesson of Indian history is the ever present need for a superior controlling force to check the disruptive forces always ready to operate in India. The description in the *Early History of India* of the condition of northern India after Harsha's death is an unconcealed justification of the continuation of British rule in India. Here Smith gives the reader

> a notion of what India always has been when released from the control of a supreme authority, and what she would be again, if the hand of the benevolent despotism which now holds her in its iron grasp should be withdrawn.[53]

The imperialist strain runs through the later *Oxford History* too:

> ...even now, in the twentieth century, she (India) would relapse quickly into that condition [political disruption] if the firm although mild control exercised by the paramount power should be withdrawn.[54]

Smith tells us that the desire of the Indians for political unity is shown in their acquiescence to British rule, and in the passionate outbursts of loyal devotion to the King Emperor.[55]

E.B. Havell, a pioneer in the sympathetic study of Indian art and the author of *The History of Aryan Ride* in India (1918), believed that the Aryans were responsible for all that is good in India, especially the rural democracy of the *panchayats*, and the rule of law. But unlike other British historians of India he arrived at a different conclusion. Both Englishmen and Indians being Aryans, England should encourage India's aspirations for self-government under the British crown, for they are in keeping with the Aryan tradition. The following passage is Havell's criticism of Smith's approach to early India:

> It must be peculiarly humiliating to [the Indians] to be constantly told by their rulers...that freedom has never spread her wings over their native land, that they are heirs to untold centuries of "Oriental Despotism"....Whether intentional or not, no greater spiritual injury can be done to a people than to teach them to despise the achievement of their forefathers. To overvalue them can hardly be a mistake.[56]

W.H. Moreland (1868–1938)

William Harrison Moreland may be looked upon as the last important British administrator-historian of India. Born in northern Ireland and educated at Cambridge, Moreland joined the Indian Civil Service as Director of Land Records and Agriculture in what is now United Provinces. His special field was Indian agricultural economy.

Economic Factor

Moreland was one who believed in the primacy of the economic factor in history, and in his writings he always focused his attention on the production and distribution of wealth. "I estimate the various Indian administrations," he wrote in his *From Akbar to Anrangazeb*, "strictly from the economist's point of view."[57] "Economic forces are at the heart of history, and in India agriculture, and the revenue derived from it, is the major economic factor."[58]

British Role in India

Moreland's first book, *Agriculture of the United Provinces* (1904), was followed in 1911 by the *Revenue Administration of the United Provinces.* With the above views on Indian agriculture and land revenue, Moreland did not see any discontinuity between traditional and British India as did the other British historians. There was no discontinuity because he held that the revenue system in ancient India was adopted continually first by the Muslim rulers and then by the English; and that even after a century of British rule, India had remained unaffected by the West. Indian economy largely remained a barter economy unaccustomed to capital as a growing mobile factor of production. The distinct role of the British in India was to act as impersonal agents of economic change. The change

itself lay in the introduction of a money economy and of the free productive use of capital. Greater production and trade would destroy the organization of agriculture based on cheap labor and the almost gratuitous services of the 'lower' castes in the villages.

Mughal Economy

The more important of Moreland's works are all on the Mughal economy. In 1918, in collaboration with Yusuf Ali he drew up a detailed study known as *Akbar's Land Revenue System*. It was followed in 1920 by *India at the Death of Akbar*. Moreland's twin criteria for a healthy social order are even distribution of wealth and the encouragement of production. Judged by these standards, the Mughal economic system came under heavy attack for its wastefulness and maldistribution of wealth. *From Akbar to Aurangazeb*, a work, which Moreland published in 1931, defended European activities in India. In the *Agrarian System of Moslem India* (1929), he argued that what the British inherited from the medieval Indian Muslim administration was a *damnosa hereditas*, a legacy of loss, from which they rescued Indian society.[59]

Mooreland and the Indian Nationalists

The early writings of Moreland were academic and research oriented in character, observes J.B. Harrison, which turned more and more into political polemics refuting charges made by the Indian National Congress against the British administration in India. Meeting the charge of over-assessment he wrote in his *Revenue Administration* (1911) that

> the revenue now assessed represents a proportion of substantially less than 10 per cent of the produce of the land—curiously just about what was thought reasonable at the time when Manu wrote, and about one-third of what was considered proper by Akbar.[60]

Agitation against the enhancement of the salt tax brought the rejoinder that in Mughal times salt was much dearer, and the *swadeshi* cry of self-sufficiency met with the comment that when India lived on its own resources its people were ill-fed and badly clothed. The book *From Akbar to Aurangazeb* maintained that if American indigo and British cottons displaced the Indian products, the fault lay in a practice of adulteration, which the Mughals could not eradicate. Indian reaction rightly pointed out that the one object of the learned author in writing his books seemed to be to prove that in the Mughal period the financial and social condition of the people of India was even worse and more deplorable than it came to be under the British.[61]

Moreland's *A Short History of India*, written in collaboration with Atul Chatterjee, rejected in its first section, claims of European origin for Indian science, thought, and arts. The second drew a grim picture of eighteenth century India, torn by factions, economically ruined, degraded in culture and religion—at the moment when power passed into European hands. Uniform praise for British motives and achievements is found in the third section.

Moreland, concludes Harrison, was a true historian though political feelings dominated him, and his vision was somewhat narrowed by his Civil Service training. But that vision was remarkably penetrating and acute, and his analysis of the Mughal land-revenue system and its conditioning factors is masterly.[62]

5. Imperialist Historiography: An Overview

Western Assumptions Regarding India's Past

The evangelical-utilitarian picture of Indian society and culture presented by Charles Grant's *Observations* and James Mill's *History* gave currency to certain historical cliches which influenced not only European historiography on India but even philosophies of history.

The first of these was that of a static, unchanging Indian society. Mill maintained that from the coming of the Aryans to the arrival of the British, Indian society had remained substantially unchanged. This concept of an unchanging society had a direct influence on Hegel's philosophy of history. For Hegel, true history involved dialectical change and development. Indian society, as the German philosopher knew it, remained stationary and fixed, and therefore outside the stream of world history. Mill's division of Indian history into the Hindu, Muslim and British periods has continued to our own days. Christian Lassen (1800–1876) applied the Hegelian dialectic to this periodization of Indiad history, with the difference that the three phases of thesis, antithesis and synthesis became in his hands the Hindu, the Muslim and the Christian—not the
British as in Mill. But Lassen could not refute Hegel's assumption of the unchanging nature concerning India's past.[63]

Oriental despotism is the other aspect of this concept of an unchanging society. The basis of Indian society was believed to be the immutable pattern of the Indian village—the village inhabited by people unconcerned with political relationships. To the Western thinker and historian it was this lack of concern with politics, and what was believed to be the absence of private property in land that gave rise to Oriental despotism. Writes Romila Thapar:

"The static character of Indian society with its concomitant despotic rulers became an accepted truth of Indian history. The concept of Oriental Despitism began to take shape."[64] The assumption concerning the unchanging nature of India's past was taken over by Karl Marx and worked into the thesis of Asiatic mode of production. The characteristics of the Asiatic Mode of Production were the self-sufficient village economy and the absence of private property in land.

The above concepts became axiomatic to Western thinkers and writers: legalists like Henry Maine, sociologists like Durkheim and Weber, but most of all to the British administrator-historians of India—Stephens, Strachey, Lyall and Hunter. They had special need for such concepts, particularly that of the unchanging character of India's past, for they could then present the British administration as the catalyst in changing Indian society. That was to them the *raison d'etre* of the British rule of India.

Change in the Nature of British Historiography

The evangelical-utilitarian hope in the early nineteenth century of transforming what was thought to be the corrupt and rotten Indian life, within a generation had faded away with the progress of the century. It gave place to the outlook of the Punjab School, expressed in the British determination to do Indians good in spite of themselves. The Indians being unteachable, the British in a spirit of altruistic resignation would do "What's for their good, not what pleases them," and to "labour, but not to hope for any reward."[65] (Except, one may add, the huge salaries and pensions.) British historiography reflected this shift in aim by moving on from the outright condemnation of Indian life and culture to the edificatory character of British rule.

Justification for the Continuance of British Rule

The so-called change in British attitude towards India was no change at all. The revival and progress of Sanskrit studies instead of lessening the prejudice against India, only served to provide a theoretical justification for the continuance of British rule. Max Muller might speak loosely of "our Aryan brother", "of the debt of Europe to the East, and of the spiritual relationship which now binds India and England together."[66] Western writers on India in general and the British administrator-historians of India in particular, accepted the common Aryan racial bond between the European and the Indian, but went on to offer historical explanations of the present differences between the two. The 'philosophic' among the latter asked themselves why the Indian Aryans failed to develop strong nationalities and institutions as their European cousins did. The evangelical Christan, aiming at conversion, had roundly blamed what he thought to be the degradation and vice of the Hindu to his religion; employing what may be loosely termed as methods of social anthropology, the British administrator-historians attributed the static quality of Indian society to caste. Whatever the explanation, it was to justify the continuance of British rule.

Dominance of the Political Element

But the most important characteristic of British imperialist historiography on India was the dominance of the political element. Here, British prejudice, the tendency to moralize, intense bias and value-loaded statements found free play. The writers had little interest in Indian life and culture, and economic issues were only treated in so far as they had political application. Works written were confined mostly to the British period, and concerned only with British activities. They always presented the British point of view. Short descriptions of Indian manners and customs were included only to emphasize their diversity and reiterate their decadence. Meant mainly for readers in England, the works invariably contained the thrilling story of the British conquest of India, and the consequent benevolence, with the writers and the readers agreeing that the benevolence should continue. It was not strange then that every kind of discrimination was shown in denying self-government to India which Britain had granted to Canada, South Africa, Australia and New Zealand. One is reminded of Gokhale's meeting with John Morley, the Secretary of State for India, at the India Office in London before the 1909 reforms to plead for establishing parliamentary institutions in India with the object of making India, like Canada, a self-governing colony within the empire. Morley had already observed in the House of Commons that it was wrong to think that because a fur coat was used in the Canadian winter, it was needed in the Deccan also. The liberal Secretary of State even threatened Gokhale that agitation by the National Congress for the realization of colonial selfgovernment would spoil even the expected chance of limited reform.

15

I. INDIAN NATIONALIST HISTORIOGRAPHY

1. The Search for National Identity

After an initial phase of shallow imitation of Western life in dress, manners and customs, an urge began to develop among the really educated Indians to make India more Indian and less English. This class did not want Western civilization to displace their own as Macaulay and the missionaries had wanted; they only wanted the West to revitalize Indian culture as Ram Mohun Roy had desired. They set out to reform their age-old religion and society and rejuvenate their ancient culture. The trend attained the proportions of a renaissance creating among the Indians a sense of self-reliance, self-respect and self-confidence which had been blown out in the Western wind. By degrees India was gaining national self-consciousness which would soon consummate in a desire for freedom from foreign domination. The new consciousness had, however, to be sustained and promoted by a historical consciousness, the knowledge of a people's past.

Bankim Chandra Chatterjee asserted that as a means of creating a sense of unity, national pride and desire for freedom, there was nothing more fundamental than the study and writing of history. India was a subject country because Indian history had not been described and interpreted by Indian historians. In his *Bibidha Prabandha* he says:

> There is no Hindu history. Who will praise our noble qualities if we do not praise them ourselves?... When has the glory of any nation ever been proclaimed by another nation? The proof of the warlike prowess of the Romans is to be found in Roman histories. The story of the heroism of the Greeks is contained in Greek writings. The case for Mussulman valour in battle rests only on their own records. The Hindus have no such glorious qualities simply because there is no written evidence.[1]

The deficiency identified by Bankim Chandra was soon to be addressed by Indian historians who wrote in the first half of the twentieth century when the spirit of nationalism provided the ideology for historical investigation and interpretation.

2. Imperialist Attack on Indian Culture and Civilization[2]

The task that the first generation of modern Indian historians had to perform was to defend their culture and civilization against the British imperialist attack. Imperialist prejudice in Indian historiography had first expressed itself in a series of value judgements on Hindu nature and character. James Mill's five-hundred page account of Hindu civilization, the second book of his famous *History*, had the specific objective of proving that it was rude, and that the Hindu excelled in the qualities of the slave. The trend that Mill set was followed by most British historians of India. Even Mountstuart Elphinstone, sympathetic to the Indians, could write passages smacking of those in Mill's *History*. "The most prominent vice of the Hindus," he wrote, "is want of veracity, in which they outdo most nations even of the East."[3]

There were other assumptions. To Elphinstone it appeared strange that "the Arabs should not have overrun India as easily as they did Persia."[4] Vincent Smith's works on India carefully maintained the imperialist assumptions of European superiority in warfare as in his account of Alexander's Indian campaigns. Again, trailing the other British administrator-historians, Smith took pains to prove that endemic political chaos was the normal political condition of India. The inability of the Indians to unite and rule themselves made the permanence of British rule absolutely necessary. They were constantly reminded that freedom had never dawned on their native land.

R.C. Majumdar arrays examples of efforts made to belittle Indian achievements in the past. In the face of the clear testimony of the *Periplus*, Elphinstone assumed that India's foreign trade was conducted by the Greeks and the Arabs. Often, the lowest possible dates were suggested for the *Vedas* and the great epics, and works sometimes hinted and often asserted without evidence that the Indians must have borrowed most, if not the whole, of their culture from the Greeks. Where there was no such possibility, the borrowing must have been from the Babylonians, Assyrians, Persians, and so on.

> Wherever there was the least similarity between Indian and foreign ideas, Indians were taken to be the borrowers. The Epics were supposed to be indebted to Homer's works, Indian drama, mathematics, philosophy, and astronomy were derived from the Greeks, and even Krishna cult was derived from Christ. The very poor evidence on which such theses were boldly enunciated, even by learned scholars, demonstrated a prejudiced mind rather than bad logical deduction or inference.[5]

Here, an observation made by Joseph Needham, the famed author of *Science and Civilization in Ancient China*, may be read with interest:

> We know that the trigonometric sine is not mentioned by Greek mathematicians and astronomers, that it was used in India from the Gupta period onwards (third century).... The only conclusion possible is that the use of sines is an Indian development and not a Greek one. But Tannery, persuaded

> that the Indians could not have made any mathematical inventions, preferred to assume that the sine was a Greek idea not adopted by Hipparchus, who gave only a cable of chords. For Tannery, the fact that the Indians knew of sines was sufficient proof that they must have heard about them from the Greeks.[6]

One method of undervaluing Indian culture and denigrating the Hindu religion and society was to select and treat only their weak points. Christian missionaries in their writings took special care to highlight the religious superstitions and social abuses of the Hindus. But righteous indignation was one-sided. While justly decrying the barbarous practice of *sati*, witch hunting and the burning of heretics in Europe were forgotten; when the Hindu caste system was justly condemned, slavery, serfdom and the treatment of the 'Blacks' by the 'Whites' were silently passed over.[7]

3. The Meaning, Nature and Content of Nationalist Historiography

Indian nationalist historiography, growing partly in reaction to the pretensions and prejudices of British imperialist histpriography on India, was at root concerned with national identity in the pre-colonial period. The search for identity took various forms and covered a wide range of attitudes.

Meaning of Nationalist Historiography

'Nationalist historians' and 'nationalist historiography' are only terms used in a comparative sense, in contrast to the colonial or imperialist attitude of foreign writers – particularly British – in the writing of Indian history. Filled with legitimate national pride, a rising generation of Indian scholars sought to vindicate their national culture against the unfounded charges of European writers. Though there were occasional lapses of the true principles of historical reconstruction, the terms in question should not be taken to mean a body of historical writers or writing whose sole object was the glorification of India's past. R.C. Majumdar restricts the term 'nationalist historians' to those Indians who in reconstructing their country's history aimed at examining or reexamining

> some points of national interest or importance...which have been misunderstood or misconceived or wrongly represented. Such an object is not necessarily in conflict with a scientific and critical study, and a nationalist historian is not, therefore, necessarily a propagandist or a charlatan.[8]

Religion and Society

The imperialist challenge had to be met, and the Hindu religion and its sacred literature, the first target of European attack, were the first to be defended. The defence was perhaps voiced more by reformers than by historians. An extreme school which included men like Rajnarain Bose, Bankim Chandra Chatterjee and Sasadhar Tarkachudamani and others defended Hinduism in all its forms – including religious superstitions and social evils – claiming that, taken in all the aspects of its development, it formed a highly spiritual force, superior to other faiths. But Dayananda Saraswati, that strange amalgam of liberalism and orthodoxy, defended Hinduism on rational lines. He claimed that the true religion and society of the Hindus are only those purer forms described in the *Vedas*. Idolatry and abuses like caste and *sati* were later accretions not sanctioned by the original faith. Caste was speciously explained as a kind of division of labor, and women in the Vedic period, and even in later times, were shown to have been enjoying a very high status.

Material Culture

The material side of Hindu culture was also defended with equal zeal against European criticism. The results of the new archeological researches and discoveries of both European and Indian scholars were brought forward to disprove the inferiority of Hindu culture. Romesh Chandra Dutt brought together such data in his three volume *Civilization in Ancient India* (1889). R.C. Majumdar calls it the first nationalist history in the best sense of the term. The book is distinguished by its scientific and moderate tone keeping at a distance the extravagant nationalist sentiment of the Indians. Following Max Muller, more or less, Dutt assigned the *Rig Veda* to c. 1200 BC, and his picture of the rude self-assertion and boisterous greed for conquests of the Vedic warriors was one which did not satisfy extreme nationalists and orthodox Hindus. These latter would be content only by the dating of the *Rig Veda* much further back in time. B.G. Tilak, a very able Sanskritist, sought to prove from astronomical data that the Rig Veda was composed in 4000 BC, while A.C. Das pushed the composition of at least some hymns of the *Rig Veda* back to geological epochs. Orthodox Hindu sentiments fancied the Vedic Aryans as a spiritual, pious and contemplative people. The spiritual superiority of Hinduism came to be so loudly asserted that care had to be taken to present the ancient Indians not as a species panting for salvation. Tall claims of scientific and technological achievements were made—claims which included knowledge of even firearms and aeroplanes in ancient India.[9] R.K. Mukherjee's book, *A History of Indian Shipping and Maritime Activity*, was a rejoinder to Elphinstone's doubt whether India's foreign trade was conducted in Indian ships themselves.

While a class of European writers was anxious to prove that Indian culture owed much to foreign sources, some Indian scholars disclaimed with equal vehemence such outside influence. Some of the latter held that India was the original home of the Aryans and that they spread from this country to Europe.

Politics and Adminsitration[10]

The British had repeatedly asserted that India was not a country but a congeries of small states, and that the Indians were not a nation but a conglomeration of peoples of diverse creeds and sects. Against this, R.K. Mukerjee wrote a scholarly thesis, *The Fundamental Unity of India*, which maintained that the religious unity and spiritual fellowship among the Hindus all over India and their ideal of an all-India empire were the basis of Indian nationalism in the past. Again, it was a time when educated Indians were demanding the establishment of representative institutions and a share in the administration of the country. In this respect K.P. Jayaswal had the spurious satisfaction of proving (in his *Hindu Polity)* wrong the thesis of Oriental Despotism. He demonstrated that not only there existed a constitutional form of government, but the entire parliamentary system, including address from the throne and voting of grants, was prevalent in ancient India.

Military

Nationalist historiography likewise sought to explain the easy conquest of India by the British. The explanation offered could not, however, always square up with historical propriety. When the issue at Plassey (1757) was held to be the result of treachery, Buxar (1764) was forgotten. English victory in the Sikh wars was attributed to bribery, but Chilianwala, which was not a British victory, was attributed to the superiority of Sikh military skill. In all this, to prove some points many more had to be forgotten.

Hatred of the British

Nationalist historiography often consciously fanned a hatred of the British government and of individual Englishmen. The calm and moderate tone of Dadabhai Naoroji and R.C. Dutt in their criticism of the British government on economic grounds was not to be heard amongst the diatribes of historians like B.D. Basu. Basu's books are well documented and his charges, supported as they are by facts and figures, are not easy to refute. But, remarks R.C. Majumdar, his scathing comments had the sole objective of arraigning the British before the bar of world opinion. Nationalist bias led to wanton criticism of Macaulay's system of education and Dalhousie's policy of annexing Indian native states. In assessing the work of Clive, Warren Hastings and Wellesly, well-deserved condemnation was coupled with unmerited censure. The very title of the book, *Clive, the Forger*, shows the obvious bias. Siraj ud-Daulah and Mir Kasim became heroes and patriots, Nandakumar a martyr, the Black Hole tragedy a myth, while the massacres of Monghyr were lightly passed over.[11]

Reinterpretation of Indian History

As the freedom struggle developed, nationalist historiography attempted "a deliberate re-interpretation of Indian history in order to infuse enthusiasm in the fight for freedom...."[12] It was the patriot in V.D. Savarkar that renamed the Revolt of 1857 as the 'Indian War of Independence'. Savarkar's book of that title is a typical example of the representation of history from an extremely nationalist point of view. S.B. Chaudhuri's *Civil Rebellions in the Indian Mutiny 1857–59* asserted that the civil rebellions which accompanied the Mutiny gave it the character of a national war of independence. Again, as the British government held out that Hindu–Muslim differences were the chief obstacle in granting dominion status to India, some nationalist historians, realizing the harmful effects of communalism, went out of their way to reinterpret the entire medieval history of India in order to prove that the Hindus and Muslims always behaved like good brothers toward each other, and that they formed one nation. Tarachand's book, *Influence of Islam on Indian Culture* is another attempt in the same direction.[13]

4. Critical Assessment of Indian Nationalist Historiography

Weakness of Nationalist Historiography

Indian nationalist historiography, engaged in an eager search for national identity by meeting European charges against Indian life and culture, at times betrayed a complete lack of historical propriety. Lack of propriety assumed various forms, some of which being inseparable from its nature and content have already emerged in the account given so far. Others may be outlined as:

Methodological Defects

Nationalist historiography in India, as elsewhere, was sometimes guilty of methodological lapses, of deviation from the ideal of objectivity which is the marrow of all true history. It is the inevitable result of making history provide service for current issues. To prove the existence of responsible government in ancient India, Jayaswal put new interpretations on words and passages in inscriptions and literary texts. A.L. Basham tells us of the manner in which Jayaswal arrived at his conclusions in his famous *Hindu Polity*.

> In older to prove his thesis Jayaswal employed a large range of sources, but used them in the manner of a barrister trying to win a favourable judgement, emphasizing every passage which tended to support his case, and interpreting it in the most favourable light, while virtually ignoring the

evidence which went against him.[14]

Chauvinistic Claims

From patrotism to chauvinism is but a step. If the imperialist historians were prone to see everything bad in the Indian past, some of their nationalist counterparts betrayed a tendency to see everything good in it. Emotion and sentiment usurped the place of reason; and detachment, balance, perspective, and objectivity—all became a casualty. Romila Thapar writes:

> There was an unashamed glorification of the ancient Indian past. This was in part a reaction to the criticism of Mill and other writers and in part a necessary step in the building of national self-respect. The glorious past was also a compensation for the humiliating present.[15]

The Indian origin of the Aryans', the pre-Harappan antiquity of the Vedic culture, denial of foreign influence on Indian civilization, superiority of what was thought to be the essential spiritual quality of Indian culture and art to the essentially materialistic culture and art of the West, and the existence from earliest times of political unity based on a cultural unity were all part of this glorification. The deep conviction in India's past glory sometimes led historians to stretch their arguments to an obnoxious and ridiculous extent. Such is Jayaswal's assertion of the existence in ancient India of constitutional monarchy, parliamentary government, voting of grants, and address from the throne. Such, again, was the claim that ancient India did not lag far behind modern Europe in scientific achievements. We are informed that there were firearms and aeroplanes in the age of the Epics.

Self-contradiction

Nationalist historians could at times be seen asserting or justifying contradictory positions: military power and the values of non-violence; democratic traditions and those of imperial glory; the spiritual superiority of Hinduism and the worldliness of the ancient Indians; and the high status of women in the Vedic period and their secluded life and position of inferiority on social, economic, religious and moral grounds.

Communalism

A by-product of nationalist historiography but one which had dangerous potentialities was communalism. Sensational accounts drawn up by Hindu historians of the heroic struggles of the Rajputs, the Marathas and the Sikhs against the Muslims were a challenge which Muslim historians could hardly afford to miss. It became such that the friend of the Hindu automatically became the enemy of the Muslim and *vice versa.* Enmity was fanned by drama, poetry and novels. Communalism which was to divide the country had its roots in the writing of history, too.

Strength of Nationalist Historiogaphy

Stimulant of Historical Studies

The weakness of nationalist historiography should not blind us to its positive side. Had the author of the *Vande Mataram* lived for three or four more decades he would have been happily surprised at the number of his fellow countrymen engaged in the grand quest of their country's past. Historical study in India received its greatest impetus from the sentiment of nationalism. This was because the nationalist spirit disclosed, as in Europe in the nineteenth century, one of the practical uses of history. Indians sought the key of their national development not in the immediate, but in the remoter past. By supplying a powerful motive for historical investigation the national spirit quickened the work of historical research. To meet the imperialist challenge, the Indian savants plunged themselves into a study of the sources, and India was rich in raw historical materials—monuments, epigraphs, coins and a variety of literary sources. Armed with the newly acquired information they proceeded with the zeal of crusaders to refute the Western charges against their nation and culture. Their researches opened the vast vistas of India's hoary past, and the new-found treasure in its turn filled the mind of the Indians with national fervor and pride, enriched nationalism itself, and quickened the struggle for freedom.

Work Done by Nationalist Historians

Weakness of historical works of an extreme nationalist color were only incidental to the time and the purpose of their composition. A good many historical works of the nationalist category deservedly occupy a high place in the world of scholarship. R.C. Dutt's three-volume *Civilization in Ancient India*, while presenting the nationalist case, is admirably free from the extravagant claims of some of the later Indian nationalist historians. Romila Thapar acknowledges that in spite of weaknesses, nationalist historians played a significant role in the interpretation of ancient Indian history. Because they wrote in conscious opposition to imperialist historiography, the historians were forced to take a fresh look at sources. Once the study of the past was found to have relevance for the present, historiography ceased to be the antiquarian's collection of mere facts, and became narration and interpretation. Although most of the historical writing was confined to dynastic history, the debate on ancient political and cultural life necessitated the study of social and economic history as well.[16]

Growth of Interest in Regional and Local History

Romila Thapar further observes that a valuable offshoot of nationalist historiography was a growth of interest in regional and local history. This in turn led to the discovery of new source materials in local repositories and to greater archeological work in the region. The result of such studies filled many lacunae in historical knowledge and acted as a corrective to some of the earlier generalizations. Evidence of regional variations in the cultural pattern led to the recognition that it was unwise and unhistorical to generalize about the entire Indian subcontinent on the basis of the history of the Ganges heartland. Histories of smaller geographical areas such as Bengal and Maharashtra became common. Neelakanta Sastri's works have brought the history of south India into national perspective.[17]

Economic History

Nationalist historiography had earlier expressed itself in revealing the exploitative nature of British rule in India. William Digby's *Prosperous British India* had shown the way and Dadabhai Naoroji and Romesh Chandra Dutt did laborious work to show that British economic exploitation ruined India's trade and industry and reduced its people to starvation. They imputed the impoverishment of India to the subordindation of its economy to British imperialist economy. The 'drain theory' developed by Naoroji blamed India's poverty to British 'draining' of India's wealth. Romesh Chandra Dutt's two-volume *Economic History of India* (1904) had a revelatory character in that it asserted that the basic cause of India's malady should be sought in the agrarian problem. The economic critique of British imperialism as found in Naoroji and Dutt marked the beginning of economic history in India.

Cultural History

Nationalist historiography had unearthed so vast a corpus of information relating to the multifarious facets of Indian life and culture as to suggest a new approach to the study of India's past. If the material for a continuous narration of ancient Indian political history is lacking, that for the cultural history of the subcontinent is abundant. The idea abumbrated by Rabindranath Tagore caught the imagination of historians. The essence of the cultural approach has perhaps been brought out by Sardar K.M. Panikkar, a nationalist historian, in his introduction to his *Survey of Indian History.*

> Ever since India became conscious of her nationhood…there was a growing demand for a history of India which would try and reconstruct the past in a way that would give us an idea of our heritage. Brought upon textbooks written by foreigners whose one object would seem to have been to prove that there was no such thing as "India", we had each to "discover India for ourselves." I do not think it is an exaggeration to say that it was a spiritual adventure to most of us to gain in some measure an understanding of the historical processes which have made us what we are and to evaluate the heritage that has come down to us through five thousand years of development.[18]

II. SOME MODERN INDIAN HISTORIANS

Under the multifarious influences set in motion by the British conquest and governance of the country, the Indians themselves made, by the end of the nineteenth century, a beginning in writing the history of their country. Valuable preliminary work had been done by genuine scholars like Bhagawanlal Indraji, Bhau Dhaji and Rajendralal Mitra in exploring and editing the core material for history. Then came real histories of which those written till about the 1960s may be said to have been more or less nationalist in character. They were mostly political, dynastic and cultural in nature. Since it is impossible in the space and scope of a textbook to deal with all the historians, and their work, only some of them and the more significant of their works are dealt with.

1. R.G. Bhandarkar (1837–1923)

The earliest indigenous modern historian of India was Ramakrishna Gopal Bhandarkar. Son of a clerk in the Revenue Department, Bhandarkar was teacher, researcher and author besides being a social reformer.

In the realm of political history, Bhandarkar produced two very valuable monographs: *The Early History of the Deccan* (1884) and *A Peep into the Early History of India* (1900). Though the author modestly calls the *History of the Deccan* "merely a congeries of facts,"[19] the work gives a historical account of western India from the earliest times to the Muslim conquest. It is not merely a political history, but one informing the reader of the social, economic and religious conditions of the Deccan during the period covered, as also the state of literature and art. *A Peep into the Early History of India* is a brief survey of the early history of northern India from the beginning of the Mauryan period to the end of the Gupta empire. Again, political history is supplemented by information given on the Brahmanical revival under the imperial Guptas as 'reflected in the religion, literature and art of the period. Both works are thus integral in approach, treated with a complete mastery of details and command over the critical apparatus.

In one of his numerous papers entitled, 'The Critical, Comparative and Historical Method of Inquiry', as well as in the introduction to the *Peep into the Early History of India*, one gets glimpses of Bhandarkar's ideas on methodology. He tried to attain historical truth and accuracy by subjecting the different kinds of sources used to rigorous scrutiny. He insisted on strict impartiality as of a judge, and condemned the attitude of an advocate or

prosecuting counsel in a historian. The scholar's aim should be dry truth. He should in every case determine the credibility of the witnesses before him. None of the current legends should be considered to be historically true, though an effort should be made to find any germ of truth that they may contain.[20] In the matter of analysis and source criticism, Bhandarkar was more meticulous than many European scholars of the time and found much fault with Vincent Smith on this score. Though patriotic he was not anti-British and he did not share the tendency of some Indian scholars to reject foreign influences on the development of Indian civilization and claim high antiquity for some of the occurrences in its history. He seems to have subscribed to the Rankean dictum that the task of the historian was to describe the past as it actually was.

The Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute at Poona is a worthy and abiding monument to the scholar-historian. Here, in 1919, presiding over the First Oriental Conference, he said: "I close the active years of my life with an assured belief that sound critical scholarship has grown up among us, and that it will maintain its own against aspersions and attacks."[21] We have to prove ourselves worthy of this belief.

2. Romesh Chandra Dutt (1848–1909)

An Indian Civil Service officer, Sanskrit scholar and master of the Indian classics, Romesh Chandra Dutt left behind him a prolific literary output. Dutt was convinced of the importance of literature as source material for India's social history. In the *Literature of Bengal* (1877) he wrote:

> The literature of every country, slowly expanding through successive stages, reflects accurately the manners and customs, the doings and the thoughts of the people. And thus, although no work of a purely historical character has been left behind by the people of Ancient India, it is possible to gain from their works on literature and religion a fairly accurate idea of their civilization and the progress of their intellect and social institutions.[22]

Thus, to discover the Indian mind and to understand Hindu social institutions, Dutt relied mainly on Sanskrit literature. Thus came *A History of Civilization in Ancient India*, in three volumes. The book was, according to Sister Nivedita, "an exposition to India and to the world, of the national glory."[23] It was history of the nationalist kind but free from all extravagant claims. The work was not of original scholarship, yet was fully rational and scientific in treatment. Its balance and restraint did not appeal to the orthodox Hindu who was inclined to think of Vedic life as more spiritual and less wordly.

It is surprising that as early as 1904 an Indian scholar should have published an avowed two-volume economic history. Dutt's *Economic History of India* took over Dadabhai Naoroji's 'drain theory' and further inquired into the nature of British rule. The work is based mainly on parliamentary papers and official reports supported by statistical material. Dutt was the first Indian analyst who diagnosed India's malady to be the agrarian problem. He focused attention on the high incidence of land tax. He pointed out that the two-fold objective of British colonial economy were the production of raw materials for British industries and the consumption of British manufactures in India. He suggested that the government "should cease to act under mandates from Manchester,"[24] and that a policy of protection should be adopted. He attacked the home charges and military expenditure, and suggested retrenchment finance. He pointed his finger to the annual 'economic drain' in the context of the poverty of the Indian people. Dutt's criticism became the economic platform of the national movement.

3. K.P. Jayaswal (1881–1937)

An Oxford product and a lawyer by profession, Kashi Prasad Jayaswal plunged himself headlong into historical research with the sole aim of regenerating national pride based on a consciousness of India's ancient heritage.

Jayswal's most important works are *Hindu Polity* (1918) and *History of India c. AD 150–350.* These two works contained important theses to prove which the brilliant Sanskritist employed a variety of literary, epigraphic and numismatic sources often giving them his own interpretations. Written in the context of the nationalist-democratic movement the *Hindu Polity* turned out to be an immense success. Against the imperialist cliche of Oriental despotism, Jayaswal painstakingly worked out the thesis that India had the earliest and most successful republics, and that it had monarchy of the 'limited' type. Rhys Davids had pointed to the existence of republics in Buddha's time; Jayaswal pushed their existence further back. The *samiti* of the Vedic period was, according to him, a sovereign representative assembly which discussed and decided upon all matters concerning the state. The *sabha* was a body of selected men working under the authority of the *samiti.* The *gana* and *sangha* of the post-Vedic times meant republican communities in which decisions were taken by a collective body by the counting of heads. The democratic procedure in the Buddhist *sangha* led Jayaswal to believe that the ancient Hindu republics introduced resolutions, debated on them and decided by vote of the majority. He even sees provision of a 'quorum' and the practice of 'referendum'. In the second book of the *Hindu Polity*, the author establishes the existence of limited monarchy. He writes: "The fact, if not the theory, was clear that the office of the king was a creation of the people and was held conditionally. Above him there was always the National Assembly, the Samiti, which was...the real soverign."[25]

The *paura* and the *janapada* are for Jayaswal twin political institutions of the city and the country, acting as a powerful check on royal authority. A passage in the *Mahabharata* is interpreted as an address from the throne asking the *paura—janapada* for extra taxes. The council of ministers with the prime minister at its head was another great check on royal absolutism. "It is a law and principle of Hindu Constitution that the king cannot act without the approval of the council of ministers."[26]

In his *History of India*,[27] Jayaswal, the protagonist of Hindu nationalism, made heroes of the Bharasiva-Nagas who are said to have liberated the country from the pernicious and denationalizing effects of the Saka-Kushan foreign rule. This much-too-labored story is based on sources sometimes of doubtful authenticity. Jayaswal's patriotism outran historical probity. Many of his theories are mere castles in the air and have been duly questioned by scholars like U.N. Ghoshal and A.S. Altekar. But his systematic account of ancient Indian republics remained the framework of later researches.

4. Radha Kumud Mukherji (1880–1963)

Born in a respectable family of Bengal, Radha Kumud Mukherji had a brilliant academic career. He chose to be a teacher and served at several universities in India.

Though cast in the nationalist mould, patriotism did not mislead Radha Kumud. In 1912, Mukherji published an important work in ancient Indian history, *The History of Indian Shipping and Maritime Activity from the Earliest Times.* The book traces the maritime activity of the Indians in all its forms from the earliest time to the end of the Mughal period. A monument of patient scholarship, the work is a mine of information from previously uncharted realms informing us of how India stood out as one of the foremost maritime countries plying her ships from the shores of Africa and Madagascar to the farthest reaches of the Malay Archipelago facilitating trade and colonization. The work is based on literary sources in Pali, Sanskrit, Tamil, Bengali, Persian and English and available archeological and numismatic evidence. Lord Curzon, V.A. Smith and K.P. Jayaswal were among those who congratulated the author. Likewise, Mukherji's *Local Self Government in Ancient India* won praise form Lord Bryce, Lord Haldane and A.B. Keith. *Ancient Indian Education* discussed the evolution and growth of Brahmanical and Buddhist education to the end of the ancient period. *The Fundamental Unity of India* (1914), as F.W. Thomas observed, traced the idea of India's unity "in a variety of geographical and political concepts and in the possession of a common fund of culture."[28] Partition pained the patriotic scholar. In *Men and Thought in Ancient India*, Mukherji presents a view of ancient Indian culture and civilization as in a representative selection: Yajnavalkya, the Buddha, Asoka, Samudragupta and Harsha. *Hindu Civilization*, though intended to be a textbook for universities, is an important work. The monograph entitled *The Gupta Empire* brings together in concise form the moral and material progress of the country achieved in the spacious days of the Guptas. *Ancient India*, again a textbook, is a very well written and profusely illustrated work. There are other works by Mukherji. In fact, no historian has written more exhaustively on ancient India than Radha Kumud Mukherji.

5. H.C. Raychaudhuri (1892–1957)

Hem Chandra Raychaudhuri had shown his brilliance at school and college and as a teacher before he joined the Calcutta University in 1918 and served it till 1952. In 1923, Raychaudhuri published *The Political History of Ancient India from the Accession of Parikshit to the Extinction of the Gupta Empire.* Of this work A.L. Basham writes:

> In so many respects it is the most important work of ancient Indian history written in the last forty years, for since its first publication in 1923 it has gone into six editions, and has been used as a standard text-book in all the colleges and universities. of India, largely replacing Smith's *Early History*. Thus it has affected the historical thinking of a whole generation of Indians.[29]

The first of the two parts of Raychaudhuri's book deals with the period from the accession of Parikshit (c. ninth century BC)
following the Mahabharata war to the accession of Srenika Bimbisara of Magadha in the middle of the sixth century BC. Here Raychaudhuri accomplished a task which had been thought impossible—reconstruction in a definite chronological order of a sober history of the period from the Mahabharata war to the rise of Buddhism. "We are now enabled by the author's penetrating researches," observed Wieh Geiger, "to start the Indian Chronology from the 9th instead of the 6th or 5th century BC."[30] Raychaudhuri's success was comparable to that of Niebuhr in tracing the historical origins of the Roman state. The second part of the *Political History of Ancient India* covers the period from the accession of Bimbisara to the extinction of the Gupta empire (c. 543 BC to AD 550).

The research that has gone into the making of Raychaudhuri's *Political History*, and the original contributions in every chapter have won the unqualified praise of scholars like de la Vallee Poussin, Wieh Geiger, A.B. Keith, F.W. Thomas, E.W. Hopkins and A.L. Basham. Basham regards him as belonging to the school of Bhandarkar in trying to discover 'dry truth'. With a mind which is not hostage to any pre-conceived notion or philosophy and taking nothing

on trust, Raychaudhuri examined the bewildering mass of genealogies, traditions, myths and tales preserved in Brahmanical, Buddhist and Jain writing with extreme care and objectivity and drew conclusions in accordance with the canons of modern historical methodology. His chronology is the only one that has a chance of approximating the truth. Yet Basham detects in Raychaudhuri's writings an undertone of Hindu nationalism.[31]

Another major work, *Materials for the Study of Early History of the Vaishnavite Sect* (1936) won praise from Sir George Grierson, Garbe, and A.B. Keith. Yet another publication of Raychaudhuri resting on solid research work is his *Studies in Indian Antiquities* (1932). Raychaudhuri is also the co-author with R.C. Majumdar and K.K. Datta of *An Advanced History of India*, a useful textbook for college students.

6. G.S. Sardesai (1865–1957)

Govind Sakharam Sardesai was in the service of the state of Baroda as reader and personal clerk to Maharaja Sayaji Rao Gaekwad and also as tutor to the Maharaja's children.

Marathi Riyasat

Sardesai's greatest achievement was the series of books on Maratha history known as *Marathi Riyasat*. The eight volumes of the series told in Marathi the history of the Marathas from the beginning to 1848. The work occupied him for over thirty years. The author had gone through the immense mass of source material on Maratha history. It was a thorough work, though not a critical one. Sardesai does not seem to have taken the trouble of evaluating the sources or assessing the work of the leaders of Maratha history.[32]

Peshwa Daftar and the Poona Residency Correspondence[33]

The long, intimate friendship with Jadunath Sarkar was of immense help and encouragement to Sardesai. When the Maratha historian retired from the Baroda State service in 1925, Sarkar suggested to him to take up the work of editing and publishing the *Peshwa Daftar*. After the third Maratha war and the transfer of power from the Peshwas to the English, the Company got possession of the entire state papers of the Peshwas—a total of 34,972 bundles. Of these, the Marathi bundles written in the *Modi* script, numbered 27,332; the English 7,482; the Persian 29; and the Gujarati 129. These diaries, as they were called, contained information on various aspects of Maratha social and political life. Knowing the value of this material Sarkar prevailed upon the Bombay government to appoint Sardesai as the chief editor of the *Peshwa Daftar*. The Maratha historian and his assistants waded through the sea of papers, selecting, chronologically rearranging and classifying some of them subjectwise for publication. The forty-five published volumes of *Peshwa Daftar* contain 8,650 papers covering 7,801 pages. Vasant Rao writes that Sardesai's introduction to each of the volumes was not of high quality. Soon after the publication of the *Peshwa Daftar*, Sarkar and Sardesai jointly set out to edit and publish the *Poona Residency Correspondence* giving 4,159 letters in 7,193 pages.

New History of the Marathas

Sardesai aimed at presenting a fresh and full treatment of Maratha history in English. He was now eighty. Dauntless, he started writing his *magnum opus, the New History of the Marathas.* The eight volumes of the *Marathi Riyasat* are here compressed into three volumes in English.

Sardesai's historical works were purely political in nature with little of the economic and social life of the Marathas of the period. He does not even seem to be interested in the methodology of history. And of style there is little that is pleasing or commendable.

7. Jadunath Sarkar (1870–1958)

An exceptionally brilliant student, Jadunath Sarkar took double honours in English and History and in 1892 passed the M.A. degree examination in English literature. From 1893 to 1926 he was teacher of English and History, and then for two years, Vice-Chancellor of the Calcutta University. He declined a second term because Vice-Chancellorship was a hindrance to his first love—historical research.

Works

Among Indian historians Sarkar was most prolific producing about fifty works of great merit. The works mentioned below are only some of his greatest. *India of Aurangazeb, its Topography, Statistics and Roads* (1901), was not a history proper in the usual sense of the term, but an account of the physical aspects of the country. His *magnum opus* was the full-scale *History of Aurangazeb* written between 1912 and 1924. A historian of tremendous brilliance and one capable of prodigious labor, Sarkar successfully tackled the difficult subject, revealing the puritan emperor's complex personality. The great *History* takes the reader through the War of Succession, the principles and policies of Aurangazeb's administration, the Islamic Church-State in India, the tragic death of Sambhaji, the subjugation of Bijapur and Golconda, the disorder and confusion in northern India during Aurangazeb's twenty-five-year absence

in the Deccan, and the death of the emperor. The book concludes with Sarkar's assessment of the impact of Aurangazeb's long reign on India's fortunes. Meanwhile, Sarkar published another work, *Shivaji and his Times* (1919). The third volume of his *History of Aurangazeb* had created a stir in Muslim circles in the country; *Shivaji* caused a similar one in Maharashtra. Sarkar's book showed that the Maratha hero's spectacular success notwithstanding, he had failed to build a nation and that most of his institutions were not quite original. These assertions were damaging to the nationalist historians' theories as well as to the hero himself, and therefore caused resentment in Poona.[34] In 1922 Sarkar edited William Irvine's incomplete work on the later Mughals, and he continued the history from 1738, the point where Irvine had left it. He did this in his *Nadir Shah* (1922), and another monumental work, *The Fall of the Mughal Empire* (1932–50). Beginning with Nadir Shah's departure in 1739, the four volumes of the *Fall of the Mughal Empire* end with the capture of Delhi and Agra by the British in 1803. Sarkar's *Military History of India* was published posthumously in I960. His works are characterized by unity of conception, of theme and presentation, and are delivered to the reader in direct, easy flowing language and a charming style free from cant, verbosity and affectation.[35]

Critical Historian[36]

Before William Irvine and Jadunath Sarkar, scholars working on medieval India had not cared to know of anything beyond the court chronicles in Persian. Sarkar insisted on getting all original contemporary material including letters and diaries in the various languages. Like Ranke, he went on treasure hunts for first-hand original documents. But his long and tedious journeys had also another end in view. To free himself from dependence on written records alone, he would visit the historical site connected with the subject of his study in order to acquaint himself with its topography and terrain. Like Jules Michelet, Sarkar would see the life of the common people and live for months, as he did in Maharashtra, in the company of the people to see them face to face and to have an insight into their character; he would visit places of pilgrimage not as a devotee but as a scholar, keen on studying the religious and communal life of the people. He would inspect every fort, valley and scene of battle of the Mughal age. Thoroughness in the collection of contemporary sources was followed by a scientific scrutiny for ascertaining their authenticity, by employing modern methods of textual criticism. Sarkar mercilessly exposed the gossip and what he called the opium-eater's tale in Marathi *bakhars* and Rajasthani prose and verse compositions. Great care was then taken in testing the evidence and trying to discover what was true in a maze of contradictory records. He did not allow any part of his work to be affected by consideration for country, race, religion, family and the like. Here is the testament of Jadunath Sarkar, the historian:

> I would not care whether truth is pleasant or unpleasant, and in consonance with or opposed to current views. I would not mind in the least whether truth is or is not a blow to the glory of my country. If necessary, I shall bear in patience the ridicule and slander of friends and society for the sake of preaching truth. But still I shall seek truth, understand truth, and accept truth. This should be the firm resolve of a historian.[37]

Criticism

Yet Sarkar had his critics, though none could challenge the factual basis of his historical edifices nor accuse him of distorting facts. Irresponsible fault-finding apart, A.L. Srivastava cites three instances of criticism and tells us how the critics were silenced when facts were revealed to them.[38] 1. In assessing Aurangazeb's religious policy Sarkar omitted to mention the emperor's Benares *firman* making a grant of land to the Viswanath temple. Sarkar answered that Aurangazeb issued the specific *firman* during the war of succession when he was keen on getting Hindu support in capturing Shuja, and that it had nothing to do with his so-called desire to patronize Hindu religious institutions. 2. Another criticism was that Sarkar's description of Shivaji's murder of Afzal Khan as 'preventive murder' cannot be supported by decisive evidence. The historian answered that Afzal Khan was guilty of gripping Shivaji and striking the first blow on him with his belt dagger. This is clearly attested by Mir Alam, the famous *wazir* of Nizam ul-Mulk of Ahmadanagar, who was also a historian. 3. Sarkar's interpretation of the *jazia* was not considered fair. But Sarkar did not offer his own interpretation of the *jazia*, he had only summed up the 'agreed judgements' of the contemporary Muslim jurists. It was ludicrous, therefore, to attempt to exonerate Aurangazeb and Islam in the same breath. The general charge of bias against Islam and the Muslims brought against Sarkar is answered by C.C. David of Oxford. While reviewing the first volume of the *Fall of the Mughal Empire*, David wrote that the readers of his account of the atrocities of the Maratha raiders in northern India would agree that the belief that Jadunath Sarkar was biased against the Muslim rulers of medieval India was groundless.[39]

Jadunath Sarkar may be compared with Ranke and Momsen. He was unquestionably the greatest Indian historian of his time and one of the greatest in the world. His powerful personality and erudite works have established a tradition of honest and scholarly historiography whose tenets have exerted a healthy influence on many an individual historian.

8. S. Krishnaswami Aiyangar (1871–1953)

Krishnaswami Aiyangar had studied Physics and Mathematics before he changed to history in which he took the M.A. degree in 1899. In 1914 he was invited by the Madras University to head the Chair of Indian History and Archaeology it had created in that year. Aiyangar held this post till 1929.

Contributions of South India to Indian Culture

Professor Aiyangar's *Ancient India* is a collection of lectures on such topics as Gupta history, the Hun problem, the Vakatakas, and the Gurjara empire in north India. In his *Some Contributions of South India to Indian Culture*, Aiyangar emphasized the special character of south Indian culture. This special character could be observed in Brahman orthodoxy in its *vaidik* form and ritual. Modern Hinduism is the product of the union of ritualistic Brahmanism and theism in the form of *bhakti*. Aiyangar goes on to emphasize the considerable share of the south in the expansion of Indian trade and the spread of Indian culture. The distinctive stamp of the south could be observed in the matter of local administration, particularly as developed under the Cholas. And, finally, the south has preserved Indian religion and learning better than the north, a service which largely owed to Vijayanagar.

Problems of Chronology and Origins

Knotty problems of chronology and of 'origins' engaged Aiyangar's attention, and the chronological framework he has provided has been more or less accepted. The Sangam literature, being of a pre-Pallava character, he assigns to the early centuries of the Christian era. The literature of the Saiva and Vaishnava saints he regards as belonging to the age of the Pallavas. The Kalabhra interregnum in Pandya rule he assigns to a period after AD 300. He held that the Pallavas were not foreigners but probably a hereditary line of officers under the Satavahanas on whose decline they conquered the Kanchi region and set themselves up as independent rulers. Aiyangar gives perhaps the best account of the working of the self-governing bodies under the Cholas, and was the first Indian historian to describe the maritime relations of the imperial Cholas, for peace or war, with the Sailendra rulers of Malaya and Sumatra. Finally, in his two-volume *History of Tirupati*, Aiyangar, a Srivaishnava, produced an impartial account of the great shrine as having passed through phases of Jain, Buddhist and Saiva influence before it became a great shrine of Srivaishnava worship.

An Ideal of History

Krishnaswamy Aiyangar's struggle as the editor of the *Journal of Indian History* deserves to be gratefully remembered. Shafaat Ahmad Khan started the journal in 1921, but could not continue after the third volume. Aiyangar took it up but had to struggle hard in the face of financial difficulties until at last he was able to relieve himself of the great responsibility by persuading the Kerala University to take it over. By then, however, he had earned for the journal a recognized position in the world of historical scholarship.

Krishnaswami Aiyangar held that the value of the study of history would be destroyed by the slightest interference with the recording of its actual course, or if it is made to subserve other purposes however noble. For example, we cannot hope to end fanaticism in the character and convictions of the nation's youth by omitting from history all that which tends to promote sectarian fanaticism, and by telling the lying tale that there were no fanatics or acts of fanaticism before us. The right way to proceed is to register the fanatical acts and those influences which were responsible for the perpetration of fanatical deeds, and by pointing out the dire consequences to human society that such deeds entailed.[40]

9. Shafaat Ahmad Khan

Born in a middle class Pathan family of Moradabad, Shafaat Ahmad Khan went to England for higher studies. From 1920 to 1941, he was professor and head of the department of history of the Allahabad University. In 1941, he was appointed High Commissioner for India in South Africa. Khan had taken interest in Muslim communal politics before he became a liberal nationalist subscribing to the Congress ideology. A *persona non grata* with the orthodox Muslims, he fell a victim to communal frenzy when he was stabbed in Simla for his alliance with the Congress. He died not long after.[41]

Principal Works

In Shafaat Ahmad Khan's early death the academic world lost a brilliant historian—perhaps another Jadunath Sarkar. He was a historian of the Ranke-Acton line. The more important of his works are *East India Trade in the Seventeenth Century, Portugese Negotiations relating to Bombay 1660–67, Sources for the History of British India in the Seventeenth Century, John Marshall in India, Indian Federation and Federal Finance.*

The Anglo-Portugese Negotiations is an authentic account of the cession of Bombay by the Portugese to the English. Based on contemporary records the story is told in forceful language. "One of the shrewdest of men," writes Khan of Charles I, "he found himself tricked at every turn of the wheel by the subtle Portugese."[42] In his *East*

India Trade in the Seventeenth Century, Khan tries to prove that the theory of mercantalism which was being developed in England had East India trade at its base. England was turning itself into a 'commercial state' imposing a series of restrictive measures against its principal commercial rivals, planting colonies, extending commerce and utilizing the navy for such functions. The narrative, though centred on English trade, brings out the power of the Mughal state which prevented the exploitation of the Indian soil for the Company's political-commercial aggressiveness.[43] Khan was a firm believer in the national unity of India which he stressed in his books *Indian Federation* and *Federal Finance.*

History and Historiography

Shafaat Ahmad Khan outlined his conception of history and

historiography in his two Sayaji Rao lectures on 'History and Historians of British India' delivered at the University of Baroda in 1938.[44] The functions of a historian are those of a judge. He should be free from influence of theories and prepossessions; he should be free alike from the war-cries of the politicians and the special pleadings of the partisan. In a country like India with its clash of races and interests, temptation to partiality and exaggeration are serious. The scholar is cautioned against the temptation to mix up history and politics. Though a historian of the Ranke-Acton line believing in the sanctity of documents, Khan said in conclusion that history was not merely a study of the documents, but involved a deep study of the subconscious impulses of the age. The mystical qualities of a born leader cannot be deciphered from moth-eaten documents and mouldy parchments. History should narrate not only thoughts of the rulers, but also the feelings and sentiments of the ruled.

10. An Explanation of the Lack of Historical Works by Muslims on Medieval Muslim India

British and Hindu historians had written in English on medieval Muslim India but no Muslim historian had worked on that area until the 1920s. Peter Hardy attempts an explanation of this time lag:[45] (a) Despite Syed Ahmad Khan's interest in Indo-Muslim history his principal preoccupation after his return from England in 1870 was religious rather than historical. He and his followers were attempting to arm Islam against Western criticism (and not against either the British or the non-Muslims of India) by interpreting the faith in terms of the science and liberal values of the West. This trend set by Khan continued after his death until the First World War. (b) Hardy suggests that in the years after the Mutiny and the banishment of Bahadur Shah II the problem for the Muslims was one of conciliating the British. It would have been unwise to remind the world of the power which Muslims in India enjoyed in the medieval period, a course which would only serve to provoke British fears of Muslim disloyalty. (c) Furthermore, writes Hardy, Syed Ahmad Khan and the Aligarh school were resolutely non-communal in politics. To study the history of medieval India with its literal reliance on 'authorities' could only provoke Hindus whose cowardly ancestors were, in medieval Muslim histories, usually being sent to hell, and Muslims whose virile ancestors were always doing the dispatching. Primarily educationists, Khan and the Aligarh school would do nothing to prevent the growth of a sense of nationhood between Hindus and Muslims, transcending religious differences. (d) Finally, before 1914, the history curriculum of the Aligarh University emphasized the study of English and European history rather than medieval Muslim history. Only in Western history could Muslims discover the new world pressing in upon them.

Muhammad Habib

The first modern Indian Muslim to study a subject pertaining to medieval Muslim India was Muhammad Habib. Habib had gone to Oxford and read modern history between 1916 and 1920.

His *Mahmud of Ghaznin* had the definite aim of correcting a tendency among Indian Muslims to adore Mahmud of Ghazni as a saint. Mahmud, according to Habib, represented an Islam which by the eleventh century had become corrupt. Habib sees Mahmud as a hero "enjoying power without morality and waging war in India not for religion but for the greed of glory and gold,"[46] plundering temples which is not sanctioned by the *shariat. Jehad* or holy war against the infidel covered the real aim of plunder. It was a cry ready at hand for any ambitious Muslim leader in the Middle Ages to inspire his followers to deeds of heroism, valor and sacrifice. Mahmud does not deserve to be called a true Muslim, for Islam does not sanction what he did in India.

Introduction to the Reprint of Elliot and Dowson

Habib's introduction to a reprint of Elliot and Dowson's *History of India* (Volume 2, 1952) is based upon the "principles of Historical Materialism developed to suit the conditions of the East and in particular of India."[47] These principles emphasized the importance of revolutions in the progress of mankind. Revolution may occur at the production level as when a new invention changes the whole structure of society, or at the ideological level as when the rise of Islam posed a moral challenge to existing social institutions. Those who count most in history are the

masses — the worker and the peasant — who from the dawn of history have been exploited by the governing classes who live by depriving the workers of the surplus value of their labor. Force, which in Marx's phrase, "is the midwife of every society pregnant with a new one," though wicked, cannot be dismissed, in human life. "Islam wrought one of the most vital and the most bloodless revolutions in human history....Medina under the Prophet was a working-class republic....There was no governing class and no subject people."[48]

Urban and Rural Revolution in Northern India

Under the heading 'The Urban Revolution in Northern India 'Habib says that the Turkish Muslim government of early medieval India was neither foreign nor military. The Ghorian Turks replaced the *thakurs* as the governing class and then enfranchised the Indian city-workers who had been obliged to live outside the city walls by the caste Hindus. The Turks emancipated them and this explains their success in maintaining their rule against foreign (Mongol) and domestic enemies alike. Muhammad Habib writes:

> The post-revolutionary Indians were in no mood to be conquered. The Indian worker with his newly-won freedom...was determined to fight it out in every city and in every street. So India alone was able to stand against the Mongol invasions, which had shattered every state power in east and west. And this new-found strength was entirely due to the urban revolution in northern India.[49]

Habib continues in his rhapsodic vein to inform us that the urban revolution was followed by a rural revolution when the Sultan Ala ud-Din Khalji relieved the 'low'-caste cultivator from the oppression of the 'high'-caste intermediary.

> India would never again become the land of caste privileges it had been for some centuries past...Ala al-din had assured one thing for all time....In all spheres of life, except marriage and personal laws, India would become what the *Manusmriti* so intensely hated "a confusion of castes."[50]

KM. Ashraf

How fine would Muhammad Habib's story be – the story of an urban revolution followed by a rural revolution sponsored by the Turkish (and Turko-Afghan) rulers of medieval India – were it only true! In dealing with the same period of Muslim Turkish rule in India (1200–1500), K.M. Ashraf does not conjure up any such revolution. He could see no fundamental revolution wrought by Islam in the basic conditions of Indian life.

Ashraf's *Life and Conditions of the People of Hindustan 1200–1500* (1935), deals with the status, habits and standard of life of different classes of people in the area of the Delhi Sultanate, although it leaves out matters like the administration, army, land revenue, transport, education, literature and religion. The work considers the Sultan both as a public and as a private person, the nobility, domestics and slaves, the artisans and cultivators, and goes on to the clothing, food, amusements, virtues and vices of the various classes—emphasizing all the time what is shared by Hindus and Muslims. Secular and non-communal in outlook Ashraf views social classes in economic terms as 'haves' and 'have-nots', not in terms of religious allegiance. He concludes that the introduction of Islam was not a "fundamental revolution in the basic conditions of Indian life.... There was no cultural conflict between the Muslims and the Hindus. In fact the cultural forces were rapidly leading to a complete fusion between the two."[51] Peter Hardy comments: "The picture is not dynamic but static; the work is an essay in dissection of a corpse not in description of a living, moving, changing organism."[52]

Muhammad Nazim

Without any analysis of economic, social or religious factors, without any unity of chronology or theme, Muhammad Nazim's *The Life and Times of Sultan Mahmud of Ghazna* (1931) has few merits. Nazim's one aim is to exonerate Mahmud of Ghazni from the charge of fanaticism and to show that his wars in India were not those of a predatory iconoclast, but part of a programme of conquests and annexations. Mahmud was not a fanatic for he "is never said to have demolished a temple in time of peace,"[53] that is to say, if we may add, when he was not in India! Nazim is certain that Mahmud was not a fanatic, but believing in the religious unity of the state he severely punished all dissenters.[54] Mahmud treated the Hindus as an imperialist rather than as a missionary or a crusader and as such they cannot have any real cause for complaint.

The Hindus rejected Islam as their national religion because of the fundamental and irreconcilable differences between Islam and Hinduism.

Ishtiaq Husain Qureshi

Peter Hardy observes that Ishtiaq Husain Qureshi's *The Administration of the Sultanate of Delhi* (1942) emphasizes the Sultanate's Islamic than its Indian character, and that the approach is strongly communalist.[55] The author treats the Delhi sultanate as a welfare state and believes that it more than satisfied modern ideas of tolerance, benevolence and efficiency. The Hindus were not ill-treated. Qureshi claims that, The Hindu population was better off under the Muslims than under Hindu tributaries or under independent rulers….Nor was the Hindu despised socially. The Muslims, generally speaking, have been remarkably free from racial prejudice. There are instances of Muslim nobles marrying Hindu maidens; of free intercourse between Muslim saints and Hindu yogis; of Hindu followers of Muslim

saints and *vice versa*...it was Hinduism which protected itself beneath the strong armour of exclusiveness. The Muslim was unclean; his very touch polluted the food of the twice-born Brahman and men of the higher castes; the new-comer was outside the pale.[56]

Zahir ud-din Faruki

A graduate of Aligarh University, Zahir ud-din Faruki went to England to qualify in law. Faruki's *Aurangazeb and his Times* (1935) is an avowed apology for Aurangazeb and is mainly directed against Sir Jadunath Sarkar's *History ofAuragazeb*. To Faruki—Aurangazeb was the savior of Islam in India after Akbar had surrendered its outer defences; political and not religious considerations moved Aurangazeb in his treatment of the Hindus; he destroyed Hindu temples and levied *jizya* merely in order to preserve Mughal domination; it was not Aurangazeb who antagonized the Hindus, it was the Hindus who antagonized Aurangazeb; and a truly Islamic monarch could not but be a just monarch. The book is evidently inspired by Amir Ali's *Spirit of Islam*.[57]

S.M. Jaffar

S.M. Jaffar's *The Mughal Empire from Babur to Aurangazeb* (1936), writes Peter Hardy,

> ...is a very clear example of an unresolved tension between Islam and Indian nationalism in some 'South Asian' Muslims in the nineteen thirties....However, should the choice be obligatory...there is evidence in this book that he would choose to be a Muslim first.[58]

Blaming false history for the lack of national unity and communal amity, Jaffar's book offers what the author thinks to be a correct interpretation of the respective policies of Akbar and Aurangazeb. Akbar was a liberal nationalist. His *Din Ilahi* which had national unity as its aim was a political code cleverly designed to attract the entire population. The Hindus, Muslims, Zoroastrians and Christians could find in that chameleon of a faith the tenets and practices of their own respective faith. It was to be a universal religion for India. Yet, Akbar was not an apostate from Islam, for he was not sincere in his *Din Ilahi*.

> In a land where the very word "Muslim" was an eyesore to the natives, Akbar thought it expedient to subscribe to the beliefs of his Hindu subjects in spite of their hollowness Whereas, in fact, he always concealed his religious identity in byways and corners.[59]

Garlic and onions and the wearing of beads were forbidden not because Akbar was an apostate from Islam but because they were inconvenient in kissing. Jaffar's serious writing at times means fun for the readers.

Jaffar writes about Aurangazeb:

> The lot of the subjugated has never been happier than under the ruling races of Islam....Alamgir was tolerant...and to a fairly high degree, but not so tolerant as Akbar and Dara who, in order to achieve their ulterior political aims, concealed their religious identities and even subscribed to the religion of the ruled....[60]

Jaffar affirms that Aurangazeb would have continued the tolerant policy of his predecessors if he had not discovered that it was
impossible to reconcile the Rajputs to his rule. Then he refused to rely on them and rallied around him his own co-religionists with whose help he succeeded in crushing his enemies.

Modern Muslim Historiography on Medieval Muslim India: An Assessment

Tension between the National and Islamic Identities

K.M. Ashraf has written that in medieval India the cultural forces represented by Hinduism and Islam "were rapidly leading to a complete fusion between the two." But in general terms modern Indian Muslim historiography on medieval Muslim India reveals what Peter Hardy calls "an unresolved tension between Islam and Indian nationalism...in the nineteen thirties."[61] It is seen in the works of Muhammad Nazim, Ishtiaq Husain Qureshi, Zahir ud-din Faruki and S.M. Jaffar.

Islamic Apologetic

Peter Hardy observes that modern Muslim historiography on medieval India has chiefly taken the form of an Islamic apologetic justifying the life of medieval Muslims to the modern world. It could be seen in an abundance of value judgements and a desire to establish that whatever Muslims did in medieval India was right if not in terms of religion then in terms of politics.[62]

Medieval Politics

The interest of modern Muslim historians on medieval India is overwhelmingly centered on politics. Muhammad Habib's work on mystics and Faruki's work on Shaikh Ahmad of Sarhind are exceptions. Peter Hardy thinks that Syed Ahmad and Amir Ali are the influence behind this comparative neglect of religion among the English-educated Muslim intelligentsia. Instead of trying to get a sympathetic insight into the religious experience of the medieval Muslim, this school stood for a reinterpretation of the Prophet's thought for today in a militant spirit.[63]

Consciousness of Islam as Way of Life and Thought

The same intense consciousness of Islam as the unique, vital, final way of life and thought seems to have been carried over from medieval Muslim historiography by modern Muslim historians of medieval India. Muhammad Habib wrote even in his Marxian strain that "The Quranic conception of God was, and can still be, a revolutionary force of incalculable value for the attainment of human welfare."[64] Peter Hardy comments:

> There is the same inarticulate premises that the writing of history should justify the ways of Muslims to men. There is the same assumption that history is purposive, teleological; there is the same urge towards a universal schematic view of history....The significant feature of Professor Habib's Marxist interpretation of medieval Indian history is not that Marxism has absorbed Islam but that Islam has absorbed Marxism.[65]

11. Surendranath Sen (1890–1962)

One of the most eminent historians of modern India, Surendranath Sen's chief interest lay in Maratha history. To explore source material in original he made a careful study of the Marathi, Persian and Portuguese languages. Leaving the beaten track of political history he chose institutions for his historical investigation. In this he was a pathfinder for later researchers.

Sen's first major work *The Administrative System of the Marathas*, challenged the British-sponsored view that the Marathas were only plunderers. The work demonstrated that they were capable of building administrative institutions consistent with their social and political traditions. Complementary to the *Administrative System* was the *Military System of the Marathas* which Sen wrote during his residence at Oxford. The subject being a comparatively new field for Indian historians, Sen read the standard English works on military history, particularly those relating to the Peninsular war. He made an extensive tour of Spain and Portugal in search of new material on Maratha history in the Portugese archives, and also to understand how military movements are affected by the terrain. Anil Chandra Banerji writes:

> His labours gave him a rich dividend. Judged as a whole, the *Military System* ranks higher than the *Administrative System* as a scholarly performance—A pioneer work on military history, the *Military System* gives interesting clues to the understanding of Maratha history and remains without a rival to this day.[66]

Sen's *India through Chinese Eyes* originally formed the theme of his Sir William Meyer lectures at the Madras University. The book threw new light on the subject. Finally, no event in British Indian history had provoked more feeling and bitterness than the Revolt of 1857, that to write an objective, dispassionate account of it was an almost impossible task. But when in 1955, Maulana Azad, free India's Minister for Education, invited Sen to write a new history of the struggle of 1857, he accepted the assignment. Though a government-sponsored work, the author acknowledged that there was no attempt at interference and that his work was "not an 'authorised version' in any sense."[67] *Eighteen Fifty Seven*, Sen's last major work, refused to idealize the Mutiny as a 'national war' except in two regions, Oudh and Shahabad; at the same time it refused to dismiss it as a mere military rising. Apart from the feelings roused, the main methodological difficulty in writing an account of the Mutiny is the 'one-sidedness' of the sources which are overwhelmingly British. Sen had to extract the Indian version from scattered materials, such as the papers of Maulvi Rajab Ali, Munshi Jiwanlal's *Diary* of the events of the Mutiny in Delhi, the account of Kedarnath, etc. Sen's narration is above the pale of controversy and his analysis and assessment have set up a high standard of historical objectivity.

12. Sardar K.M. Panikkar (1895–1963)

A man of ideas and many abilities, K.M. Panikkar had a rich and varied career. But his passion was history which he wrote profusely. Sardar Panikkar died in 1963.

In 1922, while teaching at the Aligarh University, Panikkar wrote the monograph *Sri Harsha of Kanauj*. Panikkar's picture of Harsha is that of an enlightened monarch who "deserves to be considered among India's greatest rulers."[68] *The Origin and Evolution of Kingship in India* (1938) which was a series of lectures delivered at the invitation of the Baroda State aimed at dispelling the notion among European scholars that political thought – the inquiry into the phenomenon of the state – was foreign to the ancient Indian genius. His *Malabar and the Portugese* and *Malabar and the Dutch* (1931) are complementary works tracing the history of Europe's connection with India's west coast from the beginning of the sixteenth to the end of the eighteenth century.

Sardar Panikkar was the first, and perhaps the only Indian, who studied history from the geographical and the geopolitical angle. In his *India and the Indian Ocean* (1945), he claimed that India never lost its independence till it lost command of the sea in the first decade of the sixteenth century. The book proceeds to trace the influence of the Indian Ocean on the shaping of Indian history and to discuss the vital importance of oceanic control to the future of India.

In the introduction to the *Geographical Factors in Indian History* (1955), Panikkar wrote that "geography constitutes the permanent basis of every nation's history,"[69] and that "both the internal policies of a country and its

external relations are governed largely by the unalterable geographical conditions and their relationship in space to other countries."[70] The role of the Himalayas and the sea as basic elements in the evolution of Indian life and outlook can hardly be overemphasized. A country like India needs "both a continental view and an appreciation of sea-power."[71]

In 1947 came *A Survey of Indian History* which soon became a popular favorite appearing nine times in print in seven years. In about two hundred and fifty pages the author gives the reader an idea of the national heritage of the Indians through five thousand years of development. Panikkar takes trouble to remove certain misconceptions. Foreign writers have attempted to show that there never was an entity called 'India', and that anything good or great in India must have had a foreign origin. The doctrine of the Aryan origin of Indian civilization which finds no support in Indian literature is the result of the theories of the Indo-Germanic scholars who held that everything valuable in the world originated from the Aryans. Indian civilization had a pre-Vedic origin. The division of Indian history into clearly marked periods – Buddhist-Hindu, Muslim, British – has little meaning. And the *Survey* is not a political or dynastic history, for the Sardar aimed at portraying the life of the people. In this portrayal he emphasizes the Aryo-Dravidian synthesis beginning at the end of the Rig Vedic age that created Indian civilization, a synthesis perfected in the life of the mind, but never attempted on the racial level. In this survey of the national evolution of the Indians, the author perceives an undeniable fact of decadence in Hindu life, a certain undermining of the national vigor, in the ninth, tenth and eleventh centuries. The fact of decadence is attested to not only by the breakdown of northern India before the onslaughts of the Turks but also by the corruption of religion, arrested progress in science, and the obscene literature and temple sculpture of the period. An incurable complacency and overweening pride took the place of thought and progress, a fact noted by the shrewd Al-Biruni.

Panikkar's *Asia and Western Dominance*, published in 1953, took the academic world by storm. Translated into many a European language notwithstanding papal prohibition, the book raised the Sardar to world rank as a historian. It is a critical survey of Europe's contact with Asian states during what the author calls 'the Vasco da Gama epoch of Asian history' (1498–1945). Control of the sea enabled the Europeans to extend their economic and political power over Asia. The imposition of Europe's commercial economy and political dominion eventually brought about a silent revolution in almost every aspect of Asian life. Asia's contact with the West created a mental ferment which roused the continent from its long slumber. The Western-educated intellectuals of Asia assumed leadership of their respective countries and liberated them from Western domination. But the liberation itself, in Panikkar's view, owed to the vitality of the old religion and culture of the different Asian countries which defeated the Christianization attempted by the Western religious missions.

Assessment

Looking at India's past as an Indian, Sardar Panikkar completely broke away from the tradition of British historiography on India. But he was not that type of nationalist historian who praised everything Indian. Using every kind of source and examining even legends, his was not record-oriented research of the orthodox type. Heavy scholarship does not sit upon his works; they are rather moved by bright ideas. Believing that "the history of a country has little value unless it deals with the conscious effort of a people to achieve a civilization, to reach better standards, to live a happier and nobler life,"[72] he gave us a new kind of cultural history holding up the national heritage.

Critics have discerned an amount of subjectivity, a pronounced Hindu bias, in his assertions though few have been able to challenge their validity in national experience.

> Indian history is of necessity, predominantly the history of the Hindu people, for though other and potent elements have become permanent factors in India, the Hindus still constitute over eighty per cent of her population. Besides, what is distinctly Indian has so far been Hindu. Islamic contribution is not specially related to India and is a part of a world culture to which Muslims belong....In essence, therefore, the history of Indian effort towards the building up and maintenance of a specially Indian civilization has to be the history of the Hindu mind and its achievements.[73]

The following passage questions the charge against Panikkar of bias against the Muslims:

> Even in regard to religion the idea that Hinduism was always held in contempt by the early Muslim rulers would not bear examination. In fact we have ample evidence that even under the most bigoted kings like Allauddin Khilji, the Hindu religious leaders received honour and recognition. From Jain sources we know that Allauddin held religious discourses with Acharya Mahasena who had to be brought from the Karnataka country for the purpose. It is also said that the Digambara Jain, Purna Chandra of Delhi, and the Swetambara ascetic Ramachandra Suri were in favour with the same Sultan. Ghiasuddin Tughlaq had two Jain officers who exercised great influence over him, while Firuz held in high honour the poet Ratnasekhara.[74]

13. K.A. Nilakanta Sastri (1892–1975)

The greatest and the most prolific among the professional historians of south India, K.A Nilakanta Sastri, succeeded Krishnaswamy Aiyangar as professor of Indian history and archeology at the Madras University, a position which he held with distinction till his retirement in 1947. From 1957 to 1971 he was director of the Institute of Traditional Cultures of South East Asia set up by the UNESCO. Sastri died in 1975.

Works

Nilakanta Sastri published about twenty-five historical works. Though his special field was the history of south India he wrote several works of a general nature. Such were the *History of India* in 3 volumes (1950–53), *Life and Culture of the Indian People* (1966), and *An Advanced History of India* (1970). Of these, the second and the third were co-authored with G. Sreenivasachari. Sastri not only edited but wrote several chapters of the collaborative *The Age of the Nandas and Mauryas* (1952), and the second volume of *A Comprehensive History of India: Mauryas and Satavahanas. Aspects of Indian History and Culture* (1974) is one of the two volumes of the more important of the articles written by him, while *South India and South East Asia* (1978) is the other volume of collected articles. *History of Srivijaya* (1949), and *South Indian Influences in the Far East* (1949) won for Sastri a respectable place in Southeast Asian historiography.

Yet, Nilakanta Sastri's special field was South Indian history, a comparatively neglected area of Indian historiography. "Attention has been concentrated too long," wrote V.A. Smith, "on the North, on Sanskrit books, and on Indo-Aryan notions. It is time that due regard should be paid to the non-Aryan element."[75] Even before Smith, Sundaran Pillai had remarked: "The scientific historian of India ought to begin his study with the basin of the Krishna, of the Kaveri, of the Vaigai, rather than with the Gangetic plain, as has been now long, too long, the fashion."[76]

Sastri's predecessor in office in the Madras Univesity, Krishnaswami Aiyangar, had made a beginning in south Indian history. Yet even its general outlines were so little known that Sastri thought they deserved to be set forth at some length. Knowing that the scientific study and interpretation of the sources of south Indian history – epigraphic, numismatic and literary – had got but little beyond the elementary stage, Sastri spent much time and academic labor on working out a dependable chronological framework. But a chronological framework by its very nature could not be built up except by fixing the details of political history. This emphasis on chronology and political history was to become a distinguishing feature of Nilakanta Sastri's works. Not that he was oblivious of the importance of economic, social, religious and cultural history, but the reconstructions of these aspects could be held together only if they could be fitted into a political and chronological mould.

The great corpus of his works on south India include the following: *Pandyan Kingdom* (1929); *Studies in Chola History and Administration* (1933); two volumes of *The Cholas* (1935–37); lengthy chapters on the history of the Chalukyas of Badami and of Kalyani in the *Early History of the Deccan*, (the first two volumes edited by Ghulam Yazdani), were definite contributions to the political history of ancient Deccan; *Foreign Notices of South India from Megasthenes to Ma Huan* (1939), which is a source book enriched with useful notes; the three-volume *Further Sources of Vijayanagar History* (1946), which is a collaborative work with N. Venkataramanayya; the *Tamil Kingdoms of South India* (1948); *A History of South India* (1955); *Historical Method in Relation to South Indian History*, with H.S. Ramanna for co-author; *Development of Religion in South India* (1963); the *Culture and History of the Tamils* (1963); *Cultural Contacts between Aryans and Dravidians* (1967); and *Sangam Literature: its Cults and Cultures* (1972).

The Cholas and A History of South India

Sastri's first significant historical work was the *Pandyan Kingdom.* It was followed by his celebrated works on the Cholas: *Studies in Chola History and Administraiton* and *The Cholas.* A revised edition of this second work, published in one volume in 1955 became Sastri's *magnum opus.* Only with great effort would such masses of details have been collected from the thousands of Chola records, and with great craft and care their confusing evidence would have been systematized to present a meaningful picture of south Indian history during the four centuries of Chola rule. Chronology and politics take up half the work, the other half being devoted to the socio-economic and cultural aspects of Chola rule. But the most significant work which Sastri published during the 1950s was *A History of South India* (1955). The book presents a general survey of the history of south India from pre-historic times to the fall of Vijayanagar. That it has gone into several editions testifies to its undimmed quality. Political history is accorded the highest honor though socioeconomic conditions, literature, religion, philosophy and art receive due attention.

Assessment

"Hitherto," observed Vincent Smith, "most historians of ancient India have written as if the South did not exist."[77] In general histories of India this "integral and not the least interesting part of the history of India"[78] figured in a small way. But the south did not have for Sastri any narrowly regional or isolationist connotation and he was always careful to present its history as an integral part of the history of the subcontinent. "We mean by South India," he wrote, "all the land lying south of Vindhyas *Dakshina* (the Deccan) in the widest sense of the term."[79] Romila

Thapar has rightly observed, though in a different context, that such histories of restricted geographical areas have "corrected the tendency to generalize about the entire Indian subcontinent on the basis of the history of the Ganges heartland."[80] Cultural patterns are likely to differ in a geographical area as large as the Indian subcontinent where historical change need not be identical nor occur simultaneously. "Nilakanta Sastri's work on South Indian history," says Thapar, "created a new awareness of the history of the subcontinent by bringing the history of the south into perspective. "[81]

14. R.C. Majumdar (1888–1980)

After Jadunath Sarkar the best known of the older generation of Indian historians and one of international fame was Romesh Chandra Majumdar. He was Vice-President of the International Commission for a *History of the Scientific and Cultural Development of Mankind* set up by the UNESCO, and chief editor of the Bharatiya Vidhya Bhavan's monumental eleven-volume *The History and Culture of the Indian People.*

Works

With a rare command over the materials of all the different phases of Indian history in their meticulous detail, and also of the pre-European period of Southeast Asian history and culture, Majumdar passed from area to area until he had authored a corpus of historical works of outstanding merit. The more important of this corpus are: *Corporate Life in Ancient India, Outline of Ancient Indian History and Civilization*, the three-volume *Ancient IndianColonies in the Far East, A History of Bengal, Classical Accounts of India*, the collaborative *An Advanced History of India, Penal Settlements in the Andamans, History of the Freedom Movement, The Sepoy Mutiny and the Revolt of 1857*, and contributions to the *History and Culture of the Indian People*.

Majumdar began with his doctoral thesis entitled *Corporate Life in Ancient India* (1918). In the introduction to the printed edition of this lucid, comprehensive work he makes an important point that "religion did not engross the whole or even an undue proportion of the public attention..." of the ancient Indians,[82] His *Outline of Ancient Indian History and Civilization* (1927) is projected on a large canvas. The work went into six editions till 1971. Majumdar's *Early History of Bengal* developed into a substantial cooperative work, *A History of Bengal*, in two volumes (1943). Extending his field, Majumdar embarked on exploring the history and culture of the Indianized states of Southeast Asia. The endeavor bore fruit in a major three-volume work, *Ancient Indian Colonies in the Far East.* Apart from its intrinsic merit, the work is also valuable in having made available to those unacquainted with French or Dutch, a systematic account of ancient Indian effort in Southeast Asia through a thousand years of its history. Majumdar has been charged of a nationalistic (imperialistic) point of view for describing, like Nilakanta Sastri, the Indianized states of Southeast Asia as 'Hindu colonies'. In this connection H.B. Sarkar points out that N.J. Krom, who has furnished a good exposition of that phenomenon of Indianization, used the term 'Hindu-Javanese' in his description of Javan culture, stressing the Indian component of that culture; in the tenth century of the Christian era when Islam was not yet a political or cultural force in the region, one could hardly think of Southeast Asia of the time without the Indian art of writing, literature, law books, statecraft, deification of monarchs, royal paraphernalia, Indian religion, social system, art and architecture.[83] Likewise G. Coedes observes:

> It [South East Asia] has not entered history except to the extent that it was civilized by India. Without India its past would be always unknown: we would know scarcely more about it than we know about the past of New Guinea or Australia.[84]

In view of all this H.B. Sarkar does not think that Majumdar was unjustified in using the term 'colony' in the sense of 'cultural colony' and not 'political domination'.

In his work on the Great Revolt of 1857, Majumdar did not treat that event as a national war of independence. He stressed the point that the most important section that fought the British were the sepoys who were inspired more by the hopes of material gain than by national, political or even religious considerations. He wrote that "the miseries and bloodshed of 1857–58 were not the birth pangs of the freedom movement in India, but the dying process of an obsolete aristocracy and centrifugal feudalism of the medieval age."[85] Yet, Majumdar maintains that the great event of 1857 had an indirect and posterior importance. It became a symbol of challenge to the mighty British power in India and was duly invested with the full glory of the first national war of independence.

Majumdar was co-author with K.K. Datta and H.C. Raychaudhuri of *An Advanced History of India,* intended for advanced students of Indian History. From its first appearance in 1946 up till 1980, it has come out in four new editions and fifteen reprints. The *History and Culture of the Indian People* in eleven major volumes is monumental in its conception, dimension and execution. Majumdar not only edited this work but also contributed many of its more important chapters on political history. Some of the volumes have gone into several editions. With the

completion of this great project our historian's life's task ended.

Hindu—Muslim Relations[86]

Writing about Hindu—Muslim relations during the Sultanate of Delhi – in Volume Four of the *History and Culture of the Indian people* – Majumdar sees an uncompromising spirit of animosity between the two communities. Living for generations as close neighbors, reciprocal relations were too superficial and touched merely the fringe of life. The ultra-democratic social ideas of the Muslims, an object lesson of equality and fraternity, did not make any impact on Hindu social rigidity and attitude of inequality among men exemplified in the caste system and untouchability. Nor did the Muslims imbibe the Hindu spirit of tolerance and reverence for all religions. They did not moderate their zeal to destroy the Hindu temples and images of gods. The Hindu was

zimmi—a being protected by the Muslim state on condition of rendering certain service and suffering certain political and civil disabilities.

History Writing

Majumdar's Heras Memorial lectures (1967) may be taken as a summary of his ideas on history writing. A historian of the Rankean school, he attached the greatest importance to facts. A master of analysis and interpretation, he tried to remove subjectivity from historical explanation. He refused to subordinate facts to yield any principle or illustrate any philosophy or ideology. Majumdar adhered, and urged others to adhere, to the Rankean dictum that the task of the historian was 'merely to show what really happened.' The ascertainment of the truth of the past, so far as it can be ascertained, is the one object, the one sanction, of all historical studies. He felt uneasy about the deteriorating standards and what he thought to be the evils growing in our historical studies. In his Presidential Address prepared for the sixth annual conference of the Institute of Historical Studies held at Srinagar in 1968 which, however, he could not attend, he wrote:

> ...history, divorced from truth, does not help a nation. Its future should be laid on the stable foundations of truth and not on the quicksands of falsehood, however alluring it may appear at present. India is now at the cross-roads and I urge my young friends to choose carefully the path they would like to tread upon.[87]

16

I. THE MARXIST PHASE

The New History[1]

In the post-independence period in India a kind of history developed, which was also deeply rooted in the writings of the nationalist historians, and which owed its birth to an interest in Marxism. By the Marxist Phase (of historians) is not meant that the writers were all Marxists but that they more or less adopted materialistic interpretation as a method of understanding the historical phenomena. Some saw that history, particularly ancient history, can best be studied within the framework of a social science discipline. Their interpretation derived from the historical philosophy of Karl Marx, particularly dialectical materialism. The essence of the new approach lies in the study of the relationship between social and economic organization and its effect on historical events. The new trend called not so much for new evidence as for a re-reading of the sources with a different set of questions in mind. It is best exemplified in the work of Damodar Dharmanand Kosambi, the patriarch of the Marxist school of Indian historiography.

1. D.D. Kosambi (1907–1966)

No single writer after James Mill and Vincent Smith has so deeply influenced the writing of Indian history as Damodar Dharmanand Kosambi. Dying rather prematurely Kosambi left behind him besides several papers and articles, the following major works: *An Introduction to the Study of Indian History* (1956), *The Culture and Civilization of Ancient India in Historical Outline* (1965), *Exasperating Essays: Exercises in the Dialetical Method*, and *Myth and Reality: Studies in the Formation of Indian Culture*. Of these, the first two works revolutionized Indian historiography.

A New Definition of History

The greatest impediment to any study of ancient India is the lack of reliable records and a dependable chronology to go on. For this reason, Kosambi tells us, the direct procedure of history writing in the old European tradition would be futile. But we may know how men lived in those distant times, times for which formal forms of sources and evidence are absent. Man would not have always lived in the same manner, particularly when he advanced by slow degrees from the food-gathering quasi-animal stage to that of food production, which definitely raised him above a mere animal existence. As Gordon Childe says with aphoristic brevity and precision, ‘man makes himself’. Man makes himself by making and using tools and implements in order to live increasingly well at the expense of his environment. It follows then that there must have been a change in his life whenever there was a change in the quantity and quality of his tools or the means of material production. This change is historically verifiable as, for instance, from the “comparatively sudden increase in the human population with every important basic discovery in the means of production.”[2] Means of material production determine social organization which cannot be more advanced than the former. This fact of human life, that is, the intrinsic connection between man’s life and the means of production at his disposal – the former changing *pari passu* (with equal pace) with the latter – constitutes the theme and method of history. Kosambi now offers his definition of history as *“the presentation, in chronological order, of successive developments in the means and relations of production.”*[3] The definition implies a definite theory of history known as dialectical materialism or Marxism, a classic statement of which appears in Karl Marx’s preface to his *Critique of Political Economy.* “Certainly,” says Kosambi, “this is the only definition known which will allow a reasonable treatment of preliterate history, generally termed pre-history.”[4]

The Comparative Method

To reconstruct ancient Indian history Kosambi employs combined methods or the comparative method and interdisciplinary techniques of investigation. Seeing that India abounded in living survivals of the dead past he would notice material relics of that past laid bare by archeology—houses, grave-goods, instruments of production and utensils of household use, groves, stones marking sacrificial ritual, caves and rock shelters; then the religious and social practice even of modern Indians; and, finally, primitive human types. From such ‘primary sources’ which no library can provide, he would work back to the productive relations and social organization of people of bygone ages. Certain types of joint burials for him indicated whether the society represented was in the matriarchal, patriarchal or the pre-clan stage. Tribal clusters living in and around highly developed areas and cities suggested to him the absorption of the tribes into all strata of a caste society. The red pigment still adorning the vast majority of the countryside deities in India is a relic of the long-vanished blood sacrifice. Caves and rock shelters may have

been occupied successively by prehistoric men, Buddhist monks and practitioners of Hindu cults. And even highly educated Indians today do not suspect that some of the religious and social rites they practise have behind them millennia of continuity.

Kosambi turned his knowledge of Sanskrit and etymological analysis in that language to good account in reconstructing the social background of the Vedic period. Since the language of the Vedic texts pointed to an admixture of the Aryan and non-Aryan elements, he thought it likely that non-Aryans must also have been taken into the fold of the Brahmans whose original seven *gotras* must have been of mixed Aryan and non-Aryan priests.[5] He philologically equated the Hittite *khatti* with the Sanskrit *kshatriya* and the Pali *khettiyo.* Knowledge of mathematics enabled him to weigh with the utmost precision large numbers of punch-marked coins which were in use between c. 500 to 100 BC. Kosambi's extensive field work on microlithic sites and artefacts enabled him to mark the routes which herders, pastoralists and incipient traders would have taken across the western Deccan in the prehistoric period.[6] Geographical, topographical and geomorphological pointers guided him to indicate some of the urban sites and Buddhist monastic centers especially in the western Deccan during the first millennium AD. The study of cultural survivals using ethnological and anthropological material is best illustrated in the pages of *An Introduction to the Study of Indian History.*

From Tribe to Caste

Kosambi maintained that one of the clues to an understanding of the Indian past is the factor of the transition from tribe to caste—from small localized groups to a generalized society. This transition was largely the result of the introduction of plough agriculture in various regions which changed the system of production, broke the structure of tribes and clans, and made caste the alternative form of social organization.[7] Indicative of such a change is the evolution of clan totems into clan names and then into caste names. Brahmanical settlement in various parts of the country was the agency through which plough agriculture was introduced. They led to the assimilation of local cults into the Brahamanical tradition and to the Sanskritization of local folk cults.

Interpretation of Myths

Interpretation of myths is essential to any study of early cultures.[8] The story of Pururavas and Urvasi, Kosambi thought, reflected the institution of sacred marriage in prehistoric societies as well as the ritual sacrifice of the hero by the mother goddess. He believed that societies were largely matriarchal in origin but many changed into patriliny, and myths therefore reflected the transition from the one to the other. Bride-price is for him a survival of matriliny. However, we may observe that the transition may not have uniformly been from matriliny to patriliny since many societies are known to have been patrilineal from the beginning.

The Indus Civilization

The earliest of the transitions from tribe to caste, Kosambi thought, occurred in the Indus Valley. He assumed that the agrarian technology of the Indus people did not know the plough.[9] The river bank, he thought, was cultivated with the harrow. Like those on the Nile and the Euphrates-Tigris, embankments on the Indus stored the flood-water for irrigation and retained the rich river-silt. Again, Kosambi squarely attributes the decline of the Indus civilization to the Aryans who destroyed the agricultural system by breaking the embankments which, he maintains, is symbolically referred to in the Rig Vedic descriptions of Indra destroying Vrtra and releasing the waters. Kosambi believes that the plough was brought by the Aryans who thereby changed agricultural technology. Romila Thapar points out however, that recent evidence on the Indus Valley makes it clear that plough agriculture was practised even in the pre-Harappan period. Indeed, the more commonly used word for the plough in Vedic literature is of non-Aryan etymology.

Aryan Conquest

Kosambi did not subscribe to the theory of an Aryan race,[10] but he did support the idea of an Aryan-speaking peoples settling in northwestern India and spreading gradually into the Ganga Valley, in both cases initially as conquerors. Superior technology in the form of iron tools and the horse seem to be responsible for the dominance of the Aryan speakers. The evidence of bilingualism suggests a long period of coexistence between the Aryans and the indigenous peoples. Kosambi makes an important point when he says that much of the Indian tradition from the earliest Vedic text is already an amalgam of Aryan and non-Aryan, even those of the highest caste. Plough agriculture and iron technology when introduced into the Ganga Valley led ultimately to the growth of urban centers as well as the recognizable forms of caste.

Rise of Jainism and Buddhism

The simultaneous rise of many religious sects in the Ganga Valley implied, for Kosambi, some social need that older

doctrines could not satisfy.[11] He analyzes this need by looking for the factors common to all the new religions. Factors such as technological changes, detribalization and urbanism constitute an economic interpretation of the rise of Buddhism and Jainism. The economic changes led to the rise of two classes in the Ganga Valley. The first was a class of land-owning peasants called *grihapatis* or heads of large patriarchal households; and the second was a class of wealthy traders called *shreshtis* meaning the most important persons in a guild or town. The rise of these propertied classes signified the institution of private property. The wealthy peasant and the wealthy trader desired peace above all. Peace could be established only by a universal monarchy seconded by a universal religion. Both Jainism and Buddhism tried to reach out to a wider social range and universal ethic. Since large numbers of cattle were required for
sacrifices without payment, the strain upon regular agriculture was intolerable. The sixth century religious reform drove sacrifice of cattle out of fashion and laid a taboo on cattle-killing and beef-eating. That was the economic basis of *ahimsa.* Kosambi argues forcefully that the patronage which the propertied class extended to Buddhism and Jainism rooted the new cults more deeply in society than did the help they received from royal patronage.

Assessment

In an assessment, Romila Thapar writes that the limitations of Kosambi's thought and analysis are marginal to the serious quality of his work. Kosambi presented a view of ancient Indian history which sought answers to the fundamental questions of how and why Indian society is what it is today. In attempting to provide answers to such questions he provided a theoretical framework which was not a mechanical application of Marxism. For example, he did not accept *in toto* the Marxian notion of the Asiatic Mode of Production in relation to the Indian past, and as for the feudal mode of production, he made his own qualifications so far as Indian history was concerned. Based as it was on dialectical materialsm, Kosambi's frame was hammered out of his proficiency in handling a variety of sources, and originality of thought. Fresh evidence may well lead to a reconsideration of his conclusions but his influence is bound to persist much longer.

2. R.S. Sharma (b. 1920)

A front-rank historian of post-independence India, Ram Sharan Sharma is a great scholar who effectively applied the Marxist method of analysis to historical research.

Sudras in Ancient India

Pivotal to any understanding of the nature of social relationships in India throughout its history is the inquiry into the caste—the *varna* system. Sharma's *Sudras in Ancient India* (1958) is a work in which his sympathy for the lower orders of society found early expression. Depending mainly on literary sources, it is a thoroughly scholarly work which examines the relationship of the lower social orders with the means of production and with higher orders from the Vedic age to the end of the Gupta period. The use of iron for large-scale field cultivation had, by the sixth century BC, transformed the tribal, pastoral and egalitarian pre-class Vedic society into a full-fledged class-divided social order. The new order required large labor power which was procured by force of arms and perpetuated by law and custom, religion and ideology—all interwoven into a social structure called the *varna* system.[12] The Sudra, as the *dharmasastras* were to ordain, was to serve the three higher *varnas*, while Manu would reduce him to slavery. The Indian helot was saddled with all kinds of disabilities – economic, politico-legal, social and religious – and was subjected to a kind of generalized slavery. Sharma writes that "...the *Sudra* skill, together with the agricultural surplus produced by the *Vaisya* peasants, provided the material basis for the development of ancient Indian society, which in this sense was a vaisya-sudra formation."[13] In the Gupta period (c. AD 300–600), the Sudras gained some religious and civic rights and in many respects were placed on a par with the Vaisyas. Many of the Sudras were now peasants with enlarged social and religious rights. Al-Biruni in the eleventh century found it difficult to distinguish the Vaisyas and Sudras. At the same time many Sudra artisans and tribals at lower stages of culture were made untouchables.

Indian Feudalism

Indian Feudalism (1966), was one of R.S. Sharma's books which immediately caught the attention of the academic world and generated debate. For Sharma the political essence of feudalism lay in the organization of the whole administrative structure on the basis of land tenure, and its economic content in the institution of serfdom in which peasants are attached to the soil held by landed intermediaries placed between the king and the actual tillers. Sharma discerns such a development in India in the land grants made to temples, Brahmanas and officials, and links it with the decay of towns, of trade and commerce and the reduced use of money. The process developed unevenly over the country from the Gupta times till about the twelfth century. There were several modes of extracting surplus—taxation, forced labor, the right of sub-in-feudation, and so on. Sharma's sources are the epigraphs of north India

which refer to feudal vassals of various ranks.

Urban Decay in India

R.S. Sharma's *Urban Decay in India* (1987) reinforces his arguments regarding the origin and growth of feudalism in India. He furnishes an impressive array of archeological evidence to demonstrate the decline of urban centers in early medieval India. The post-Mauryan period was remarkable for the growth of towns, handicrafts and trade. The towns reached the peak of prosperity during the period from c. 200 BC to AD 300. But after the third century AD urban centers began to decline, a process which continued throughout the Gupta period. An important cause of urban decay was the decline in long-distance trade, which in its turn is to be attributed to the end of the Han (China), Kushana, Parthian and the Satavahana empires, and to the internal dissensions in the Roman empire. A second phase of urban decay, though not as widespread as the first, appeared after the sixth century AD. It covered several important towns in the middle Gangetic plain. This second phase of decay is linked with the decline in the flourishing trade with Byzantium in spices and silk. Throughout the period of the urban decline a process of feudalization marked by large land grants was proceeding apace.

Material Culture and Social Formation in Ancient India

Sharma's *Material Culture and Social Formations in Ancient India* (1983) runs strictly along Marxist lines of historical analysis and interpretation. The book tells us of the transition of the pastoral economy of the Rig Vedic times into the far more developed economy of the later Vedic times (1000 BC to 500 BC) marked by large-scale agriculture, and the use of iron and painted grey ware (PGW). The process had so developed in the Ganga plain that as we come to the age of the Buddha we witness the use of northern black polished ware (NBP), the manufacture of wrought iron, the minting of coins, and wet paddy cultivation with the iron plough-share which doubled production. Change in material production brought with it political and social changes. The large surplus in agricultural production created conditions for the establishment of large rural settlements, growth of trade, use of metallic money, rise of towns, and emergence of large territorial states with a regular system of taxation, well-ordered administrative machinery, and a standing army. Large estates needed large number
of dependent laborers as wage earners, for which the *varna* system was created. Tribal society gradually disintegrated into class and occupational groupings. The progress of iron-plough agriculture depended on the augmentation of cattle wealth and hence the Buddhist stress on non-injury to animals. Again, Buddhist teachings recognized the reality of the new social order by favoring money- lending to facilitate trade and slave-keeping to augment agriculture.

Light on Early Indian Society and Economy

In *Light on Early Indian Society and Economy* (1966), Sharma writes on an assortment of subjects pertaining to the social and economic history of ancient India such as traces of promiscuity in ancient Indian society, joint notices of woman and property in the epics and *puranas*, slavery, caste, marriage, land grants, and usury.

R.S. Sharma's works, taken together, have outlined the social and economic history of ancient India.

3. Romila Thapar (b. 1930)

Romila Thapar's life is wholly devoted to creative research on early India in the reconstruction of whose history her contributions are certain to take a crucial place. She was Professor of Ancient Indian History at the Jawaharlal Nehru University where she had a decisive role in building the Centre for Historical Studies.

Asoka and the Decline of the Mauryas

Romila Thapar's brilliant scholarly career began with the publication of *Asoka and the Decline of the Mauryas* (1963). Reprinted several times, this work is in its essentials an original reinterpretation of the history of Asoka Maurya in which his policy of *Dhamma* is seen not as the moral effulgence of an idealistic monarch but as a political and social necessity. Asoka was confronted with a problem which only a statesman could solve. The conquest of Kalinga, induced by strategic and economic reasons, had taken the Mauryan empire to its subcontinental limits leaving only the southern Tamil tip which was only too submissive and friendly to invite imperial attention. The imposition of imperial control over the diverse ethnic and cultural elements of the empire and keeping it intact called for some binding factor. The policy of *Dhamma* with its emphasis on social responsibility was intended to provide this factor. It was Asoka's own invention. It was a way of life based on a high degree of social ethics and civic responsibility, a code of social behavior, least sectarian and highly moral.

As to the causes of the break up of the Mauryan empire, Thapar writes that the extremely centralized Mauryan administrative system depended for its proper functioning very much on the personal ability of the ruler. Asoka's death was the signal for the breakdown of the administration and the breaking away of the provinces. The breakdown could have been prevented even in the absence of rulers of exceptional ability by some kind of national

consciousness, i.e. the conception of the state as an idea above the king, the government and the social order, and as an entity demanding the loyalty of every citizen. This was simply not existent in Mauryan India.

History of India

Romila Thapar's *History of India,* Volume 1 (1966), is a work intended to reach out to a much wider audience at the popular level of historical understanding. Yet the book presents a view of history marking a departure from earlier works in aim and treatment. The new emphases are clear:

> Political histories and dynastic studies remain an important aspect of historical interpretation but these are viewed in the light of other features which go into the making of a people and a culture. Changes in the political pattern are inextricably entwined in changes in the economic structure and these in turn have a bearing on the social relationships....[14]

and, as it is to be understood, the emergent culture. Beginning with the culture of the Indo-Aryans one thousand five hundred years before Christ, the book takes the reader through three thousand years of the history of the subcontinent to the arrival of the Europeans in the sixteenth century. The aspects of Indian life it touches in a suggestive outline is comparable to the length of time it encompasses. Culture is viewed as rooted in and flowering from the material life of the people. The economic, religious, artistic and literary aspects are portrayed in their interrelation to each other within a framework of political history. Agriculture and industry, rural and urban life, and trade and maritime activity are given especial attention. A systematic study of Indian society through time, the book is a marvel of compression and yet thoroughly scholarly.

Ancient Indian Social History

Romila Thapar's *Ancient Indian Social History* (1978) treats of themes that relate to the study of ancient Indian social life from early times to the end of the first millennium AD. The first of the thirteen essays included in the work, 'Society and Law in the Hindu and Buddhist Traditions', is a kind of parallel, comparative study of Hindu and Buddhist socio-religious systems. The Hindu tradition was generally monarchical and authoritarian in politics and government, discriminatory in law, caste-ridden and inegalitarian in social relations, and inimical to human freedom and individual liberty. In comparison,

> The heterodox (Buddhist and Jain) tradition emphasized the equality of human beings, the equality of all before the law, disapproved of slavery, encouraged the acceptance of a higher status for women, and placed greater value on empirical thinking and education than on the formalism of the brahmanical system.[15]

The essay, 'Ethics, Religion and Social Protest in the First Millennium B.C. in Northern India', looks upon the ethics and religion of Buddhism as means of social protest also. Stress on non-violence, recruitment to the *sangha* from all groups including women, equality of status and compulsory community-living for the monks, and promotion of learning were challenges to the caste segregation, food taboos and educational monopoly of the Brahmanical order. 'Social Mobility in Ancient India with special Reference to Elite Groups', questions the assumption that society in India remained in a more or less frozen condition throughout the period from c. 1000 BC to c. AD 1000. The *varna* concept which was responsible for the assumption was largely a theoretical model and Thapar suggests that in terms of actual, if not in ritual, status there was mobility.

In her Presidential Address to the Ancient History Section of the Indian History Congress (Varanasi, 1969) she called for a reorientation of perspectives in the study of the social history of ancient India and made the following points: First, that archeological evidence does not suggest a massive Aryan invasion or migration; there was only a diffusion of the Indo-Aryan language by small groups of new comers who used iron and the horse.[16] Second, that the origin of caste is not to be seen as a result of the subjugation of the dark-skinned non-Aryans by the light-skinned Aryans, that the essential of caste society could have been present in the Harappan culture, and that on this question the historian must of necessity take the help of social anthropology.[17] And, third, the inclusion of a large amount of non-Aryan practice and belief in the religious aspects of later Vedic literature makes it unlikely that this literature was of purely Aryan composition.[18]

From Lineage to State

Thapar's *From Lineage to State* (1984) is a perceptive analysis of the process of state formation in the middle Ganga Valley in the first millennium BC. Earlier historians had taken the existence of the state for granted without troubling themselves to answer the fundamental question of how it came into existence. Thapar traces the origin of the state system in the Ganga Valley to the transition from a lineage mode of agrarian production to a peasant economy of private holdings and increasing urbanization. She treats Rig Vedic or pre-state society as 'lineage' and not 'tribal' since common ancestry was its binding factor. A lineage society would be mainly pastoral and mobile. A state, in contrast, is neither migratory nor based on lineage descent. It is impersonal. The prime factors towards such a move of state formation were the use of iron, the advance of plough agriculture, the rise of a class of *grihapatis* or

peasant proprietors, some of whom were so affluent as to turn over part of the agricultural surplus into trade and commerce and become *shreshtis* or rich merchants. The process led to the establishment of market towns, urbanization, use of coined money, banking and trade. This new society, as it were, called for a new organization to protect and promote its interests, one which the new agricultural and commercial surplus could sustain as taxes. Thus emerged states like Kosala and Magadha which were a far cry from the Kurus and Panchalas of the old lineage system. Among the requisites of the new state system was a treasury built on regular tax collection able to pay its officials and finance a professional standing army. Kinship slowly eroded giving way to impersonal and more formal political ties.

Interpreting Early India

In 'Ideology and the Interpretation of Early Indian History' (the first essay in *Interpreting Early India*, 1992), Romila Thapar challenged two main ideological trends in modern interpretations of early Indian history—the theory of the Aryan race and the notion of Oriental Despotism. Romila questioned the Aryan theory in the light of the evidence supplied by archeology, linguistics and social anthropology. In the same essay she questioned the notion of 'Oriental Despotism' which Western writers had treated as axiomatic in their understanding of India's past. Central to this notion was the unchanging nature of that past. With its emphasis on a static society and absence of change, Karl Marx "worked the theory into his model for Asian Society—that of the Asiatic Mode of Production."[19] The theory had as its main planks absence of private property in land, state monopoly of the irrigation system, absence of urban centers and an effective network of trade, self-sufficient villages at the base, and a despotic king at the apex. Against this Thapar points out that the *Dhamasastras* and the *Arthasastra* list and discuss the laws and regulations for the sale, bequest and inheritance of land and other forms of private property, and the many inscriptions after AD 500 give more precise information relating to private property in land. Archeology has thrown up evidence of the existence of urban centers from the Harappan period onwards, and the details of urban society occurring in the early Pali Buddhist texts and in works like the *Kamasutra* are other striking refutations of the notion of Oriental Despotism. Cities and urban life had as their economic base trade and commerce marked by an extensive use of coins, letters of credit and promissory notes which incidentally testify to a measure of literacy.

Romila Thapar's work in the field of ancient Indian history has immensely widened the historical horizon.

4. Bipan Chandra

Bipan Chandra is another prominent member of the Marxist school of Indian historians.

The Rise and Growth of Economic Nationalism

Chandra's *The Rise and Growth of Economic Nationalism* examines the economic policies of the Indian National Movement before the *swadeshi* agitation carried it to a higher and different plane. Perhaps slightly deviating from the Marxist line of approach and subscribing to what may be called a realist conception of history, Bipan Chandra treats ideas, though secondary to economic forces, as the direct agents of historical evolution.[20] Subscribing to the Marxist position that social relations exist independently of the ideas men form of them, Chandra however holds that "men's understanding of these relations is crucial to their social and political action."[21] This emphasis on ideas leads him to include a wide range of fora – the National Congress, the legislative bodies, the speeches and writings of nationalist leaders, newspapers and journals – as voicing nationalist opposition to British economic imperialism. But he is, however, clear as to the basic capitalist outlook of the Indian national leaders. He writes that "In nearly every aspect of economic life they championed capitalist growth in general and the interests of the industrial capitalists in particular."[22]

Nationalism and Colonialism in India

In his later work, *Nationalism and Colonialism in India*, Bipan says that the independent capitalist class that developed in India after 1857, particularly after 1914, did not develop an organic link with British or other foreign capitalism and it did not become an ally of British rule in India. Indian capitalism was that of a colony with a colonially subordinated and structured economy.

India's Struggle for Independence 1857–1947

In *India's Struggle for Independence 1857–1947* which Bipan Chanda edited and to which he contributed, the authors differed widely from both the imperialist approach of the Cambridge school and that of the Indian nationalist school to the nature of the Indian national struggle. Bipan Chandra assails the Cambridge school's
argument that the Indian national movement was not a people's movement but a product of the needs and interests of the elite groups. The nationalist school of historians, though showing awareness of the exploitative nature of colonialism, however ascribe the nationalist movement itself to the spread of the ideas of nationalism and liberty.

Bipan Chandra writes that unlike the Imperialist School, the Marxist historians clearly see the primary contradictions, as well as the process of the nation-in-the making, and unlike the nationalists, they also take a full note of the inner contradictions of Indian society.[23]

Yet, he adds that the Marxist writers, and Palme Dutt in particular, "tend to see the (national) movement as a structured bourgeois movement...and miss its open-ended and all class character."[24]

Communalism in Modern India

In *Communalism in Modern India* Bipan Chandra denies that the phenomenon of communalism was a mere historical accident or product of dialectical conspiracy.[25] The growth of communalism owed to a multiplicity of forces or causes. He accepts the Marxist thesis that communalism was one of the by-products of colonialism. He writes of the middle-class or petty bourgeois base of communalism under conditions of relative economic stagnation."[26] Communal politics, he says, is marked by the struggle for individual positions and posts. Communalism often distorted or misrepresented social tension and class conflict into communal conflict. Communalism, he concludes, is an extreme form of reaction to be fought on all fronts and given no quarter. The analysis of communalism in *India's Struggle for Independence*: *1857–1947* is more scientific.[27] Communalism, according to Bipan Chandra, remained liberal from 1857 to 1937. But from 1937 it assumed a virulent, extremist or fascist form, based on the politics of hatred, fear psychosis and irrationality. During 1937–47, with the youth and the peasants turning Left, the national movement was radicalized. When the Second World War broke out and the Congress demanded an assurance of complete independence after the war, the British relied entirely on the communal card and recognized the Muslim League as the sole advocate of the Muslims.

5. Irfan Habib (b. 1931)

One of the distinguished historians of the post-independence era, Irfan Muhammad Habib had his initial academic training under the fostering care of his historian father, Muhammad Habib. Habib's contribution to Indian historiography is remarkable in its variety and range.

Interpreting Indian History

Habib's *Interpreting Indian History* underlines the need for explanation and interpretation in historical reconstruction. He thinks that it is interpretation rather than narration that goes to make a historian. To comprehend questions of how and why, one should interpret history. The need for interpretation arises from the fact that the historian in treating events of the past cannot recreate and verify those events. Particularly, the evidence for earlier times is so little as to leave wide blanks. Such blanks could be filled up only by an understanding of how societies operate and what people are motivated by and capable of doing in various situations. Here the historian's personal judgement counts as much as his erudition.

In the same work, Habib examines the kind of'social formation' established after the Ghorian-Turkish conquest of northern India (1192–1206) on the basis of (a) the form of labor process, i.e., whether slavery, serfdom or wage labor; (b) the extraction of surplus value, i.e., rent, profit; and (c) the system of the distribution of surplus. Based on these categories he finds that in medieval India the labor process was that of petty producer laboring under various constraints; the surplus was extracted by tax which was identical with rent, and that it called for a centralized despotic state sustaining a vast parasitical urban economy. Our historian concludes that medieval Indian economy was a separate social formation different from the feudal economy.[28]

Caste and Money in Indian History

In another work, *Caste and Money in Indian History*, Irfan Habib tries to interpret Indian history in the light of the phenomenon of caste which, he writes, "still remains perhaps the one single most important divisive factor in our country."[29] A rigid form of division of labor, caste formed part of the relations of production. Habib thinks that the chief beneficiaries of this rigorous form of class exploitation were the ruling classes which in the medieval Indian context were the nobility and the *zamindars*.[30]

Problems of Marxist Historiography

In his *Problems of Marxist Historiography*, Irfan Habib observes that Marx has been ill served by some of his followers by their insistance on a rigid universal periodization into Primitive Communism, Slavery and Feudalism, and on a classification of all societies according to that pattern. Nor is it true that Marx held all thought to be just a reflex of the material world.

The Agrarian System of Mughal India

Irfan Habib's greatest work is the *Agrarian System of Mughal India.* The pivot of his thesis is that the principal

contradiction In the medieval Indian social formation lay between the centralized ruling class (the state) and the peasantry. This contradiction extended to the relations between the state and the *zamindars* also. This was because the basic motive force, so far as the state was concerned, was the drive for higher tax revenue. The pressure for higher collection of land revenue "devastated the country, antagonized *zamindars* whose own share of the surplus was thereby affected, and drove the peasants to rebellion."[31] Thus we come across in Mughal India the most widespread conflicts between the peasants and the revenue appropriating ruling class.[32] The Mughal state failed to provide any relief to the cultivating peasantry. There followed rapine, anarchy and foreign conquests to which the empire succumbed. The Mughal empire was "its own grave-digger".[33] In the *Agrarian System* Habib postulates the view that economic tyranny rather than religious reaction was the major cause of opposition to Aurangazeb. The *Agrarian System of Mughal India* clearly shows that the historian was disposed to view medieval north Indian society from the standpoint of the peasants rather than that of the government and the *zamindars.*

An Atlas of the Mughal Empire

Irfan Habib made distinctive contributions in a field which Indian historians had consistently neglected—historical cartography. His *An Atlas of the Mughal Empire* contains thirty-two pages of maps in addition to three maps in the introductory chapter and sixty-six pages of detailed notes. He has to his credit 'The Economic Map of India, AD 1–300', and has also made cartographic depictions of such themes as 'The Geography and Economy of the Indus Civilization' and 'The Mauryan Empire'.

The Cambridge Economic History of India

Habib's chosen field of inquiry is economic history. In *The Cambridge Economic History of India,* (Volume 1, 1200–1750) which he co-edited with Tapan Chaudhuri and to which he contributed, he discusses the agrarian economy in terms of agrarian production, rural classes, agrarian taxation, and the *iqta* system (forerunner of the *jagirdari).* He estimates the population of the Mughal empire in 1600 between 140 and 150 million, of which 85 per cent were rural and the rest urban.

What we see in Irfan Habib's writing is an urge to understand the common man, especially the peasant and his village in their political, social, economic and cultural settings. Of these the economic setting is central to his analysis.

6. The Marxist Phase of Indian Historiography: An Assessment

Kosambi worked out the general theory of historical development propounded by Marx and Engels into a method, and employed it creatively in the reconstruction of early Indian history. The increasing adoption of this method has wrought a change in Indian historiography that has assumed the proportions of a revolution. Analysis and explanation in terms of economic production and social classes have become basic tenets in historical reconstruction in India.

Broadening of the Scope of History

The Marxist trend has resulted in a major shift of emphasis and has broadened the scope of history from the state to society, from soldiers and statesmen to the people, that is to say, from the political to the economic and social aspects of human life. Large sections of people, hitherto unnoticed, have become legitimate objects of historical inquiry. Works like R.S. Sharma's *Sudras in Ancient India* and Irfan Habib's *The Agarian System of Mughal India* are instances in point. The new paradigm has thrown dynastic history out of fashion and reduced political history itself to the level of a framework, a backdrop, for economic and social history. Idealist and romantic treatment of the past has given way to a search for the economic and social factors of human life—the objective forces of material production and the resultant social relations. The concern with individual roles or with individual achievements or failures is disappearing from history, and with it, much of value judgements, too.

Interdisciplinary Methods

The materialist orientation of history has resulted in the use mostly of primary sources. To study such sources historians try to call to their aid such skills as those of the linguist, sociologist, anthropologist and the statistician. Though the interdisciplinary method has not been attempted in any big way, the data supplied by specialists in the various disciplines have been used extensively in historical reconstruction. Historians now try to integrate literary and archeological evidence wherever possible. The search for material forces of production – pivotal to Marxist historical methodology – has increasingly turned their attention in the direction of archeological evidence, particularly in the study of ancient Indian history. Unlike literary sources, the physical remains of the past are completely free from bias and constitute direct, immediate and tangible evidence allowing a more accurate

reconstruction of the past. In the reconstruction of the history of the later Vedic age, the Marxist historians have liberally used archeological evidence (PGW, NBP, etc) along with their reading of the later Vedic texts. A concern with urbanization as centers of production and circulation of wealth is common to Kosambi, Sharma and Thapar who have labored to reconstruct the early history of India. Sharma's *Urban Decay in India* is a work almost entirely based on archeological evidence.

Accounts of Origin

Marxist historiography has been particularly strong in explaining the origins of human institutions. Accounts of state formation in the Ganga Valley by Kosambi, Sharma and Thapar mark a radical advance in historical understanding and should be reckoned a triumph of materialist historiography. The origin and development of caste, that most characteristic institution of the Hindu social order, still awaits a more satisfactory explanation. Oversimplified and readymade explanations will not do. Indeed, Romila Thapar exhorted historians at the Indian History Congress at Varanasi (1969) not to see that complex institution of caste simply as a distinction between light-skinned Aryans and dark non-Aryans but to take the help of social anthropology in the study of its origin and development. No human institution miraculously leaps into existence, and in history there cannot be any other activity and institution than what is human.

Defence of Explanation and Interpretation

The Marxist model has made history writing in India far less narrative and descriptive and more explanatory and interpretative. The change from one to the other has been a conscious exercise in which processes and large movements, not events (as they are understood), assume importance. Some have held that it is interpretation that makes the historian. Irfan Habib's *Interpreting Indian History* contains a theoretical defence of the historian s freedom of interpretaiton.[34] In all interpretation, ideology of some kind plays the leading role. It is through an emphasis on the interpretative aspect of history that the Marxist view has had its impact on Indian historiography.

Critique of Western Understanding

The nationalist historians had questioned some of the oft-quoted cliches current in British imperialist and European writing on Indian history. Continuing that tradition, as it were, the Marxist historians have challenged certain concepts which were axiomatic in the foreigner's understanding of India's past. D.D. Kosambi refused to accept *in toto* the concept of the Asiatic Mode of Production as applicable to Indian history. Marxist historians have in general taken pains to show the existence from the sixth century BC of extensive urban centers and brisk commercial activity down to the Gupta times. R.S. Sharma and Romila Thapar have drawn attention to the prevalence of comparative social mobility, both occupational and territorial, in ancient India. The theory of the Aryan race and the concept of Oriental Despotism have been criticized by Romila Thapar. She has shown the pervasive influence of such misconceptions, as well as of others like 'the unchanging character of Indian society' and 'an arrested state of development' even in the works of leading European sociologists like Durkheim and Weber.

Differences in Conclusions

Historical explanation based on the mode of production and changes therein need not always lead to identical results. Perhaps, unavoidably, some conclusions could only be distant approximations or even pure guesses. Kosambi assumed that the Harappans did not know the plough and that the banks of the Indus were cultivated with the harrow. We may protest that raising dykes and embankments to collect the flood-waters of a great river and producing agricultural surpluses sufficient to feed an entire urban population are operations that argue for explanations based on more developed tools than the surface-scratching harrow. Or, grain must have been imported. Romila Thapar has in fact argued that recent evidence makes it clear that plough agriculture was known to the pre-Aryans and was practised even in the pre-Harappan period since the more commonly used word for the plough in Vedic literature is of non-Aryan etymology.[35] Sharma and Thapar seem to differ to the extent of contradicting each other as regards the attitude of Buddhism to slavery. The former avers that the new religion recognized the reality of the new social order of the sixth century BC by favoring money-lending to facilitate trade and slave-keeping to augment agriculture,[36] but the latter asserts that Buddhism disapproved of slavery.[37]

Economics of Ashimsa

Kosambi and, following him Sharma and others, offer an economic interpretation of the principle of *ahimsa* enjoined by Buddhism and Jainism. The large-scale slaughter of cattle prescribed by the Vedic rituals was an intolerable strain on the new iron-plough agriculture in the Ganga basin which depended on the preservation and augmentation of cattle wealth. Kosambi writes that "Cattle and other animals were requisitioned in increasing number for the *yajna* without payment. This is shown by Pali stories of royal fire sacrifices. The strain upon regular

agriculture was intolerable."[38] Buddhist and Jain reform in the sixth century BC completely drove this Brahmanical practice out of fashion by laying a taboo on cattle-killing and beef-eating.

It is difficult to believe, unless supported by quantitative evidence, that cattle were slaughtered at royal sacrifices on such a scale as to decimate the bovine population and to endanger the new iron-plough agriculture. Were the royal sacrificers and those about them so thoughtless and shortsighted as to kill productive animals? The "slaughter of more and more animals at a growing number of sacrifices"[39] would have added up, from time to time, to forbidding quantities of sacrificed meat (the gods to do not eat!), the difficulty of preserving which would have required countless mouths to consume such enormities of beef before it rotted. A more precise citation of the Pali stories instead of an easy saunter around them would have clarified the point. Such evidence should indicate, in the interests of quantitative objectivity, the incidence of royal sacrifices during a given period, say a year, in a given area and the probable (if not precise) number of cattle killed at each such sacrifice. A mathematician like Kosambi should not have neglected the importance of quantities in historical analysis. It is equally unbelievable that the sixth-century reform could have so easily stopped the ritual cattle-killing of the Brahmanists whose hostility to the reformers is only too well known. "The main Vedic sacrifice," writes Kosambi, "was of cattle, natural in a predominantly pastoral society. How completely the sixth-century reform drove this, too, out of fashion is seen by the absolute Hindu tabu upon cattle killing and beef-eating which is still in force...."[40]

A passage in the *Suttanipata* ascribed to the Buddha and quoted by Kosambi reads: "Cattle are our friends, just like parents and other relatives, for cultivation depends upon them. They give food, strength, freshness of complexion and happiness. *Knowing this brahmins of old did not kill cattle*."[41] (Emphasis added.)

If Brahmans of old did not kill cattle, where, then, was the need for a Jain and Buddhist taboo on cattle-killing? At any rate the Brahmanists could scarcely be believed to have respected a Jain or Buddhist prohibition.

Freedom of Interpretation

Historians of a Marxist persuasion generally concentrate more on the interpretation of events than on their narration. In his *Interpreting Indian History*, Irfan Habib stresses its need and importance. None acquainted with the nature of history will ever doubt the need for interpretation and the historian's freedom thereof. That this freedom should not get beyond the factual basis of history needs to be stressed. The historian should interpret and amplify the facts for the benefit of the reader and not confuse him with a parade of abstruse terms and jargons. The latter course is a temptation which comes when the historian looks for the vanguardism of theory and its vocabulary. Romila Thapar is admirably free from such temptation. But the same cannot be said of some others. Thus Bipan Chandra:

> However, many of them—and Palme Dutt in particular—are. not able to fully integrate their treatment of the primary anti-imperialist contradiction and the secondary inner contradictions, and tend to counterpose the anti-imperialist struggle to the class struggle or social struggle. They also tend to see the movement as a structured bourgeois movement, if not the bourgeoisie's movement, and miss its open-ended and all class character.[42]

And Irfan Habib:

> The principal contradictions lay between the centralised ruling class (state) and the peasantry; but there were contradictions too between the state and the *zamindars* which often induced the *zamindars* to use peasants as allies or as canon-fodder in their conflict with state. There were potential contradictions between the menial proletariat and the rest of society, and on the fringes there was a visible conflict between the tribes and advancing caste peasantry. Still more secondary were the contradictions between artisans and town-labour, on the one hand, and the state, on the other.[43]

Perhaps the writers could have better served the interests of the readers than by such exercises in obscurity. Defending the Communist stand on the 'Quit India' movement of 1942, Habib asks: "If Fascist Germany had triumphed, where would the

world-working class movement have been today"?[44] Such expressions can hardly serve as explanations.

II. SUBALTERN STUDIES

A Historiography of Protest

A series titled *Subaltern Studies*, appearing in the last two decades of the twentieth century, has introduced an almost new genre of history writing on modern India. Editing the first of the series Ranajit Guha protests that the historiography of Indian nationalism is beset with a prejudiced elitism of two kinds, both sharing the view that the development of the national consciousness and the making of the Indian nation were elite achievements. The first of these – colonial or British imperialist historiography – based on a narrow behavioristic approach, looks upon Indian nationalism as the response of the Indian bourgeois elite to the stimulus provided by British ideas, institutions, opportunities and resources. The second kind – Indian nationalist historiography – on the other hand, pictures Indian nationalism as primarily an idealist venture in which the indigenous elite led the people from subjection to freedom. Neither of these two views can explain Indian nationalism because neither acknowledges the contribution made by the people *on their own*, that is, *independently of the elite*, to the making and development of that nationalism. For

this reason, according to Guha, elitist historiography cannot explain such instances of popular initiative asserting itself as the anti-Rowlatt upsurge of 1919 or the 'Quit India' movement of 1942.[45] Guha asserts that parallel to elite politics, there was a domain of people's politics in which the principal actors were the subaltern classes and groups constituting the mass of the population. He feels that elitist historiography which does not recognize this fact should be resolutely fought by developing an alternative discourse based on the recognition of the subaltern domains of politics. That is the *raison d' etre* of subaltern historiography.

Nature of Subaltern Historiography

The *Subaltern Studies* are collections of monographs on diverse, unconnected topics. Their one theme is the insurgency of the lower classes. Subaltern, a term taken from Antonio Gramsci's manuscript writings, means 'of inferior rank' whether of class, caste, age, gender or office. *Subaltern Studies* bring to light the lower sections of the Indian people hitherto neglected by historiography. They are "addressed to a range of topics extending in time from the Mughal period to the nineteen seventies, in theme from communalism to industrial labour, and in manner from the descriptive to the conceptual."[46]

A distinctive feature of subaltern activity being its labor orientation, the *Subaltern Studies* are Marxian in tone, premise (categories) and analysis. The peasant, the factory worker and the tribal – their woes and accumulated grievances breaking out at times in rebellions against constituted authority – become objects of subaltern historiographical treatment. Revolt was the means, the method, by which the lower classes tried to improve their conditions and force themselves on the attention of the elite in colonial India. Guha affirms that the peasant never stumbled or drifted into rebellion. He rebelled consciously and only when he found that his pleadings of various kinds had failed. Insurgency, whether of the worker in the factory, villagers of the plains or of the *adivasis* of the uplands, was a deliberate, desperate way out of an intolerable condition of existence created by wicked landlords, extortionate usurers, dishonest traders, venal police, irresponsible officials and partisan processes of law. Hence revolts and their impact on Indian nationalism form staple theme for the historians of the subaltern genre. Moreover, subaltern consciousness together with the elements of that consciousness – religion, superstition, communalism, and the view that subject classes took of the elites – becomes an object of historical study.

Some Examples of Subaltern Historiography

Close to ten *Subaltern Studies* (SS) volumes have so far appeared. A perusal of the more important titles in the first four collections of the series will give an idea of the historiography that has appeared under that label.

David Arnold brings to light the story of a long series of disturbances and rebellions of hillmen in the Gudem and Rampa hill tracts of Andhra during 1839–1924 (SS 1). Studying the Madras famine of 1876–78 (SS 3), the same author writes of

peasant consciousness and peasant action in such crises of subsistence and survival. Arnold complains that the voluminous literature on Indian famine does not treat that phenomenon in terms of human experience, and that peasant experience of dearth and famine has almost invariably been subordinated to the descriptions of state policy and relief administration.

Gyan Pandey gives an account of the peasant revolts of Awadh during 1919–22 and its impact on Indian nationalism (SS 1). Stephen Henningham shows how in Bihar and eastern Uttar Pradesh the 'Quit India' movement of 1942 was a dual revolt consisting of an elite nationalist uprising combined with a subaltern rebellion (SS 2). This combination called forth the enthusiasm and participation of a broad spectrum of society. If, in spite of its drama and intensity the 'Quit India' revolt has not received adequate scholarly treatment, Henningham's explanation is that, for historians operating within the confines of elite historiography "the substance of the 1942 revolt is difficult to swallow and impossible to digest."[47]

Aravind Das demonstrates how erroneous it is to attribute agrarian changes in Bihar during 1947–78 to elite-sponsored land reforms (SS 2). The two major attempts at 'agrarian changes from the above', that is, through *zamindari* abolition and the *bhoodan* movement, were not elite sponsored but responses to peasant discontent. The first followed after years of agitation by Swami Sahajananda Saraswati and the powerful Kisan Sabha, and the second came on the miliant Communist-led peasant upsurge in Telengana. Both were measures to preempt class war in the Bihar country side. Says the author: "Any interpretation of agrarian change primarily as an elite sponsored land reform, amounts therefore to chasing the shadow without trying to grasp the substance."[48]

In 'Agricultural Workers in Burdwan' (SS 2), N.K. Chandra reveals the appallingly poor conditions of the mass of the agricultural laborers and poor peasants in terms of wages and earnings, underemployment and poverty.

Dipesh Chakrabarty studies the condition of the Calcutta jute-mill workers between 1890 and 1940 (SS 2). In another essay on the jute-mill workers during 1920–50 (SS 3), Chakrabarty shows how the elitist attitude has crept

into socialist and Communist ranks, leaders treating unions as their ‘zamindari’, their contact with the workers degenerating into the hierarchical terms of babu–coolie relationship.

Shahid Amin in his essay on Gandhi (SS 3) is concerned to know how the Mahatma’s charisma got itself registered in peasant consciousness. He finds that an important element in that charisma was the peasant’s belief in superstition and miracles. David Hardiman’s essay on the Devi reformist movement among the tribals of south Gujarat (SS 3) affords insights into tribal consciousness and must arrest the attention of the sociologists.

The anti-Partition agitation (1905) did not arouse as much popular enthusiasm in Bengal as did the Non-Cooperation Khilafat movement of 1921–22. Sumit Sarkar informs us (SS 3) that the former did not go beyond the confines of Hindu upper class *bhadralok* groups whereas in the latter “popular initiative eventually alarmed the leaders into calling for a halt.”[49]

Ramachandra Guha’s essay, ‘Forestry and Social Protest in British Kumaun, c. 1893–1921’ (SS 4) shows that the Chipko Andolan Movement starting from 1973 in Kumaun against the commercial exploitation of forests has in fact a history beginning from the nineties of the nineteenth century and lasting into the twenties of the twentieth. The reservation of the Kumaun forests in 1911–17 met with violent and sustained opposition from the traditionally ‘simple and law abiding hillmen’ which culminated in the revolt of 1921 when within the space of a few months the whole administration was paralyzed, first by a strike against statutory labor and then through a systematic campaign in which the Himalayan pine forests were swept by incendiary fires almost from end to end.

Tribal protest as that of Jitu Santhal’s movement in Malda, northwestern Bengal (1924–32), is a favourite theme for subaltern historiography (SS 4). In 1924, an anti-landlord tenant agitation developed in Malda under Jitu’s leadership and continued till 1932 when the leader was shot. Even *bhadralok* opinion as expressed in the *Amrita Bazar Patrika* was sympathetic to Jitu’s revolt but, as Tanika Sarkar shows, in true elitist fashion the responsibility for the revolt was taken away from the tribal leader by imputing it comfortably to the Swarajist agitator from outside.

Gautam Bhadra observes in his ‘Four Rebels of 1857’ (SS 4) that all the principal modes of historiography on the Great Revolt of 1857 whether ‘nationalist’ as exemplified by the writings of S.B. Chaudhari or ‘radical communist’ as represented by Promod Sengupta and Datta have, with due elitist prejudice, portrayed the great event as an elitist venture. The ordinary rebel, his role and his perception of alien rule and the contemporary crisis—all these have been left out of the historical literature of the Great Revolt. Bhadra’s essay rehabilitates four of such rebel characters of 1857: Shah Mai, Devi Singh, Gonoo and Maulvi Ahmadullah Shah. Their stories point to the existence in 1857 of what Gramsci calls ‘multiple elements of conscious leadership’.

Assessment

Fine examples of radical scholarship, Marxist and subaltern historiography are bringing historical inquiry to the foundations of Indian society. In its anxiety to highlight the struggles of the workers, the peasants and the tribals, the latter has upset not only conventional historiography but even that of a Marxist perspective. Subaltern historiography essentially belongs to the category of sub-history or local narratives supplementing and enriching mainstream historical accounts and filling up the lacunae in them. Based on a loose, negative elite-subaltern dichotomy, it has no greater theme than popular militancy and consciousness. Its topics are grimly partitioned with no connection or sequence of any kind. A continuous and sustained narrative is outside its purview. Yet, its positive side should not be lost sight of—subaltern historiography is ferreting out innumerable records from their dusty shelves in dark and dingy rooms which stand witness to many a story of faith and struggle. It has reopened for historical examination questions long believed to have been settled. It has restored individual human beings and groups hitherto considered too low for elite historical treatment. These dissevered limbs of subaltern historiography – these sagas of struggle – could be brought together and in many cases woven into mainstream historiography and thereby enrich it.

92 *Ibid.*, 160.

93 Sarkar, *Studies in Mughal India* 240–41.

94 Sarkar, 'Personal History of some Medieval Historians', 191.

95 *Ibid.*, 192.

96 See Majumdar, *Historiography in Modern India*, 6–7.

97 Sathianathier, *History of India*, Vol. 2, 384.

98 Rashid, 'Treatment of History by Muslim Historians', 141.

99 Sarkar, 'Personal History of some Medieval Historians', 183.

100 Rashid, 'Treatment of History by Muslim Historians', 150–51.

101 Sarkar, 'Personal History of some Medieval Historians', 184.

102 *Ibid*.

103 *Ibid*., 186.

104 For details see Mukhia, *Historians and Historiography*, 170–176.

CHAPTER 14

1 Majumdar, *Historiography in Modern India*, 9–10.

2 *Ibid.*, 8.

3 Kosambi, *Introduction to the Study of Indian History*, 6.

4 Majumdar, *Historiography of Modern India*, 20–21.

5 *Ibid.*, 23.

6 Allchin, 'Ideas of History in Indian Archaeological Writing: A Preliminary Study,' in Philips, ed., *Historians of India, Pakistan and Ceylon*, 246.

7 *Ibid*.

8 *Ibid.*, 246–47.

9 MacDonnell, *A History of Sanskrit Literature*, 1.

10 Thapar, *Intrepreting Early India*, 81–82.

11 Mukherjee, Sir William Jones: *A Study in Eighteenth Century British Attitudes to India*, 95.

12 *Ibid.*, 117–19.

13 Philips, *Historians of India, Pakistan and Ceylon*, 218.

14 *Ibid.*, 219.

15 *Ibid*.

16 Majumdar, *Historiography of Modern India*, 11.

17 Philips, *Historians of India, Pakistan and Ceylon*, 221.

18 *Ibid.*, 220.

19 Majumdar, *Historiography of Modern India*, 12.

20 *Ibid.*, 12-13.

21 *Ibid.*, 13.

22 *Ibid*.

[23] *Ibid*.

[24] *Ibid.*, 13-14.

[25] *Ibid.*, 14.

[26] Philips, *Historians of India, Pakistan and Ceylon*, 225.

[27] *Ibid.*, 226.

[28] Elliot, *History of India as Told by its own Historians* Vol. 1, xxii.

[29] Philips, *Historians of India, Pakistan and Ceylon*, 227.

[30] Joll, *Europe Since* 1870, 104.

[31] Furber, 'The Theme of Imperialism in Modern Historical Writings on India', in Philips, ed., *Historians of India, Pakistan and Ceylon*, 341.

[32] *Ibid.*, 339–40.

[33] Stokes, 'The Administrators and Historical Writings on India', in Philips, ed., *Historians of India, Pakistan and Ceylon*, 386.

[34] *Ibid*., 393.

[35] *Ibid*.

[36] *Ibid*.

[37] *Ibid.*, 395.

[38] *Ibid*.

[39] *Ibid.*, 396.

[40] *Ibid*.

[41] *Ibid.*,397.

[42] *Ibid.*, 399.

[43] *Ibid.*, 394.

[44] *Ibid.*, 402.

[45] *Ibid.*,402–403.

[46] *Ibid.*, 403.

[47] Smith, *Early History of India*, 4.

[48] Basham 'Modern Historians of Ancient India', in Philips, ed., *Historians of India, Pakistan and Ceylon.*, 269.

[49] *Ibid.*, 270.

[50] *Ibid.*, 269.

[51] Majumdar, *Historiography in Modern India*, 42.

[52] Philips, *Historians of India, Pakistan and Ceylon*, 252.

[53] Majumdar, *Historians in Modern India*, 41–43.

[54] Philips, *Historians of India, Pakistan and Ceylon*., 271.

[55] Smith, *Oxford History of India*, ix–x.

[56] Philips, *Historians of India, Pakistan and Ceylon*, 274.

[57] Harrison, 'Notes on W.H. Moreland as Historian', in Philips, ed., *Historians of India, Pakistan and Ceylon*, 316.

[58] *Ibid.*

[59] *Ibid*., 316.

[60] *Ibid.*, 314.

[61] *Ibid.*, 315.

[62] *Ibid.*, 317–18.

[63] Thapar, *Ancient Indian Social History*, 6–7.

[64] *Ibid.*, 6.

[65] Philips, *Historians of India, Pakistan and Ceylon*, 409.

[66] Stokes 'The Administrators and Historical Writings on India', in Philips, ed., *Historians of India, Pakistan and Ceylon*, 393.

CHAPTER 15

[1] Clark, 'The Role of Bankim Chandra in the Development of Nationalism', in Philips, ed., *Historians of India, Pakistan and Ceylon*, 436.

[2] Majumdar, 'Nationalist Historians', in Philips, ed., *Historians of India, Pakistan and Ceylon*, 418.

[3] *Ibid*., 418.

[4] *Ibid*.

[5] *Ibid.*, 419

[6] *Ibid*.

[7] *Ibid*., 419–20

[8] *Ibid*., 417

[9] *Ibid*., 421–422 .

[10] *Ibid*., 422–423

[11] *Ibid*., 424

[12] *Ibid*., 425

[13] *Ibid*.

[14] Basham, 'Modern Historians of Ancient India', in Philips, ed., *Historians of India, Pakistan and Ceylon*, 283.

[15] Thapar, *Ancient Indian Social History*, 12.

[16] *Ibid*., 14.

[17] *Ibid*., 16.

[18] Panikkar, *A Survey of Indian History*, viii.

[19] Pusalkar, 'R.G. Bhandarkar', in Sen, ed., *Historians and Historiography in Modern India*, 30.

[20] Basham, 'Modern Historians of Ancient India', 281.

[21] Pusalkar, 'R.G. Bhandarkar', 28.

[22] Sen, 'Romesh Chandra Dutt', in Sen, ed., *Historians and Historiography in Modern India*, 322.

[23] *Ibid*.

[24] *Ibid.*, 324.

[25] Sinha, 'Kashi Prasad Jayaswal', in Sen, ed., *Historians and Historiography in Modern India*, 91.

[26] *Ibid.*, 92.

[27] *Ibid.*, 77–94.

[28] Srivastava, ‘Radha Kumud Mukherji’, in Sen, ed., *Historians and Historiography in Modern India*, 77.

[29] Basham, ‘Modern Historians of Ancient India’, 284.

[30] Majumdar, ‘Hem Chandra Raychaudhuri,’ in Sen, ed., *Historians and Historiography in Modern India*, 98.

[31] Basham, ‘Modern Historians of Ancient India’, 284–85.

[32] Rao, ‘Govind Sakharam Sardesi’, in Sen, ed., *Historians and Historiography in Modern India*, 225.

[33] *Ibid*., 227–29.

[34] Srivastava, ‘Sir Jadunath Sarkar’, in Sen, ed., *Historians and Historiography in Modern India*, 137.

[35] *Ibid*., 139.

[36] *Ibid*., 138–39.

[37] See Majumdar, *Historiography in Modern India*, 56.

[38] Srivastava, ‘Sir Jadunath Sarkar’, 141–42.

[39] *Ibid*., 142.

[40] Dikshit, ‘S. Krishnaswami Aiyangar’, in Sen, ed., *Historians and Historiography in Modern India*, 65–66.

[41] Prasad, ‘Sir Shafaat Ahmad Khan’, in Sen, ed., *Historians and Historiography in Modern India*, 147.

[42] *Ibid*., 150.

[43] *Ibid*., 151–52.

[44] *Ibid*., 155–56.

[45] For details see Hardy, ‘Modern Muslim Historical Writing’, 294–97.

[46] *Ibid*., 298.

[47] *Ibid*. 299.

[48] *Ibid*.

[49] *Ibid*., 300.

[50] *Ibid*., 300–01.

[51] *Ibid.*, 301.

[52] *Ibid*.

[53] *Ibid.*, 302.

[54] *Ibid*.

[55] *Ibid.*, 302.

[56] *Ibid.*, 302–03.

[57] *Ibid.*, 303.

[58] *Ibid.*, 305.

[59] *Ibid.*, 304.

[60] See *Ibid*., 305.

[61] Philips, *Historians of India, Pakistan and Ceylon*, 305.

[62] Hardy, ‘Modern Muslim Historical Writing’, 307.

[63] *Ibid.*, 308.

64 *Ibid*., 299.

65 *Ibid*., 309.

66 Banerji, 'Dr. Surendranath Sen', in Sen, ed., *Historians and Historiography in Modern India*, 354.

67 *Ibid.*, 356.

68 Banerjee, 'Sardar K.M. Panikkar', in Sen, ed., *Historians and Historiography in Modern India*, 330.

69 *Ibid.*, 340.

70 *Ibid.*, 340–41.

71 *Ibid*., 341.

72 Panikkar, *Survey of Indian History*, 23.

73 *Ibid.*, 237–38.

74 *Ibid.*, 127–28.

75 Sastri, *History of South India*, 11.

76 *Ibid.*, 11–12.

77 *Ibid.*, 2.

78 *Ibid.*, 2.

79 *Ibid.*, 1.

80 Thapar, *Ancient Indian Social History*, 16.

81 *Ibid.*, 16.

82 Sarkar, 'R.C. Majumdar and his work on South and South East Asia: A Panoramic Review', *The Journal of Indian History*, Diamond Jubilee Volume, 1982, Part 1, 316.

83 *Ibid.*, 311.

84 *Ibid*.

85 *Ibid.*, 323.

86 Majumdar, *History and Culture of the Indian People*, Vol. 4, 615–18.

87 Majumdar, 'Indian Historiography: Some Present Trends', in Sen, ed., *Historians and Historiography in Modern India*, xxiii.

CHAPTER 16

1 Thapar, *Ancient Indian Social History*, 16–17.

2 Kosambi, *Introduction to the Study of Ancient Indian History*, 6.

3 *Ibid.*, 1.

4 *Ibid.*, 7.

5 See Thapar, '*The Contribution of D.D. Kosambi to Indology*', in *Interpreting Early India*, 94.

6 *Ibid.*, 96

7 *Ibid.*, 98.

8 *Ibid.*, 98–99.

9 *Ibid.*, 101–02.

10 *Ibid.*, 102.

11 See Kosambi, *Culture and Civilization in Ancient India in Historical Outline*, 96–132.

[12] Sharma, *Sudras in Ancient India*, 315.

[13] *Ibid.*, 318.

[14] Thapar, *History of India*, Vol. 1, 22.

[15] Thapar, 'Society and Law in the Hindu and Buddhist Traditions', in *Ancient Indian Social History*, 34.

[16] *Ibid.*, 215.

[17] *Ibid*., 220.

[18] *Ibid.*, 221.

[19] Thapar, 'Ideology and Interpretation of Early Indian History', in *Interpreting Early India*, 7.

[20] Singh, 'Bipan Chandra', in Sharma et. al., ed., *Historiography and Historians in India since Independence*, 216.

[21] *Ibid.*, 216.

[22] *Ibid.*, 217.

[23] *Ibid.*, 219.

[24] *Ibid.*, 219–20.

[25] *Ibid.*, 223.

[26] *Ibid.*, 224.

[27] *Ibid*.

[28] Varma, 'Irfan Habib', in Sharma et. al., ed., *Historiography and Historians since Independence*, 236–37.

[29] *Ibid.*, 234.

[30] *Ibid.*, 233.

[31] *Ibid., 237.*

[32] *Ibid.*

[33] *Ibid.*, 239.

[34] *Ibid*., 230–31.

[35] See Thapar, *Interpreting Early India*, 101–102.

[36] Sharma, *Material Culture and Social Formation in Ancient India*, 165.

[37] Thapar, *Ancient Indian Social History*, 34.

[38] Kosambi, *Culture and Civilization in Ancient India*, 101–02.

[39] Kosambi, *Introduction to the Study of Indian History*, 166.

[40] Kosambi, *Culture and Civilization in Ancient India*, 102.

[41] *Ibid.*, 103.

[42] Bipan Chandra, ed., *India's Struggle for Independence*, 22.

[43] Sharma, 'Irban Habib', 237.

[44] *Ibid.*, 240.

[45] Guha, *Subaltern Studies*, Vol. 1, 3.

[46] Guha, Preface to *Subaltern Studies*, Vol. 2.

[47] Henningham, 'Quit India in Bihar and the Eastern United Provinces: the Dual Revolt', in Guha, ed., *Subaltern Studies*, Vol. 2, 136.

[48] Das, ‘Agrarian Change from Above and Below: Bihar, 1947–78’, in Guha, ed., *Subaltern Studies*, Vol. 2, 227.

[49] Sarkar, ‘The Conditions and Nature of Subaltern Militancy: Bengal from Swadeshi to Non Co-operation, c. 1905–22’, in Guha, ed., *Subaltern Studies*, Vol. 3, 271–72.

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